

Śrī Śrī Mukta Caritram

The Great Pearl Escapade

Śrīla Raghunāthadāsa Gosvāmin



Invocation

Namaḥ Śrī Gāndharvā-Gīridharābhyaṁ

To he who is more attractive than
tens of millions of Cupids,
whose bodily lustre resembles that
of a blue lotus in full bloom,
and whose pastimes have completely enchanted
the world of animate and inanimate beings,
to Śrī Govinda, son of Nanda, chief of the cowherds,
I offer my respectful salutations.

I adore the Divine Couple, Śrī Śrī RādhāMādhav,
who have become immersed in an ocean of playful
pastimes through the buying and selling of pearls,
each of them mutually desirous of victory,
in the matter of disputatious wrangling
over the said merchandise.

I take shelter of the Full Moon,
Śrī Gaurāṅga Mahāprabhu,
who has risen in the sky of Śrī ŚacīMātā's womb,
with the intention of bestowing the nectar of his own
pure devotion upon the citizens of the world.

Aho! By the most celebrated mercy of he from whom I
have attained the hope of some service ~
to the best of all names within the orb of this earth,
Śrī HariNām MahāMantra,
to Śrī ŚacīNandan Mahāprabhu,
to Svarūp, Rūpa, & Sanātan
and to the extensive dominions of MathurāPurī,
with all of its pasturing grounds and residences,
to Śrī RādhāKṛṣṇa,
to the chief of all mountains, Śrī Govardhan,
and to the lotus feet of Śrī Śrī RādhāMādhav,
~ to Śrī Gurudeva I bow my head again and again.

For the purpose of increasing the rapturous delight
of those divine persons,
the celebrated devotees of the Lord,
who are conversant with the science
of the mellows of devotion,
I will now churn the ocean known as Śrī Vrindāban,
that the waves of nectar produced therefrom,
namely the wonderful character and qualities of Śrī Hari,
may expand,
thus causing the devotees to drown therein.

Śrī Satyabhāmā Devī, after hearing briefly that Śrī Kṛṣṇa had created in Vrindāban a creeper that produced pearls, submissively inquired from him, expressing her desire to hear in full about this wonderful event,

“*Nāth!* [My Lord!] The pearls set in my bracelets were produced originally as the fruits of a creeper! What sanctified country is it that produces such fascinating plants?”

Satyabhāmā’s question awakened within the mind of Śrī Kṛṣṇa memories of that wonderful pastime, which in turn caused him to feel very afflicted in his heart. Externally, however, he smiled as he began his reply,

“*Priye!* [Dearest one!] The time has long passed since pearls were produced from creepers. At present pearls come only from oysters.”

Satyabhāmā listened carefully to his reply which increased her intense eagerness to hear more, thus she repeatedly requested him to tell her more about these wonderful events.

Śrī Kṛṣṇa replied,

“In Gokul, one day during the month of Kārttika, the Dīpamālikā festival was about to be held at Śrī Govardhan.¹ At that time, the residents of Gokul were carefully preparing all kinds of decorations and ornaments just suitable for celebrating the festival and making it a grand success. The cowherd men had adorned themselves with various ornaments and were especially engaged in decorating the cows, buffaloes and other animals. The cowherd women and girls were all embellishing their houses with the appropriate decorations and cleaning various ornaments, preparing them to decorate their own delicate bodies. Amongst them, the daughter of VrishaBhānu, Śrī Rādhikā, was seated within a courtyard covered with

¹During this celebration, more commonly known as Dīpāvali, which takes place on the dark moon night of Kārttika, rows and rows of little lamps, appearing like garlands of twinkling stars, are placed all around.

Mādhavī creepers, surrounded on all four sides by cottages, on the banks of the lake known as MālyaHāraṇ.² There, in the company of her sakhīs, she was preparing to make various ornaments from a collection of the most exquisite pearls.

“Coming to know of these events from the tidings of a clever young parrot aptly named, Vicakṣaṇ,³ I immediately proceeded to that place in eager curiosity.

“Upon my arrival, I submitted with great solicitude, before Rādhā and her friends, my petition for a collection of pearls with which I might decorate the receptacles of my fondest love, my two cows celebrated with the names, Hamsī and Hariṇī.

“Though they heard my request, the girls barely glanced at me, and even then with only seeming indifference. Their glances issued from the corners of their lovely eyes, half-open and partially concealed by the ends of their saris, yet still exceeding the beauty of a blue lotus, scented with the fragrance of their coquettish humour. They remained absorbed in stringing their necklaces with great concentration, responding only with the diamonds of their smiles reddened with the lacquer of their silence.”⁴

At this point I smiled and addressed them once again, “He Sakhīgan! Because you have all recently attained the priceless touchstone of adolescent beauty, is this pride of yours, which is now so magnified that it resembles a very tall mountain,

² lit.-lost or stolen garlands

³ lit.- clever, experienced

⁴ apr [another possible reading]

“Maintaining their silence they continued to expand the beauty of those necklaces that they were constructing with great skill and expertise, while at the same time discreetly exhibiting priceless diamonds and other gems on the ground stained red with lac dye, as though they were trying to decide which jewel to add next, but factually only that I might appreciate their fabulous collection.”

somehow blocking your ears? Please heed for a moment this matter that I, who am your dear friend, submit before you.”

This time my words caused ripples of laughter to spread amongst them as they each glanced at one another. Finally, the intrepid and impertinent Lalitā accosted me with angry words, coming from one as though offended, but which nevertheless emanated from her smiling face, “*Ohe Nāgar!* [Oh our Great Gallant!] These extremely costly pearls which are fit to be worn by the king’s queens (*mahiṣī*), are now deemed as being just suitable for your she-buffalo (*mahiṣī*)? Oh really! I know! Why shouldn’t we just give you all the pearls so that you can decorate your cows!”

Having listened to these deceitful and hypocritical words of Lalitā I became absorbed in their playful, joyful mood while continuing to address them with pleasant words, “Oh you who are yourselves all very attractive ornaments!⁵ You don’t have to give me all of the pearls, but at least you should give me some of them, which in fact are just perfect for decorating the four horns of these two most favourite cows of mine.”

Then Lalitā, after patiently hearing my words, took the pearls of all the sakhīs and while showing them to me with a big smile on her face, moved them around and around with her fingers, saying, “He Kṛṣṇa! [Alas!] What shall I do? There is not even one pearl here fit for your cows.”

I replied, “Ayi Lalite! Oh most clever one! Just forget it! Henceforward, you will never be able to call me a miser.”

After reproaching them in this and various other ways, I immediately came to my mother and told her, “*Janani!* [Mother!] Please give me some pearls. I want to plant them in the field.”

⁵ *Priyabhusanagan!* - This contains a double meaning: It can also mean, “You to whom ornaments (alone) are precious.”

I repeatedly requested her in this way, and finally, after listening to my eager requests, Mother laughed loudly and replied, “*Batsa!* [My darling!] Pearls will never sprout if you plant them.”

I answered, “Janani! You must give me some pearls. They will definitely sprout within three days. This you will be able to see with your own eyes.”

Seeing my intense eagerness, Mother could not refuse me, and so gave me a collection of many of her pearls. Binding them in a cloth, I immediately proceeded to the banks of the Yamunā (in Gokul), just near Jalaharon Ghāt,⁶ where I now began to prepare the soil in a low lying plot the length of three men. While I was busily engaged in seeding my freshly prepared beds with pearls, some gopīs happened to pass that way and made their presence known by their loud laughter. This I nevertheless managed to completely ignore.

Having sown all of those pearls in the ground, I covered them with fresh earth and then constructed a very dense, strong wooden fence around the field.

Hereafter, I devised a plan whereby the gopīs would be induced to come to me to beg for pearls (so that I could then refuse them, reminding them how they refused my requests). I sent some of my friends to them to request some milk for the purpose of watering my pearl plants. Of course, they only laughed very loudly as they replied, “Our milk is not suitable for such a noble purpose. Rather, you should use the milk of those cows for whom you are going to such great lengths to procure a quantity of pearls. Even if you do get pearls in this way, we will never come to covet the fruits from your garden.” (Though they spoke in this way, still they were all now fully aware of what I was doing.)

⁶ lit.- where water is collected; or a collection of water

Accepting their advice, we then proceeded to water those plants with abundant milk from our own house, on a daily basis, just so they might see that we were doing so.

On the fourth day all of those pearl bushes began to sprout. Seeing this, I was extremely delighted and ran to tell Mother. I caught hold of her sari and brought her to my garden to show her the new sprouts. She was quite surprised and simply exclaimed, “What is this?!” Considering the whole matter within her mind, she returned to Vraja, full of wonderment.

When the gopīs received this news, however, they simply joked among themselves, saying that ‘ferocious creepers of envy were sprouting.’⁷

Our pearl creepers grew as quickly as hemp plants. I saw that they were growing very quickly and spreading out quite luxuriantly, so I made them to take shelter of the Kadamba trees nearby that they might climb up on them.

In the space of only a few days, a heavenly scent which drove the bees mad, began to emanate from the flowers that had now bloomed, thus pervading the whole of Gokul with their fragrant perfume and bestowing upon the gopīs an ineffable joy. The pearl fruits which began to appear assumed an uncommon beauty, more so in fact than the eight kinds of original pearls from which they derived their existence.⁸

Seeing that all of these creepers had produced pearls, the Vrijbāsis were amazed. The gopīs in particular were especially dumbfounded with astonishment. They now came every day to see these wonderful plants, allured there by their own covetousness.

⁷ i.e. sticker bushes

⁸ Pearls come from oysters, conch shells, wild boars’ heads, elephants’ heads, king cobras’ heads, bamboo stems, clouds and fish heads.

Very soon they began to consult amongst one another, “He sakhīgan! We know very well that Kṛṣṇa will never give us any of his pearls, because previously when he requested from us both pearls and milk we refused to comply. Therefore, why should he now give us his pearl fruits? But what does it matter? It’s not that we didn’t witness the procedure for growing pearls. In fact, we have seen exactly how it is done. Therefore, let us take courage! Why shouldn’t we begin a pearl plantation which is at least twice the size of Kṛṣṇa’s?”

Hearing this, the supremely intelligent Lalitā addressed the sakhīs, “My dear friends, who are now overwhelmed by insanity! These sorts of miraculous activities, such as picking up Śrī Govardhan, and producing pearls from the earth, marvellous deeds which are difficult even for the demigods to imitate, are nevertheless accomplished without effort by Kṛṣṇa. He has, no doubt, received special mantras and medicines from some great sage, thus enabling him to execute these wonderful activities. This has already been ascertained by the residents of Vraja [*Vrajvāsigan*]. Otherwise, how is it possible that this cowherd boy Kṛṣṇa, born from the lotus pond of the womb of the wife of Vrajrāj Nanda, and exactly resembling a soft and delicate blue lotus, acquainted only in the ways and means of the cowherds, can spontaneously perform such uncommon activities, as though he had a natural ability for doing so? Even though you are aware of all these things, still you are desirous of persuading yourselves to undertake this project, though none of you possess any such mantras or magic potions. This resolution of yours will in the end most certainly amount to nothing more than the cause of your falling into the ocean of embarrassment and ridicule. This also you will certainly be made aware of. Take it from me; this is the truth.”

TuṅgaVidyā spoke up, “We can also receive a mantra possessing esoteric powers from NāndīMukhī, the most accomplished disciple at the lotus feet of Śrī Bhagavatī

Paurṇamāsī; so why shouldn't we enthusiastically persevere in this matter?"

Deciding that TuṅgaVidyā's counsel was best, they all approached NāndīMukhī and humbly submitted their intentions.

After hearing all about the aforementioned events, NāndīMukhī exclaimed to herself, "Aye! Just to make the vision of our two eyes successful, this opportunity, eternally desired by us, namely the wonder of sportive play in the matter of trade and commerce, has appeared before us like the seed of a desire tree. Today great fortune is certainly soon to follow. Hence, I will now introduce such convincing and excellent arguments to these gopīs, the crown jewels amongst clever girls, that this desire tree quickly sprouts and bears fruit."

After deliberating about the matter in this way, NāndīMukhī addressed those gopīs with a cheerful mind, "He sakhīgan! You should know it to be the truth that these pearls have been produced from the earth, not by the power of any mantras uttered by Mukuṇḍa."

The sakhīs replied, "He NāndīMukhī! Oysters are the only source of the origin of pearls. How is it possible that without oysters, pearls can be brought forth from the earth?"

NāndīMukhī replied, "Sakhīgan! Please don't think that anything is impossible in this matter. It is all due to the natural influence of this soil. The transcendental earth of these forest lands of Vraja has produced many varieties of jewels. This has been taught to me on many different occasions by Śrī Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī herself. Not only that, I also have genuine experience of it myself. In Vrindāvan, golden trees have grown and are growing, visible before our eyes, with new twigs made of coral, fresh green emerald leaves, buds of diamonds and pearls, and fruits made of rubies. Therefore, if pearls are planted in these fields of Vrajabhūmi and are seen to

produce creepers which bear pearl fruits, what is so strange or wonderful about that?! So you should also similarly engage in the cultivation of pearls, but carefully water your plants with fresh, fragrant butter. In this way you will get fruits which are superior even to those of Śrī KṛṣṇaChandra.”

In this way, the gopī maidens of Vraja drank the sweetness of NāndīMukhī’s words, completely believing everything she said. With happy hearts and great praise they all embraced her and returned to their respective homes.

They then set about their work with a spirit of great audacity. As a challenge for gaining victory over me, they paid their servants twice or thrice the normal salary (paid in the form of milk), to go out and prepare the fields for their newly discovered agricultural enterprise. Pearls that were piled up in wicker baskets waiting to be strung and those that had already been strung into necklaces were all brought for this purpose, setting only a few of the very best ones aside. They even removed all of the pearls from the ornaments which were at present decorating their graceful bodies. Each and every one of them they now planted within the ground and carefully watered with milk, butter and the most fragrant ghee, every morning, noon and evening.

Thereafter, when Candrāvalī and all the other gopīs of Vraja heard that Rādhā and her friends had taken up the cultivation of pearls, they also, being moved by intense jealousy and a covetous nature, prepared fields more extensive than any of those prepared so far. They planted each and every pearl which could be found in their houses and on their bodies, without setting even one aside for any other purpose.

Within a few days, when they saw that little plants had begun to sprout in their fields (not realising them at first to be sticker bushes), they became very proud and began to ridicule my friends, taunting them in various ways.

One day, the cowherd men noticed that there were very few milk products at the dinner table, and so became suspicious. They also noticed that their homes were devoid of their store of pearls. In an angry mood they demanded an explanation.

When they had heard the mysterious reason behind it all, the elderly ladies of the house addressed them, “*He Ayusman gopagan!* [Oh ye long-lived cowherd men!] This is nothing to chastise anyone about. True, these girls have been watering their pearl fields with an abundant supply of milk and ghee, but they will very soon be getting a great profit in return. We have seen that Śrī Kṛṣṇa’s fields have already begun to produce pearls of a quality rarely obtained even by great kings and queens.”

One day, ViśākhāDevī, after carefully observing the plants that were sprouting in her own field, secretly whispered into the ears of some of her sakhī friends, “He sakhīgan! The young plants in our fields do not appear the same as the ones that I have seen in Kṛṣṇa’s garden. I don’t know what the outcome of all this will be. Now we have to make sure that Kṛṣṇa’s friends don’t notice this. Therefore we should adopt the pretense of constructing a very nice fence to protect our plants, but in reality, the purpose of this enclosure will be to prevent Kṛṣṇa’s friends from seeing inside.”

It didn’t take many more days, however, before the plants in Rādhā’s and her friends’ fields, as well as the ones in all of the other gopīs’ fields, clearly exhibited the symptoms of being thorny creepers. The news spread throughout the length and breadth of Gokul, that, “The gopīs’ fields have produced only sticker bushes!”

Coming to know of this myself, I sent some of my friends to the meeting place of the gopīs [*GāndharvāGosthi*], and through them conveyed my congratulations, by way of a

few slightly sarcastic remarks, “I heard that your fields have produced many wonderful pearls by now, so, since I am the dearly beloved of you all, I hope that you will send with my friends, as a presentation to me, the first produce from your gardens.”

To this they replied, “Had we engaged in agricultural activities, then even the pasturing grounds would have become completely saturated with pearls. What makes you think that others are prepared to give up their traditional duty of cow protection to adopt some lower profession (that of a niggardly cultivator), just because your friend Kṛṣṇa has done so?”

Thereafter, I began to decorate all of my friends, the cows and calves, the she buffaloes who pull the carts, the sheep along with their lambs, the female goats and their kids, and even the female monkeys who cavort all over Vrindāvan, with pearl garlands and ornaments.

Seeing this, the gopīs now felt ashamed in the absence of their own ornaments. Fearful of a severe reprimand from the cowherd men, due to the fact that they were responsible for a great loss of wealth from their own homes, they now held counsel together, “What should we do now? He sakhīgan! Being partial to Kṛṣṇa, this clever NāndīMukhī has collaborated with him to unjustly deceive us.”

They arrived at NāndīMukhī’s in a hot temper, and after describing everything that had happened they rebuked her without cessation.

NāndīMukhī replied, “He sakhīgan! On the strength of whatever austerities I have performed I am prepared to declare under oath that I have not deceived you in any way! Rather, you yourselves have spoiled everything.”

The gopīs retaliated, “*He Kapatini!* [Oh fraudulent friend!] How is it that we have ruined everything?”

NāndiMukhī replied, “Becoming overly haughty and pretentious, you made such a din and bustle, just like a town-crier beating on a big kettle drum, that Kṛṣṇa and his friends were directly aware of everything you were doing. They knew that you had planted all of your pearls in the fields, yet, none of you left anyone to guard those fields.”

The gopīs all chimed in together, “So what! Is that why our plants didn’t produce pearls?”

NāndiMukhī fired back, “Oh you who are so conceited by your cleverness! I will explain to you exactly what happened! Listen carefully:

‘With the motive in mind of soundly defeating you, the spiritual master of all cunning knaves, your paramour, the great gallant, Śrī Kṛṣṇa, very cleverly enticed someone with bowls and bowls of sweet rice, namely his greedy friend, the buffoon MadhuMaṅgal, to zealously uproot all of your pearl plants, just when they had begun to sprout, and replace them with thorny creepers. The pearls thus obtained from your gardens were then planted in his own fields.

‘In this way, the entire multitude of pearl plants from all of the various gopīs’ gardens, were uprooted and either replanted, or thrown into the deep waters of the Kālindī [Yamunā]. I have come to know all of this, as the whole truth and nothing but the truth.”

The gopīs retorted, “*Ayi Mahanandi!* Oh you who are faultless in your only business of expanding the dramatic impact of our pastimes, by your own expertise in playacting, introducing as you always do the element of crooked and double dealings. Oh you who are the fellow classmate of MadhuMaṅgal, almost fit in fact to be his guru. *Ayi!* You who are a worthy partner of that deceitful dancer who is famous throughout Vraja [Kṛṣṇa]. *He tat priyatame nati.* [The darling dancer of his troupe!] Oh you famous female ascetic of KaliYuga. Let it be. Let it be.”

Many such arrows were fired as if from their arched eyebrows, but finally they subsided and the gopīs returned home to consult further on the matter. From amongst them Śrī Rādhā spoke up,

“He sakhīgan! Perhaps it was NāndīMukhī who beguiled us, or perhaps it was the crest jewel of the shrewdest of slick operators. We are at present sorely afflicted by the misery of this moment, but what will we gain by all this commiseration and consultation. Right now, our greatest distress is the persecution we face from our superiors. But if we can somehow or other show them those pearls that were feared to be lost forever, then only will that fear be relaxed. Pearls are, however, especially rare here in Gokul, therefore the only matter at hand is to consider how we might obtain those pearls from Kṛṣṇa once again, at whatever the price.”

After some more deliberation, it was decided that ChandraMukhī, who was very cunning by nature, should take a sufficient amount of gold and go to Kṛṣṇa to buy back the pearls.

ChandraMukhī submitted, “I will not be able to go there alone, since we have just finished rebuking him with such harsh words. KāñchanLatā should come with me.”

Thus it happened, with all the gopīs’ approval, that ChandraMukhī and KāñchanLatā arrived at a garden house within the pearl fields, carrying with them an abundant quantity of gold.

They addressed the proprietor of that garden house, who was sitting there next to me, “He Subal! We have heard from reliable sources that you are desirous of selling your new pearl crop. Therefore please accept all of this gold, which is of the purest quality, and give us in return its proper value by presenting us with a choice selection of your pearls.”

To this I smilingly replied, “Ohe Sakhigan! With great submission, I humbly entreated you that you might give me a few pearls, but you wouldn’t even give us one. Then I requested you for some milk to water our fields but that was also denied. Before we will sell you any pearls, we will throw them all into the waters of the Kālindī. Even if you present us with everything in all of your houses, and the houses themselves, we will never give you even one pearl of inferior value.”

KāñchanLatā spoke up, “If it were not for fear of their husbands and elders that the gopīs have to live with every day now, is there any girl who would otherwise tolerate such mean and ugly words? Anyway, what to do? Many different jewels are available in Mathurā but at present that is very far away. Therefore: He Subal! You please be the middleman in this affair. We are prepared to pay even more than the going rate.”

These were the words I was waiting to hear! Thus did I smilingly reply, “Well, after all is said and done, I am of course very soft-hearted by nature, so I won’t be able to remain as relentless as are all of you. If I don’t let you have them then what shall I do with so many pearls? But who will negotiate the price? You two?”

ChandraMukhī and KāñchanLatā replied, “Yes, we will do it.”

So I told them, “Then we might hear a detailed account of that amount just now.”

ChandraMukhī smiled and looked at KāñchanLatā, who shyly addressed Subal, “He sakhe Subal! You should accept the responsibility of arbitrating in this affair, by making a judicious and sensible solution which will enhance your good name and reputation.”

Subal turned to me and said, “*Bayasya!* [Comrade! Buddy! Pal!] What can KāñchanLatā say as regards the value of these pearls? She’ll just banter about with you, stating only a fraction of the real value. Just let the pearls speak for themselves. Then all of you should simply accept that price which is evident”

I replied, “Sakhe Subal! I can very easily understand ChandraMukhī’s intentions. Imagining KāñchanLatā to be a priceless object, she has been sent here by Rādhā to be given to me. But these pearl fruits are worth much more than heaps and heaps of Kāñchan (lit. gold). This fact is quite well known in the world, so how is it that this mere creeper of gold [KāñchanLatā] is expected to be sufficient payment for such a great collection of pearls? Now in this instance ChandraMukhī might say that the two fruits on her (KāñchanLatā’s) chest are actually golden caskets containing many priceless touchstones. However, even if this be true, it would still not be a fair price because only one of my pearl fruits is worth hundreds of thousands of billions more than even the KaustubhaMani worn by the Lord of Vaikuntha around his neck.”

KāñchanLatā’s eyebrows now contracted into a very threatening scowl as she fixed her eyes on me while fuming in anger, “Aye! You dolt! ChandraMukhī! I told you before that I didn’t want to come anywhere near him. Still, with great persistence you managed to bring me here anyway, simply to be harassed. You bring the pearls! I’m leaving this place right now!”

ChandraMukhī: “Sakhī KāñcanLate! You’re perfectly right. But how will I fix the price by myself? Worse still, how will I remain alone with these fellows in this secluded place? As it is said,

‘It is best decided together whether to proceed or desist in any particular activity.’

Or, ‘one should neither accept nor reject anything which has been decided without witnesses.’

If you’re going, then so am I!”

When I saw them about to leave I told Subal, “Sakhe Subal! Didn’t I tell you that these two would never be able to enter into negotiation?”

Now Subal approached the two gopīs and to accommodate them, said, “Sakhī ChandraMukhī! I see that my friend is very eager in the matter of pricing these commodities. Therefore, if priyasakhī Rādhā, Lalitā and the others come here themselves to represent the appropriate value, then I see no reason why they shouldn’t be able to retrieve all of the pearl fruits that they long for. I will do everything I can to mediate in this matter.”

After hearing his counsel, ChandraMukhī and KāñchanLatā returned to Śrī Rādhā and the other gopīs, and, while still boiling in anger, narrated before them the preceding events.

Rādhā, Lalitā and the others arrived outside the pearl garden house and sent ChandraMukhī to call Subal, “Our dear friend Subal! You are naturally very affectionate towards us! Therefore, please prescribe some means by which we might procure these pearl fruits for a just and proper price.”

Subal came and informed me of all the recent news, and then, according to my instructions, came back to bring Lalitā and the other gopīs before me.

Rādhā, however, accosted him, “Subal! Don’t you dare tell your bosom buddy, who is my oppressor, that I have arrived here!” So saying, she secretly entered into a KadambaKuñj nearby and sat down to listen to the proceedings.

I began to look amongst Lalitā and the other gopīs, but unable to find Rādhā I exclaimed, “Why don’t I see Rādhā here?!”

To this TuṅgaVidyā replied, “*He Gokul Yuvaraj!* [Oh crown prince of Gokul!] The respectable lady, Jaṭilā, has affectionately kept Rādhā at home today, for the purpose of executing some specific household duties.”

MadhuMaṅgal now entered and intimated to me through signs and gestures that, ‘Śrī Rādhā is secretly staying somewhere nearby.’

Smiling slightly, I asked TuṅgaVidyā, “*Ayi TuṅgaVidyā!* It would appear that Rādhā is no longer interested in obtaining any pearls.”

To this TuṅgaVidyā replied, “No it isn’t that. Not at all. We have come to buy some for her too.”

So I told her, “*Viśākhā is Rādhā and Rādhā is Viśākhā,*⁹ so I suppose that Viśākhā can pay for her. Anyway, I’m not terribly concerned about selling anything to Rādhā at the present moment. But perhaps I should inform you – my sakhās have firmly decided that whoever does not personally come here will have to pay four times the going rate and will get ordinary pearls only.”

I then addressed my friend, “*Sakhe Subal!* Bring the casket full of pearls here and spread them all about on the ground. Disregarding her previous miserliness, collect all of the smallest ones and present them to Viśākhā for Rādhā. Then collect from her the fair price. If she is unable to pay that much hard currency, then take her, by hook or by crook, she who is non-different from Rādhā, to the jail [MādhavīKuñj] next to the one where we keep those cowherd girls who are caught stealing flowers.”

⁹ One the basis of astrology, a single constellation has both these names.

MadhuMaṅgal spoke up, “Dear Friend! In spite of restraint, these adulteresses¹⁰ are all well versed in the science of escape.”

I replied, “Bayasya! I am well aware of that, but there is nothing to worry about. Though touching or coming into contact with beautiful girls, even in dreams, and having thus abandoned one’s reserve, is, for persons like ourselves, completely unworthy, I always bear in mind the following saying-

‘A wise man is prepared to do even something which could be blamable, yet he is always careful to perform his duty.’

or, furthermore,

‘In matters of law [vyavahāra] and eating [āhāra], the injunction is that one should give up shyness.’

In light of these statements from the Saṁhitās, I am prepared to stay up the whole night guarding her.”

Subal laughed, “Sakhe Purusottam! For how many days will priyasakhī Viśākhā have to remain in this greatly apprehensive situation?”

I replied, “For as many days as that person on whose account Viśākhā is being incarcerated (namely Rādhā), does not remit the total amount. Or, if she is feeling sorry for Viśākhā, she can come here herself with a partial payment and take Viśākhā’s place while Viśākhā goes to bring full payment.”

MadhuMaṅgal: “Sakhe! The Empress of all of these gopīs, namely Rādhā, is more expert than any of them at everything, especially in the matter of fleeing away. We have noticed this many times at the toll station where we collect customs duty in the form of milk and yogurt. Not only that, but you are

¹⁰ *par-ramā*: lit. ‘others’ women’ (wives of other men; girls outside of one’s family), can include the unmarried virgin also. *Para* can also be taken as a superlative, thus the meaning becomes, ‘the best women’. Vaisnavas understand the the gopīs are never really married to anyone but their eternal husband, Kṛṣṇa, so the pun should be understood in this way.

often seen to be quite sleepy due to fatigue after a hard day's work in the pastures.”

At this remark I smiled and took him aside, “Sakhe! There is no point in your entertaining these fruitless anxieties. I won't feel sleepy with her. If perchance I should, then I will appropriate the lotus stem of her left arm as a most appropriate pillow for my head, while placing my tender left hand, as pink as the eastern sky in the morning, upon the yellow silk cloth of another exquisite pillow, situated like the moon upon the delicate chest of that Rādhā. We shall thus pass the time discussing the price of pearls, fully awake in the happiness of those moments, so that the fourth watch¹¹ of the night will quickly pass, ending nevertheless, on a very pleasant and favourable note. Otherwise, placing her within the dark, impervious jail cell of my chest, I will shackle her in very firmly with my two arms, like hardened emerald bolts, and thus very happily and without apprehension, drift off into the world of dreams.”

When the gopīs overheard me speaking to MadhuMaṅgal, their faces all lit up with sweet smiles. Rādhā lifted up her head from her hiding place and while looking at me, Viśākhā and the other sakhīs, said, in secret chastisement, “*He Candrāvalī-kelikuranga!* [The Pet Deer of Candrāvalī!] *Tistha! Tistha!*” [lit.- Stop! Be quiet! Shut your mouth!]

As she chastised me in this way, her face also brightened with a smile. Viśākhā, however, looked at me askance while saying, “*He Vrajadhurtta dhrista!* [Oh you arrogant knave of Vraja!] I think its time for you to go now. Go on!”

So saying, she entered amongst the other sakhīs, all of who turned to Subal and said, “Forget this clown! If you are at

¹¹ one *yam* = a *prahār*, or 3 hours. The day and night are each divided into 4 *prahārs*. So the 4th *yam* would be between 3-6AM.

all desirous of selling any pearls, then show us the merchandise and then, after accepting proper payment, present us with the goods. Otherwise, we're going home. We can also arrange to have pearls brought from Mathurā."

At this point Subal decided it was time to show them the pearls, so he opened the treasure chests while saying to me, "*Priya bayasya!* [Beloved comrade!] These pearls are priceless. Even if they sell their houses along with the proprietors of those houses (their husbands), and their whole herds of cows as well, they still won't have enough to purchase even one pearl. Moreover, they know nothing other than you and their affection for you. Therefore, just forget their previous miserly behavior. Knowing me to be your faithful friend, I can now distribute these pearls with your permission, so much cherished by all of them, for a nominal price or for free."

I replied, "Sakhe Subal! No, no, no. That we cannot do. We're businessmen now! Anyway, what can I do? I should also support what you say I suppose. So, exact from them the nominal price that I am asking and then you can give them the pearls. No, come to think of it, I have heard from others that you sometimes accept bribes and in this way manage to spoil so much of my profit from customs duties. I had better accept the payment myself."

Subal laughed, "Very well. But you should allow them to choose the pearls of their choice, and then after seeing the ones they have chosen, you can name your price."

I replied, "Fine. They can place the pearls of their choice before me and I will then tell them the price."

Subal: "*Priya Bayasya!* Whatever these gopīs are humbly offering - if you kindly concede to accept that, then let this be the arrangement."

I replied, "He Subal! Just tell me. What are they offering?"

If it is reasonable, then I will accept.”

Subal said, “Their proposal is this:

‘Since MadhuPuri is quite far away, it will take us a couple of days to collect all the goods needed for payment. The problem is that our elders are always expressing their distress at our having lost all of their pearl ornaments, and they continually chastise us for this. Knowing you to be a very agreeable fellow, we have abandoned our shyness to come to this lonely place. We therefore request that you now present the pearls to us as a loan which we will repay, and let us go from here very quickly. We will repay the loan within one or two days along with whatever interest your friend desires. If he doesn’t believe us, then please vouch for us.’

“If you give them the pearls now, knowing that you can place your confidence in them as truthful persons, then you can collect the value of the goods, with interest, very soon. This will also greatly increase your affectionate bond with them.”

I laughed, “He Subal! You are extremely gullible. You know absolutely nothing about their dealings. If these gopīs, who are like female dancers in a drama of diplomacy, decide to play the game by absconding with the pearls, and then, without making any payment, take shelter within the walls of the great fort of their husbands, surrounded by the mountains of their elders, then what will you do?”

Subal replied, “Sakhe! Don’t say that. I’m certain they wouldn’t do such a thing. Or, even if they do, then I will go there, taking with me Ujjvala, Vasanta, Arjuna, Kokila and some other cowherd boys to tell their husbands that these gopīs promised to pay for the pearls with ‘the payment of the nectar of their lips and fond embraces’. I will frighten those gopas in this way so that the gopīs’ husbands and elders will send them to you immediately for making payment.”

To this MadhuMaṅgal angrily replied, “Ore Subal! You are Subal [endowed with auspicious strength] in name only, and a male in name only. Indeed, this is not the first time that I have noticed your appearance to be just like that of the weaker sex [*abala*].¹² Anyway, it is just befitting your timid nature that you can think of nothing better to do than to blow some hot air at the exceedingly insignificant guardians of the gopīs. Better that you should just sit down here, while I dress myself for battle. After surrounding the cows and buffaloes, along with the gopīs’ husbands, I will bring them and confine them where they can be guarded, here within NandisvarPur. Then the gopīs will be forced to come themselves to liberate their husbands and cows by making the proper payment.”

These words of MadhuMaṅgal greatly pained me, and so I asked him, “PrānSakhā MadhuMaṅgal! What kind of counsel is this? All the Vrajavāsins, even those who belong to the aboriginal classes of men known as Bhilla and Pulinda, are still dearer to me than my dearest. The cowherds especially are our family relations and our brothers, non-different from my very self. Consequently, this advice of yours is most inappropriate. I am a little inclined to support Subal’s statements except for the fact that initiating a system of exchange amongst one’s dearest friends and relatives will make it very difficult to maintain our friendship and honesty. This is mentioned in the *SmṛtiŚāstra*:

*‘The practice of mutual giving and receiving of presents
among friends should be curtailed.
Though performed with love and affection,
it becomes the cause of the extinction of love itself
and will gradually be followed by quarrel and dispute.’*

¹² The effeminacy of Subal is remarked upon in *UjjvalaNilamaṇi* (2.13), where he is said to have the ‘temperament of a girlfriend’ (*sakhī-bhāvam āsritaḥ*). The *priya-narma-sakhās* are privy to the most intimate secrets of Kṛṣṇa’s loving affairs (*ātyantika-rahasya-jñā*).

Therefore, let them pay the current price and only then can they carry away the merchandise.”

Angry that their proposal had been rejected, the gopīs flared up, making a show of false anger. While looking at Subal they addressed him thusly,” Ore! *Kautilyaparadarsin Subal!* [Oh most expert amongst double-dealing hypocrites!] You have brought us here only for the purpose that you can enjoy our vexation in being deceived and disappointed by all of you. Therefore, go ahead with your plan to build up your kingdom by trading in pearls. We’re leaving!”

As they were preparing to go, Subal approached them with a very amiable disposition and spoke very softly to Lalitā, “Sakhī Lalite! This practice of giving extended credit and the taking on of debts (on your side) will prove in the long run to be nothing more than the cause of the loss of love between friends. Only due to fear of this, our dear friend has concluded, with absolute certainty, that he is unable to hand over the merchandise without ascertaining the proper price for the goods and the means of receiving that amount. I have now especially understood this point, so there is no recourse for you all but to turn around. Please don’t leave now. Let us get together and first fix the price. You can consider how the payment will be made afterward.”

Humbly submitting the facts of the matter to them in this way, Subal brought the gopīs back. Bringing them before me he said, “Bayasya! Please stop joking around now and tell us the price that you are asking.”

I replied, “Sakhe Subal! To whom should I quote the price first?”

Subal: “Since Lalitā is the chief amongst them, please tell us what payment you will receive from her?”

With a playful smile on my lips I replied, “In the battlefield, if the chief amongst this battalion, Śrī Lalitājīu, is able, by

exhibiting the prowess of the most vigorous amongst us, to blunt the weapons of such a lion among men as me, then I will lay my weapons down. Having ceased firing my weapons, I will then sing the glories of her manliness and virility. I will, in this way, become her servant. This is the small payment I will receive from her.”¹³

Subal laughed as he replied, “*He Gokul Vir!* [Oh Champion of Gokul!] For the purpose of humbling the mountain of pride of Devrāj Indra, who had become so puffed up by his accumulated opulence and power, you held up, here in Vraja, for a period of seven days and seven nights, the mount GovardhanGiri, on the tip of the little finger of your left lotus hand, which is as soft as the outer covering of a lotus seed, as though he was no more than a bee perched there. Now how will Lalitā, who is more delicate than the softest young girl, contest in battle such a ferocious (*uccaṇḍa*- wild, passionate, untamable) warrior as you?”

MadhuMaṅgal spoke up, “Subal! How is it you are so highly acclaiming his prowess of preadolescence [childhood-*pauganda*], when the Desire Tree of KamDeva [namely Śrī Kṛṣṇa himself], by being sprinkled with the nectar of fresh youth, has now extended its branches and creepers in all directions, far surpassing its previous size and beauty?”

¹³ This paragraph contains references to the reversal of sexual roles. Thus, the word *pauryuṣa* (prowess) refers to Lalitā’s adopting the masculine role, while *kunṭhitāstrikartum* (blunting my weapons) can also mean, ‘make me into a meek woman’. ‘I will never again bear weapons before her’, can also mean, ‘I will never be able to come before her as a non-woman (man) again’. Or again, ‘I will never be without a woman again’. *Amuktā sṛī* (not firing weapons) can also mean, (having become) an unliberated {i.e., submissive or dependant} wife. *Samara* (battle) can also mean, as does *samiti*, ‘intimate congress’, for both have as their root meaning, ‘coming together’.

“If the chief amongst this battalion, Śrī Lalitājiu, is able, by exhibiting the prowess of the most vigorous amongst us, to even once pin me (the lion among men) down in a wrestling match, in hand-to-hand combat, then I will come before her as a woman. Appearing just like a submissive and dependent wife, I will sing the glories of her manliness and virility.”

Subal replied, “And how have you come to know all this?”

MadhuMaṅgal: “Well, just as Kṛṣṇa previously gave much perturbation to his enemies (in lifting Govardhan hill) without any difficulty whatsoever, he has now also totally vanquished with the weapons of his nails the Kandarpa Parvat [hills of KāmDeva], situated just near the hearts of his enemies, though they be very difficult to approach. In this battle, however, he has known some fatigue.”

Thereupon I laughed as I addressed Subal, “My friend Subal! You have spoken truthfully. Most of the time and in most cases I am as you have described me; but not in front of this girl. Since from the very beginning, in the most forceful and intense manner, this Lalitā, who is so strangely wonderful in all her diverse ways, and so wise and intelligent, has on many occasions, simply with the twang of her eyebrows, which are like two fierce bows, completely stunned me. By her battle cry, I become easily paralyzed. So how can she be described as a member of the weaker sex?”

Hearing my statement, Lalitā smiled as she looked towards the other gopīs. Though she felt great ecstasy she concealed it and spoke as if she was absolutely infuriated, “*Aye Vidushak Subal!* [You clown Subal!] It seems that even you have become possessed by the goddess of buffoonery worshipped by the friend of MadhuMaṅgal, the Lord of hypocrisy, the greatest jester and cheat of Gokul, since we find that you have brought us before him only to cast us into the ocean of affliction and frustration, chaffing us as the butt of your jokes.”

Using phrases such as this, Lalitā cast her eyes on me in a very crooked fashion. As though rebuking me, she sarcastically repeated, “Come on you sweet little sakhīs, you simple-hearted gopī girls!”

Having said her piece she was preparing to leave, along with all the other gopīs, when who should arrive on the scene but the disciple of Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī, NāndīMukhī. Judging from the presence of everyone, that they were all about to leave, she addressed Lalitā, “Sakhī Lalite! Simply due to a few jocular remarks from this sportive connoisseur of amusement, Śrī VrajendraNandan, how is it that you are now prepared to disregard your real purpose and leave this place? I beseech you, tarry with me for a few moments, for,

In the face of insult, I keep my pique [resentment] behind me.

A wise man always endeavors to realise his objective.

To lose sight of one's goal (to give up) is foolish.'

(For the purpose of realising my objectives I always remain alert,

No matter what anyone says or how much treachery and cunning they apply.)

We should guide our lives in this way, by the principles of logic; tolerating any imposture due to excessive mockery and harassment. Maintaining patience and repose, one should always remain diligent regarding one's duties, that they may be carried through to fulfillment. It is my solemn oath to you, though you may find it hard to accept, that it is his very jest and raillery, acting as though a go-between [mediator], which will in the end bestow these pearls upon you all. Otherwise, if Śrī Kṛṣṇa, who is as you know very conceited and sensitive, at all recollects your parsimonious behavior, then it will no longer be possible for him to apply his humorous methods. Therefore, after hearing the asking price for all those present, you should adopt whatever behavior is proper and civil, and in this way realise your ends.”

Having spoken thus, NāndīMukhī forcibly caught hold of Lalitā and brought her, along with the other gopīs, near the mountain of pearls. Then she addressed me as follows, “He Gokul Yuvaraj! Along with hundreds of her blessings, the worshipful Bhagavatī sends you a message.”¹⁴

¹⁴ In the *GovindaLīlāmṛta* also, NāndīMukhī is cast in the role of a go-between, carrying messages from Paurṇamāsī to Kṛṣṇa or Rādhā, and intervening as a referee in the quarrels of the lovers.

I replied, “NāndīMukhī! I hope that the venerable Bhagavatī Devī is keeping well. Please tell me her order, that I may felicitate my soul with the nectar of her good instructions.”

NāndīMukhī replied with the message sent by Paurṇamāsī:

“You are the son of the sovereign of Vraja, the master of vast wealth. All of these darling young girls, beginning with Śrī Rādhā, are the favourite objects of our affection, and they are also continuously devoted to you to whom we wish long life. Therefore, kindly glance upon us, by giving up this excessive persistence of yours, and accept whatever they are capable of giving, a value within the realms of practicality. You can thus satisfy us by bestowing upon them the pearls they so cherish.”

NāndīMukhī continued, “Accept such words of solace as these, spoken by Bhagavatī. Give up your facetious moods, and after presenting these young girls with their pearls, send them on their way home. Demonstrate to the whole of Gokul that you are the most magnanimous bestower of happiness within its realms.”

To this I admirably replied, “NāndīMukhī! Previously, when we received Bhagavatī’s order through Subal, we accepted it on our head as a bouquet of flowers. We at that time discarded all ideas about exorbitant prices. Only in the case of Lalitā, some nominal fee was ascertained in collaboration with her, but now if she says that she wants even that amount to be reduced, then she need only say so. I am prepared to give up that amount also.”

Hearing my reply, NāndīMukhī saw that all the sakhīs were smiling, except for Lalitā, whose lips were trembling and whose eyebrows were crooked up into quite a frown. Laughing quietly she addressed me, “VrajaYuvaRāj! I have heard from them all about your nominal prices. But now it is time to leave

all joking aside. After having determined the appropriate prices for everyone here, you can quote them before me now.”

I replied, “NāndīMukhī! Jyeṣṭhā is the most senior amongst these gopīs. After consulting with her, you can just tell me the price that you have agreed upon.”

NāndīMukhī: “The usual system is that the master of the wealth should first fix the amount. Therefore, you tell us your asking price.”

I replied, “Jyeṣṭhā should first give up her dignity and patience (abandon her boundaries) and with passionate desire, rise up (dawn), as have Rādhā and AnuRādhā, in the pathway of the sky of my heart (upon my chest), I who am the Lord of the night [the moon]. Then, along with them, or individually, she should very slowly and gently kiss the moon of my mouth with her lotus-soft lips. This is the only price I ask.”¹⁵

I then noticed, that amongst all those present within this forest bower, Rādhā, Viśākhā, Lalitā and Jyeṣṭhā, were knotting their eyebrows in terrible frowns expressing great anger. So I inquired, “NāndīMukhī! Why are they getting so angry to hear these words of mine, which are so propitious as regards their own individual fulfillment?”

NāndīMukhī replied, “*He Sundor!* [Oh most beautiful one!] These chaste girls are the wives of men other than the Dark Lord of the Gokul night.¹⁶ Thus they consider it to be a

¹⁵ As Viśākhā, Rādhā, and Anurādhā, are all names of constellations, so too is Jyeṣṭhā. Kṛṣṇa is often known as Vidhu, the moon, or the ‘Lord of the night’. The ‘abandonment of boundaries’ indicates that Jyeṣṭhā does not generally appear in the sky near to the moon at the same time as Rādhā and AnuRādhā. The created metaphor presents a very beautiful picture of these three constellations approaching (kissing) the moon in the night sky. Metaphors comparing the players in Vraja with constellations are rife in the writings of Rūpa Gosvāmin and the other Gauriya Vaisnava authors: e.g. BRS i.1.1, LalM 2.22, ViM 1.10, Dānakelikaumudī 413, etc. The name Jyeṣṭhā is not found in the three main puranic lists of gopī names cited by Jiva in KṛṣṇaSandarbha (189).

¹⁶ GokulShyām Niśapati- the Dark one (moon) of Gokul / Lord of the night

sign of great sin, simply to touch another man, what to speak of kissing the moon of his mouth. For this reason they are angry.”

Having heard the narration of such pleasure pastimes thus far, Satyabhāmā addressed Kṛṣṇa, “He Nāth! When enumerating the gopīs, who are like stars in the sky, the name of Lalitā was left out, who is likewise Rādhā’s own, and while under the influence of excessive mirth and mockery, the name of AnuRādhā was used. It is perfectly reasonable that the witty Rādhā and Viśākhā felt enraged when reflecting upon the mention of their own names in this teasing manner. Yet why did Lalitā become angry at hearing your amusing comments?”

Kṛṣṇa replied, “Priye! Another name of Lalitā is AnuRādhā.”

Satyabhāmā: “Yādavendra! [Oh Lord of the Yadus!] My mind has been abundantly satisfied by hearing the narration of these unprecedented pastimes, but not to the point of satiation. Please therefore, continue to describe to me these events in all their detail.”

Kṛṣṇa continued, “At this point, while gazing upon the moon-like face of ChampakLatā, lit up with a smile, I caused the pearls belonging to her to fall through my fingers as I said:

“NāndīMukhī! I have suspected for a long time now that this dear sakhī of yours, ChampakLatā, has attained supernatural powers from some spiritually adept sage.”

NāndīMukhī: “And how did you arrive at this conclusion?”

I replied, “Since we see that this Champak vine, amongst other inanimate objects, though bent down by its brace of very large fruits, is still quite easily able to move about, hither and thither. Therefore, let this golden Champak garland grace

my chest, which is like a beautiful black cloud, with its sweet fragrance. By my mystic powers, I will without delay, as per the order of this Champak garland, then adopt the heroic form of a fine garland of emeralds about her neck, as well as the MahendraNīl sapphire suspended between her two breasts.”

Subal spoke up, “Priya sakhā! All of us have perceived the mystic powers of ChampakLatā, by virtue of her ability to move about as she does, and so forth. However, no one has at any time or place witnessed the powers of yours that you speak of. On account of this, if you are powerless to immediately accomplish this difficult task that you have described, we shall be the laughing-stock of all those present. I hope you can understand, after carefully considering the matter at hand, that it is incumbent upon you now to demonstrate your abilities.”

To this I replied, “Subal! Though I demonstrate my mystic powers; still you cannot see! What can I do about that?!”

NāndīMukhī addressed me, “*MadhuRanga!* [Oh you of graceful limbs and delicious appearance!] Please tell us. We are exceedingly desirous to hear all about the wonderful accomplishments effected by your supernatural powers; when, where and how you performed these miraculous achievements.”

I replied, “On the occasion of a pilgrimage to Ambikāvana, my father was attacked by a large python. Simply by the touch of my toe, that serpent was transformed into the king of the Vidyādhara race [of demigods], fully decorated with all his ornaments. I held up like an umbrella, the chief of all mountains, Girindra Govardhan, with only one hand and for a full week. When Subal and my other friends became bewitched by the poison of Kāliya, I brought them back to clear consciousness simply by my glance. On many occasions I transformed great forest fires into nectar and then very easily drank them up with one swallow. Is there anyone in Gokul

who hasn't seen these and the many other manifestations of my mystic potency? Hence, what is the need for me to expand further upon these topics?"

Having heard these and other similar words of mine, the following words now emanated from the sweetly smiling face of Lalitā, "NāndīMukhī! This disagreeable lecher of yours has spoken truthfully, but those days have passed. All of these miraculous activities were performed due to the potency of his celibacy [*brahmacārya*]. Nowadays, however, as a result of continuously enjoying wanton pastimes with the wife of Govardhan Malla [Candrāvalī], servant of the malignant, malevolent, malicious, murderous and cruel Kamsa, along with her friends Padmā, Śaivyā and others amongst the beautiful young girls of Vraja, his *brahmacārya* has been vitiated and his mystic powers have all but vanished."

To this I replied with a smile,

doshmadhye ganna nahi hoy tejiyan |
sarvabhug bahni hoy tāhār pramān | |

*'High-spiritedness is not counted amongst faults. The all-omnivorous quality of fire is the proof of this.'*¹⁷ ¹⁷ BhP x.33.29

"You are only able to speak as you have because you cannot understand the true meaning of this verse. Therefore, listen carefully as I explain it in detail-

'Fire does not lose any of its vigour by consuming whatever it may. On the contrary, its strength increases by doing so. Similarly, through the sweet satisfaction of constantly enjoying erotic pleasures with beautiful young girls like you, my mystic potencies are kindled, constantly blazing forth brighter and brighter.'

Now MadhuMaṅgal spoke up, "Lalite! Our dear friend has spoken correctly. If his powers hadn't increased, then how was it possible that he could plant pearls in the ground and

get them to sprout? Not only that! They all grew luxuriously and produced such an abundance of blooming flowers and fruits.”

Lalitā laughed, “Venerable MadhuMaṅgal! Was this in fact due to the influence of your dear friend’s supernatural potencies?”

MadhuMaṅgal: “If it was not due to his powers, then what was it due to?!”

Lalitā: “Surely it was the potency of the soil of Vrindāvan!”

Rādhā spoke softly to herself, “Lalite! Say that it was also due to the influence of association with young girls!”

Viśākhā spoke out, “Aye! Yes! This has all come about as the result of his association with young women!”

I replied, “Then how is it that your pearls turned into thorny bushes?”

Lalitā: “*Aye Catursiromani!* [Oh most clever one, crest jewel amongst the most cunning!] Can pearls ever become thorny?”¹⁸

I said, “Then why weren’t pearls produced?”

Lalitā: “On account of the defective condition of the soil, or some imperfection in the seeds.”

Rādhā again, off to the side, “Lalite! Say that no pearls were produced because of the properties of the particular field!”

Then Viśākhā spoke out, expressing the desires of Rādhā.

NāndiMukhī: “Lalite! I think Viśākhā has something here!”

¹⁸ Can liberated souls (*muktā* = pearls) ever behave viciously (*himśrāḥ* = thornbushes)?

Lalitā: “How is that?”

NāndīMukhī: “This land of Vrindāvan,¹⁹ saturated with juicy sweet dew, is barren soil for the poisonous creeper of total liberation,²⁰ yet fertile terrain for the heavenly creepers, illuminated by feelings of continuous rapturous delight, produced from hearts overflowing with an abundance of *prem*, their very being permeated with the ambrosia of pure devotion. Any living creature who happens to wander into these lands becomes a devotee. So how could they be merely liberated?”

Lalitā laughed, “Viśākhē! You had already expressed to us that it was through his association with young women that he was successful in his garden pastimes. Please expand upon this for us.”

Viśākhā quoted:

*“If he associates with those who are fallen,
even a great yogin who has ascended the ladder of yoga
is made to fall from the path of sense control,
what to speak of one with negligible spiritual perfections.”*

According to this principle: by belonging to the same family, or through even only a moments association by touch, thought or conversation with this person of the darker sort, very witty and humorous, who is thoroughly addicted to

¹⁹ Kṣetra can mean both ‘field’, as in Rādhā’s previous statement, and here as, ‘place of pilgrimage’.

²⁰ The type of liberation or mukti which leads to the total disintegration of the ego is not desired by devotees because it gives no opportunity for service to Kṛṣṇa. Here again the pun on mukta (pearl) and mukta (liberated person) is being exploited.

“Since we see that the poisonous creeper, which is always and in all ways the emblem of total freedom (liberation – mukti), produces pearls on barren land; yet within these fields and meadows of Vrindāban, the heavenly creepers are reduced to cowering in fear of the wild animals who happen to wander into these lands. For this reason they couldn’t produce any pearls.”

women and often to be seen with a flute which is full of holes,²¹ these pearls²² had to take birth from within the womb of the earth, and were then pierced with holes and strung together like someone bound in the ways of the world (*samsar*)."

Thereupon I said, "Viśākhe! Everything you have spoken is perfectly correct."

Subal: "Bayasya! How is that?"

I replied, "Well, though the sages of DaṇḍaKāranya were liberated while still embodied (*mukta*), they took up the observance of very severe penances and austerities after hearing in detail from Nārada Muni and the other saintly persons about my auspicious qualities, my beauty and wit, the personified forms of the professors of passionate pastimes. By virtue of this, they could then accept birth in the homes of the cowherd men of the forests of Gokul, as the wanton women of Vraja [*vrajavilāsinī*].²³ Being bound²⁴ with an abundance of good qualities, beginning with wisdom and good humour, they are now residing on my chest like a beautiful necklace, along with so many other *muktas* (pearls; liberated souls). These other saintly souls have been similarly attracted by my inconceivable qualities, to take up their residence in the forests of Vraja, multiplying themselves as a plenitude of eternally perfected animate and inanimate creatures, bushes, creepers, birds and beasts, simply to increase my pleasure; thus enjoying the highest happiness themselves."²⁵

²¹ *chidra* - hole or fault

²² liberated persons or pearls

"Similarly, by such association these pearls have become pregnant within the womb of the earth, and their full implication within the snare of *samsar* [family life] is realised by the sprouting up of so many of their offspring on the surface of the earth."

²³ The reference is to *PadmāP* vi.272.166-7, an incident which is sufficiently important to have been cited several times by Rūpa ((BRS ii.2.302, *UN* 3.40) and Jiva (*BhaktiS* 321, *Rādhakṛṣṇārcanadī tīkā* 80, *Gopālacampū* i.23.38).

²⁴ The word *guna* means knot (in which sense it has been used in connection with the pearls), as well as, 'quality of nature', i.e. *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*.

²⁵ The flora and fauna of Vraja are often likened to sages in *BhP*, e.g.: x.15.5-6; 21.14; 47.18.

Subal: “Well spoken, my friend.”

Lalitā smiled slightly, “If in fact you do possess esoteric powers, then you could have produced pearls regardless of where they were planted or the differences in the soil? If you really have such great mystic potencies, then how is it that you have set up this small business selling pearls, simply for the purpose of accumulating superfluous commodities?”

I responded, “*Ayi! Murkhe Lalitike!* [Lalitā, you dolt! Silly girl!] Puffed up by the treasure of your youth, all of you have given up your religious duties and are now wandering here and there. Should I too, the only son of the King of Vraja, the crest jewel amongst the *vaisyas*, who am so devoted to my religious duties, also renounce these duties like a wilful, wanton and spoiled child? In the scriptures, the sages have prescribed the duties of the *vaisyas* to be: agriculture, tending the cows, engaging in commerce and usury. These four professions have been ascertained in relation to the *vaisyas*. Since we are *vaisyas*, these four occupations exist for us. By the practice of even one of these professions, all mystic powers increase. But by engaging in all four of them, my potencies have ascended beyond the perfectional limit.”

NāndīMukhī smiled, “*He svadharma nisthā Yuvarāj!* [Oh Prince who art devoted to thy duty!] Your three occupations, agriculture, cow protection and commerce are clearly understood by us. But I have never heard mention of this money-lending business (usury).”²⁶

I replied, “NāndīMukhī! Hadn’t you heard that we were doing this? At this most needed juncture in time, due to the present shortage of pearls, that is, their present unavailability, we are duty bound to take up this much desired business with these young gopīs, much perturbed by circumstances beyond

²⁶ Another reading lists law as the fourth duty. In the *BhagavadGītā* 18.44, usury is not mentioned as one of the duties of the *vaisya* caste as are the other three.

their control, simply for the sake of arranging that these pearls might further flourish.”²⁷

Viśākhā laughed, “He Subal! Those who are attached to certain actions, though they be blameworthy, will nevertheless praise those activities to the skies. Thus I suppose it is not terribly surprising that your fine friend here describes his impious activities in such a splendid fashion.”

Subal laughed, “NāndīMukhī! It is not only in the matter of money that such prosperity has been realised. This exacting of interest is also the cause of an increase in others’ possessions as well.”

NāndīMukhī: “Such as?”

Subal: “For instance, the attractive bodily characteristics of those in the fresh bloom of youth, whose every limb can conquer Cupid (or, the mind) tens of millions of times over; those whose roving eyes, especially very restless at the corners, far surpass the softest lotus flowers; and whose speech is like a shower of the sweetest nectar.”

MadhuMaṅgal: “Subal! Have you forgotten the other things which have enjoyed similar prosperity?”

Subal: “Please remind me. To what are you referring?”

MadhuMaṅgal: “Shark-shaped [Capricorn] earrings; jewelled anklets; jewelled armlets; rings, and the like; the beauty and pride of those who wear them and especially the playful pastimes of love dalliance itself.”

Lalitā: “Arya! ²⁸ There is another thing that has also increased. Why are you concealing that?!”

NāndīMukhī: “Which is?”

²⁷ There are some hidden meanings here: During the day the gopīs are greatly afflicted by separation from Kṛṣṇa. He is trying to make some provision that they can meet together, even when he is herding the cows and such, so that their agitation will be due to the experience of ecstatic symptoms of love, and not due to feelings of want.

²⁸ *Arja-* form of address to a respectable person

Lalitā: “The tasted remnants of the nectar from the lips of chaste young girls (*adharāmrita*).”

Śrīmatī Rādhikā laughed, “Lalite! The body itself speaks of what its food is (‘You are what you eat’)!—²⁹

“In those two arms that more than trample the pride of exquisite, perfectly shaped sapphire bolts; in that chest which totally destroys the vanity of an emerald door; in those two thighs that goad the pride of emerald banana trees; in that beautifully expanded face which is the support of the graceful beauty of a hundred, thousand billion full moons of the Sarad season, who remain embarrassed in the face of such exquisite sweetness; in those two feet, the softness of which causes all praise of succulent new mango leaves to fall to pieces; in all of those delicious bodily limbs, the construction of which bestows well-being and modesty to all symmetrical beauty, most pleasing to the eyes; and in that body which steals away the lustre of a new blue lotus flower, just ready to blossom, lending its radiance to scintillating sapphires – its (*adharāmrita*’s) dallying presence, pervading all of his bodily limbs, is a dazzling pastime. The ambrosial, soft, smiling speech of Viśākhā and yourself is its perfume, like a soft flower smeared with sandalwood paste.”³⁰

MadhuMaṅgal felt that his advice was now needed, “Bayasya! Making you greedy for the delicious lips of young women who belong to others, these extremely shrewd gopīs, after saying so many sweet things and enticing you with tall talks about increased profits and promises of prosperity, will

²⁹ (apr) “Even Bapu should be able to understand something about this! Who can enjoy a nice meal without it!”

Bapu-(*shman*)- abdominous; MadhuMaṅgal is very fond of eating prasādam

³⁰ The implied meaning here is that it is by drinking the nectar of the gopīs’ lips that Kṛṣṇa has acquired these super-excellent bodily features.

[apr of the last sentence: “This ambrosial speech of Rādhā’s was made even more fragrant by Viśākhā when she repeated it aloud, adding to it the blooming flower of her smiling face.”]

simply, in the end, take all of these pearls and enter into the inaccessible fort protected by Jaṭilā ³¹ and her compatriots, a labyrinthine maze where you will never find them. Then, neither will they give you any more news about accrued interest, nor even the original, asking price of the merchandise. Having clearly perceived this, I have, as your friend, spoken these words for your benefit. Afterwards, you may do as you please.”

Thereupon I had to bite my tongue, “Sakhe! Gāndharvikā (Rādhā) and these other heavenly damsels are chaste and respectable girls. They are very upright and pure in their exchanges of the objects of desire. You have spoken thusly only because you are unaware of all this. Therefore, listen carefully as I explain everything to you:

“Just recently, Gāndharvikā provided me with excessive delight by offering the nectar of her lips to me, and in the morning received from me a pair of ruby necklaces with which to decorate her breasts.³² Then in the evening, I was again amply rewarded at four times my own expenditure, when she spread out her wares³³ upon my chest. Then on the evening of the day before yesterday, Lalitā received from me one lodestone, oozing forth with nectar, but only after some dispute did she finally pay me back at a profit of three times. Another time, around midnight, after drinking the sweet nectar of my lips with great fondness and persistence, Viśākhā entertained me till early morning, gratifying me to the utmost with the whole wealth of her entire being. I profited many times on

³¹ Jaṭilā - (lit.) complicated, intricate, complex, abstruse; Rādhā's mother-in-law

³² “Gāndharvā then came very near to me, after very tastefully decorating her breasts with lotus flower pollen that has received its colour from the best friend of the lotuses, the early morning rising sun.” Or, *Rekhika* (ruby necklace) also means, ‘scratches’. Thus, “She received from me some beautiful scratches, the colour of the pollen of a lotus flower, with which to decorate her lovely breasts.”

³³ Her own breasts, kisses and scratches.

that occasion. The others also, beginning with ChampakLatā, have on many occasions, after eagerly accepting from me their most desired objects, satisfied me immensely in return, some at double my expenditure, some at triple. Amongst all of them, only two gopīs display some slightly contrary business dealings.”

NāndīMukhī: “Who are they?”

I replied, “One of them is RaṅganBalli³⁴ (RanganMālā). She once agreed to place the two round fruits of her bosom on my chest three times, but then after accepting two *mardan*³⁵ fruits from me, in the shape of my massaging hands, she only offered her fruits to me once. The other two that she still owes me, after much delay and procrastination, have, to this day, yet to be paid. Then also, the constant companion of RanganMālā, Tulasī, told me that she would pay me double, but then after accepting a whole bunch of embraces from me, she only teases me, passing the time by saying, ‘Now I’ll give you. No! Not now, I’ll give you then, when.....’

The price that we had agreed upon has still not been paid.”

MadhuMaṅgal said, “Ayi RaṅganBalli! Ayi Tulasī! Even though my dear, affable friend couldn’t obtain from you any of his own celestial commodities, still, due to his natural simplicity, even people of your manners remain dear to him, though our dear friend is by nature a spoiled child and used to having his own way.³⁶ Are you so ungrateful that you do not fear what the people in general, or even what the gods will think of you, that you behave in such a deceitful and

³⁴ Raghunāth knows Rūpa Gosvāmin in his mañjarī form by this name. The reluctance of the mañjarīs to engage in direct dalliance with Śrī Kṛṣṇa is being expressed here. Tulasī is the name by which Raghunāth knew his own mañjarī form. Rūpa Gosvāmin is more commonly known as Rūpa Mañjarī and Raghunāth as Rati Mañjarī.

³⁵ *mardan*- subduing, manly, male

³⁶ or, “Still, due to his natural simplicity, he does not speak ill even of people of duplicitous ways.”

cunning fashion with those who are by nature very simple and sincere.”

Lalitā gave a lovely little laugh at hearing all this as she retorted, “He Arya MadhuMaṅgal! [Oh most venerable MadhuMaṅgal!] Is there anyone in this assembly who does not hold the words just uttered by your friend to be dearer than the most ambrosial nectar? Yet, if it weren’t for the fact that his speech smacks heavily of mystic perfection, then his every word, nay every syllable, could be understood to be nothing more than fictitious lies!”³⁷

All the sakhīs laughed uproariously as they each embraced Lalitā while exclaiming, “*Sādhu Sādhu!* Lalite! [Bravo! Well done Lalite!] You summed that up pretty well!” Śrīmatī Rādhikā also embraced Lalitā within her mind.

Now NāndīMukhī spoke up, “*He Mohan!* [Oh most charming one!] Whose word do you doubt? This RāṅganMālīkā is the most beloved of Lalitā, and Tulasī is the disciple of Viśākhā. Therefore it is certain that Lalitā and Viśākhā, after consoling and explaining various things to them, will bring them around to your way of thinking. Then surely they will present you with the goods remaining in arrears so that the matter will be rectified and you will again treat them as you did before. If for some reason they remain adamant in the matter of presenting you with your dues, then I’m sure that Lalitā and Viśākhā, because they are so deeply affectionate to RāṅganBalli and Tulasī, will themselves present you with your goods. Yet even if they also unexpectedly refuse to come through with any payment, they will never again be able to lodge complaints against you, no matter what you do.* Otherwise, if you stand

³⁷ The pun is this: Since another meaning of mystic perfection [*siddhi*]: is *bhang* (a drink made from cannabis); thus, “He is intoxicated from drinking *bhang* and his words reflect this, thus we can understand that his every word, no, every syllable, is nothing more than lies!”

*^{apr} they will never again be able to ask anything of you, no matter how great their need

in front of the sister of AnaṅgaMañjarī³⁸ and begin to whistle very loudly, then they just might get frightened and anxious enough that they will immediately agree to give you whatever you want.”

At this the gopīs frowned and sent very crooked glances askance at both NāndīMukhī and myself.

TuṅgaVidyā now came slightly forward and smiling to herself, said, “*Bho! Bho!* [Hallo!] He sakhīgan! I have a bit of juicy news for you all!”

Everyone replied, “Yes, what is that?”

TuṅgaVidyā: “There is an ācārya by the name Kānta Darpa.³⁹ Have you heard of him?”

Lalitā: “I have heard the name but I don’t know much about him.”

TuṅgaVidyā: “Śhyāmal Miśra, the dear disciple of KāntaDarpĀcārya, has written a commentary called *Sandhi Catustayākhyāta-kṛd-vṛttayaḥ* {*Sandhi Chatuṣṭay*}⁴⁰ on the *sutras* [aphorisms] of his guru. Have you seen what is described in that commentary?”

Viśākhā: “Visnu! Visnu! I have never even heard of this commentary, what to speak of having seen it!”

Lalitā purposefully questioned her, “TuṅgaVidyā! Where did you become acquainted with this ācārya?”

TuṅgaVidyā: “One evening I met here a very beautiful river goddess, the *apsarā* called MahāPadmā, coming from Sakhīsthali [Candrāvalī’s kuñj]. She was looking for Śhyāmal Miśra, that she might hear a reading of his commentary.”

³⁸ AnaṅgaMañjarī is the younger sister of Śrīmatī Rādhikā

³⁹ the *pride of a lover*, or, KandarpaDarpa- the *pride of Cupid*

⁴⁰ Four Sandhis; [*sandhi*- union]; ostensibly a grammatical treatise

At this point I spoke up, “TuṅgaVidye! How did that river goddess come this far into the forest?”

TuṅgaVidyā: “By her ability to extensively yet uselessly flood her banks!” (apr) or, “By the power of a flood of desire!”

Everyone laughed to hear this answer.

Lalitā: “And then?”

TuṅgaVidyā: “Along with Śhyāmal Miśra, there is also the unrivalled [false] Paṇḍit of the king, Alikā Paṇḍit, who after first having quoted the precepts of the *NarmāPañjikā* (Amusement Almanac) and the *KroyVikroyPañjikā* (Commerce Almanac), then produced the *AlīkPañjikā* (Imaginary Almanac; Almanac of Lies, Deception) and the *ĀdānPradānPañjikā* (Exchange Almanac; The Almanac of Giving and Receiving Gifts) as well. I’m sure you must have heard of these four treatises, though they may have been under different names.”

Lalitā: “We certainly have. We also have had firsthand experience of the same.”

TuṅgaVidyā: “Even more accurate and erudite, exhibiting the sharpest intellect and effrontery, are the commentaries begun at the same time (perhaps as a challenge) by his fellow classmate, Kuhak Bhaṭṭa.”*

ChampakLatā: “TuṅgaVidye! As you are well-versed in all the branches of knowledge, we are all intently desirous of learning from you the etymologies of the names of these four well-known authors of scripture.”

Viśākhā: “The meaning of the two titles, Ācārya and Bhaṭṭa, is clearly understood, but we would appreciate it if

*Kuhak - magic; Bhaṭṭa - Master of Deception

you would elucidate the etymological derivation of Miśra and Paṇḍit.”⁴¹

TuṅgaVidyā laughed, “There are faults as well as attributes. Because there is mixing [*miśrit*] of these faults and attributes, the name is Miśra. The word pronounces its own meaning.”

NāndīMukhī: “What are the faults and attributes?”

TuṅgaVidyā: “The tendency to be indiscriminate in judging whether one is clever and dexterous or not (in matters of love) is a fault. An equal disposition, devoid of discrimination and averse to the judgement of superiority or inferiority, all due to an excessivity of simplicity (naivety), is an attribute.”

Lalitā laughed, “Consequently the title [degree] is quite appropriate.”⁴²

Citrā: “Now please elucidate the etymological derivation of Paṇḍit.”

TuṅgaVidyā: “The word *paṇḍā* indicates the intelligence to tell truth from falsehood. Therefore *Paṇḍit*, which is a compound of *paṇḍā*, designates the same (or, one who is possessed of such intelligence). Yet, this Paṇḍit, thinking himself to be endowed with such honourable sagaciousness, has considered that the maxim, ‘*Of the previous and latter precepts, the latter carries more weight,*’ gives him the right to only contemplate

⁴¹ Ācārya is a title given to any teacher. It is derived from *ācār*, and is generally taken to mean ‘one who knows the proper conduct from scripture, who follows it himself and who instills such behaviour in his students’. Bhaṭṭa is generally taken to be the corrupt form of *bhartṛ* (nom. sing. *bhartā*) meaning master. It is a title, like *ācārya* fixed to the names of learned scholars, etc. The use of Miśra as a title for brāhmanas probably derives from its usage as a plural address, e.g. *aryaMiśrah*. The root meaning is ‘mixed’.

⁴² One who is mixed up, or confused.

the false and impermanent; thus he has become implicated in the intelligence to judge wrongly.⁴³

Citrā: “Sakhī TuṅgaVidyē! Now please elaborate on the imports of the composition *SandhiCatuṣṭay* and its corollaries.”

TuṅgaVidyā: “Since among us, Lalitā is most expert in expanding upon these subjects, let her be so kind as to delineate them before us.”

Lalitā: “I have never even heard of these discourses. It is TuṅgaVidyā who is most familiar with these topics and therefore she is the most qualified to expound upon this subject before us.”

Citrā: “TuṅgaVidyē! We would be honoured if you would please explain to us this lore.”

Thereupon, the favourite of Śrī Rādhikā, TuṅgaVidyā, who was too shy to say anything herself, considered that this subject was best breached by another. So she smiled and signalled with her eyes to the comedienne, TuṅgaNarmā, the daughter of the best of earthly actors, who is the apple of Rādhā’s eyes [the emblem of Rādhā’s delight], and who without being told by any other person knows exactly how to bring about Rādhā’s happiness. Thus the sweetly smiling TuṅgaNarmā stepped slightly forward, and while looking at my smiling face, addressed Citrā,

“Citrē! We are not particularly adept in the inner meanings of these abstruse topics, but I was present when that *apsarā* came here on repeated occasions to eagerly

⁴³ The Sanskrit word here is *sadasad vicār*. *Sadasad* is a combination of *sad* and *asad* or, good and evil, right and wrong, truth or falsehood. When joined together, the entire word means discrimination between good and bad. But, after consideration of the maxim, “between former and latter precepts the latter is more important,” then we are left with only *asad vicār*, or, bad judgement, wherein *pañḍā* is clearly existing. Thus the Paṇḍit must necessarily become implicated in the same. The title is appropriate in light of the Paṇḍit’s first name, *Alika*, or illusion, falsehood, etc.

narrate before TuṅgaVidyā and ourselves, the subject matter of the four commentaries which she had humbly studied under that most propitious and appropriately named, the eminent Mr. Miśra, whom she has satisfied completely by her fount of enthusiasm. That which she described before us, with attention to all details, I will now briefly reiterate before you. Please hear me:

“First of all, she explained that the word *sandhi* refers to the alliances and unions that take place between youthful couples. The development (*vr̥tti*) of *sandhi* comes through trysts and assignation (*abhisāra*- rendezvous, or secret meeting of lovers), and through the resolving of quarrels and complaints, either personally or by ones’ messenger.

“The word *catuṣṭaya* in the title (*Sandhi Catuṣṭay*) refers to the four categories of erotic activity: touching of the breasts, embracing, kissing and drinking the nectar of the lover’s lips. The development (*vr̥tti*) of these erotic acts includes: bruising with the nails, binding the other person’s arms and related sports, covering the cheeks with wanton kisses and biting with expertise.

“The word ‘*ākḥāyṭa*’ refers to the arts of conducting pleasant or amusing conversation. This involves some specific techniques applied for the purpose of defeating one’s companion by using *prahelikā* (riddles with concealed meanings) etc.”

Citrā smiled, “TuṅgaNarmān! Having so expertly explained these unprecedented and previously unheard topics, please be kind enough to describe to us what is meant by *kṛd-vr̥tti*.”

TuṅgaNarmā: “Because it is the giver of so much ecstasy, the form of enjoyment known as *sambhog* (union), is called as such, *ānanda-kṛt*. Its developments (*vr̥tti*) are hissing sounds and amorous cries, closing of the eyes, etc. KalāpaPriya, the

origin of KāntaDarpĀcārya and the other incarnations, the young prince of mystic potencies who wrote the esoteric portions of the *Kalāp-vyākaran* (a Sanskrit grammar), due to the deliciousness and mystery of the activities which caused his descent, has here secretly revealed some small part of that knowledge under another name. He has done so, however, only in an unapparent and unclear fashion, entering into very detailed discussions with the witty and intelligent sakhīs, he reveals his thoughts through disguised gestures and figurative, ambiguous and paradoxical puns. These can be understood only by persons like yourselves, who are very astute, versed in aesthetics, affectionate, discerning and gentle, through detailed discussions in the company of your girlfriends, who are deserving enough to fully perceive the inner meaning of these discussions.”

ChampakLatā smiled, “TuṅgaVidye! This Bhaṭṭapad has only two arms, and they are very delicate at that. How is it then, that he was able to write four commentaries at the same time?”

TuṅgaVidyā: “*Mugdhe!* [Oh enchanted one! or, Foolish one! Stupid!] This Bhaṭṭapad is such a master magician that he is also able to manifest four arms!”

Lalitā: “Yes! Yes! On the occasion of the Spring Rāsollas festival, near the RāsaSthali, within a kuñj in the middle of the forest named Praviṣṭak, after first veiling his own sweetness and suavity of manners (which would give his identity away), he did indeed manifest four arms by the power of his enchantment [*kuhaka*], with the intended purpose of plundering the precious jewel of others’ beautiful women and deceiving any number of young cowherd girls [*vallabi vṛnda*].”⁴⁴

⁴⁴ This incident is based on a verse by Rūpa Gosvāmin from *LalitāMādhava* (6.14), used to illustrate the gopīs attachment to the form of Kṛṣṇa alone. The verse has been quoted and expanded upon by Kṛṣṇadās Kavirāj in his *CaitanyaCaritāmṛta* (i.17.279).

Viśākhā: “Actually, all of these activities have expanded from the influence of his magic. While enjoying pleasant and amusing conversations with his beloved Rādhā in the assembly of the sakhīs, he seeks, through the charms of his erudition, to overcome them, weaving an ever-increasing web of illusion around them with the help of so many prose and poetic devices. As of late, we have also seen, that as his magic continues to grow, his two feet do also.”⁴⁵

Sudevī: “Viśākhē! Why is it that the authors of these four treatises have applied themselves in only one subject matter?”⁴⁶

NāndīMukhī: “Sudevī! Did you not hear the brief description that was given by TuṅgaNarmā?”

Sudevī: “At that time I was distracted with thoughts of our dear friend who is in Jāb at present, ⁴⁷ and so I did not follow everything. Please be so kind as to explain it all to me again.”

NāndīMukhī: “Sudevī! Listen carefully! All four of these persons are in actuality the same person: this one young bachelor of the name Kuhak Bhaṭṭa. For the purpose of performing his variegated pleasure pastimes, he has, by the influence of his very developed powers of delusion, ascended to the rank of KāntaDarpĀcārya, by manifesting one form, and has taken the title Śhyāmal Miśra, by assuming another. Moreover, you should know that Alīk RājPaṇḍit (the visionary Paṇḍit) is not a distinct personality from Śhyāmal Miśra. This

⁴⁵ The word for foot, or *pad*, also means employment; this is a pun which indicates that now he is also trying to expand his activities and influence through doing business. *Vṛiddhi*, meaning ‘growth’ or ‘expansion’ can also be taken as ‘usury’.

⁴⁶ “How is it that in practically all of the four departments of knowledge discussed by this author of scripture, we see only one profession, through-in and throughout?”

⁴⁷apr “At that time I was distracted with watching the *priyasakhīs* from Jāb” [Jābat / Yāvaṭa, the village of Rādhā’s so-called husband, Abhimanyu].

young bachelor, ŚhyāmalĀcārya, is always very religiously inclined. Therefore, in order to experience further exultation of his wanton dalliance, he has assumed this alias of Alīk RājPaṇḍit. Having done so, he now delights in his wayward pastimes as much as he pleases, bringing tumultuous ecstasy to his friends and himself, through a variety of amorous diversions.”

Thereupon I had to say something, “Hung Ho! [Ho! Hallo! Hold on there!] If it is that all of these graceful, lovely four-armed forms, full of amorous gestures, have appeared due to the influence of my mystic perfections, then, consequently, it is only by the power of the inferior magic of these stupid, hot-tempered, female magicians, that they are able to continue to spout out this nonsensical pack of lies.”

They replied to my remark, “This *siddhagoswāmin* (perfected sense-controller) has effected his own imaginary mystic powers by his own influence and now compliments himself before us, after first having assessed his own glorious position with his own mouth.”

Finding fervour and strength in numbers the sakhīs all laughed in joyous delight.

I said to myself, ‘Bho! [O ho!] Well well, isn’t this astonishing? These talkative young girls [*vallabī vrinda*] have very neatly and methodically summed me up as a specious fool (illusionist).’

Due to my embarrassment I considered the matter carefully, and having come up with a plan, I signalled with my hands, indicating that I couldn’t hear what they had said, as I smiled to them, “Ayi! (used in addressing a female) Lo! Oh you enchanting and wanton young girls, blinded by your newly found youth. If you are lacking in confidence relating to matters regarding my mystic perfection, then I will exhibit the same in front of all of you, by first manifesting my form

as a necklace (or forest flower garland) around the neck of ChampakLatā.”

As I approached ChampakLatā with these words, MadhuMaṅgal called to me, “He Bayasya! You are a saintly sage! It is not at all proper for you to touch other women!”

Being thus dissuaded by these joking words from my friend, I said to him, “Sakhe! Close contact between two perfected persons (a male and female adept) is only for the purpose of mutually attaining great ecstasy!

“Just as Devarsi Narada has said,
‘paramānandalābhay svayuthyāmeva samśraye’ -
*To attain the greatest happiness it is,
that friends of the same feather flock together.*”

Everyone laughed heartily to hear these words of mine, attaining at the same time various ecstatic symptoms (beginning with trembling) in their bodies, due to excessive mirth. ChampakLatā, however, became as though enveloped in a dark cloud of great fear. She immediately fled from the spot, taking shelter in the kuṇj where Śrīmatī Rādhikā was hiding, practically merging into her body while tightly hugging her from behind.

I let the pearls fall through my fingers as I spoke to Citrā, “Ayi! Citre! Please come here to hear the price of these pearls. Your dearest friend [*prāṇpreṣṭha sakhī*] Rādhikā, has told me that you are very expert at dressing and decorating with various ornaments [*śṛṅgār*], and that you have many wonderful ornaments in a chest for this purpose. Therefore you should tastefully decorate all of my limbs with these ornaments, in as many different ways as you can think of.”⁴⁸

⁴⁸ The word *Śṛṅgar* means: erotic sentiment; amorous passion; love; coition; toilet; marking with vermilion and sandal paste; and red lead. Therefore, an implied meaning is, “Because I have heard that you are very expert at making love, and that your delicate form is possessed of such exquisite beauty just suitable for accomplishing the same, you should now apply this expertise in decorating my body with such erotic passions.”

“I will in turn satisfy you, by decorating those two golden pots on your bosom with crescent moons (nail marks) and various scented, flowering creepers. I will in this way also bring the greatest delight to your dear friend (priyasakhī Rādhikā), to whom I will certainly describe all of your artful ways.”

Citrā replied in a huff, completely filled with anger, “Ohe! (Hmff!) Oh you who are continually possessed by that horrible and wrathful goddess, empassioned by your outrageous deceptions! Aye! Oh emperor of the city of the most cunning and knavish knights, famous in all the three worlds as the most arrogant amongst hundreds and thousands of billions of the greatest rogues and cheats that ever existed! Oh you who so quickly go to dance with the female relatives of the deer at the cottage of Sakota! Let them who are just suitable for your purposes and so qualified at the above-mentioned activities, decorate you to their full satisfaction. Then, after you have sung their praises in a sweet voice with sufficient hyperbole, you should, my lord, hastily depart from here!” ⁴⁹

All of the gopīs faces lit up with laughter to hear these words of Citrā, as they applauded her enthusiastically.

⁴⁹ “You have become such a mischievous and grotesque wolf (in sheep’s clothing), there being no end to your wrathful and wicked ways. Aye! Oh emperor of the city of the most cunning and knavish knights, famous in all the three worlds as the most arrogant amongst hundreds and thousands of billions of the greatest rogues and cheats that ever existed! Oh you who like to make the forest deer dance, as soon as the opportunity presents itself, in the form of a safe and secluded forest garden.”

There are a few other possibilities in the translation of this line: First off, the context is that of a long string of epithets being used to address Kṛṣṇa. Now here he is being called a *nat*; which means dancer, as well as lewd person. Depending on the juxtaposition of the words, he is either a dancer, the best dancer of the female relatives of the deer, (though this can also be taken in another way, laden with even more sarcasm), a dancer to entertain the noblest female relatives of the deer, or one who makes them dance. The best dancer of the deer [*kul-nut*] is sarcastic, because, whereas *kul* is a word denoting aristocracy, *nat* can carry the connotation of lewdness pertaining to philanderers.

Thereupon NāndīMukhī spoke up, “He Gokul Maṅgal! Your moon-like face is the only medicine which enables the residents of Gokul to sustain their lives. To see you, who are the only source of our long lives, suddenly looking so brokenhearted and dejected, a burning pain is welling up in our hearts, as though a malignant cancer had penetrated to our most vital part. Therefore you must certainly tell us, please, what is the cause of all this. Then only can Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī promptly remedy the situation, so that you, who are endowed with such beauty and fortune, will be pleased. Thus, will our hearts also be blessed.”

Having heard this synopsis of the situation, I replied, like one whose mind is fully prostrated (mentally incapacitated; dazed and confused; overwhelmed), “NāndīMukhī! Please hear me:

“She who possesses such fine intelligence, never before seen or heard of; whose wit and humour are so fascinating that they completely captivate the mind; whose study of the most incomprehensible facetiousness has placed her as the primal preceptor in this line* the personified form of the treasure chest of the rarest jewels in the shape of the most auspicious qualities; whose nectarean speech, scented with the sweet camphor of her smile, like condensed cream of the most fragrant ambrosia, is the life subsistence of her attendants; whose exceedingly good fortune is paid homage to by the most fortunate damsels of the heavenly regions, headed by Śacī, the wife of Indra; the radiant loveliness of the tips of whose nails is continually searched out by Indirā [Laxmī] and the other fawn-eyed nymphs of fair complexion, as the emblem or source of all beauty; whose lotus feet are worshipped by hundreds and thousands of Laxmīs, the Goddesses of innumerable universes, who are themselves worshipped by

*the first *ācārya* of the Veda dealing with the whole diversity of mirthful sports (cutting jokes);

all the demigods, men, Gāndharvās, Vidyādhara and munis; whose *abhishek* [coronary bath] is performed on a jewelled *simhāsan* [lion throne] at MahāYogaPīṭh, within the forest of Vrindāban, the expanse of which completely dwarfs the whole of all the Vaikuṇṭha planets and the spiritual sky itself; the two syllables of whose name, Rādhā, produced from the churning of an ocean of nectar, are actually the condensed form of the cream of that ambrosia, which was produced in two pots,* and it is the transformation of that ambrosia (in the form of the name Rādhā) which felicitates and gratifies the fourteen worlds.†

“The feet of this most renowned Devī, continually perfumed with the sweetest fragrance, infinitely, boundlessly beautiful and incomparably soft, put to shame, by their dawn-like, pinkish colour, the combined elegance of the total aggregate of all red lotus flowers. The service of feet such as these is life itself to me. But this Rādhā is not openly and unhesitatingly calling to me, who am so expert in all branches of service, to bestow upon me this service which I so much long for. Therefore, she doesn’t love me. Having determined this, I shall now seek out the aptly named TuṅgaVidyā,‡ who, I have heard from Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī, is (a plenary form) the selfsame form as Rādhā, and request her to immediately initiate me as her disciple, that by this process I might achieve my most cherished object of desire. I will request her to initiate me with the mantra of MahāDevī (the great goddess, Rādhā). I take shelter of you, the matchless disciple of Bhagavatī, that this endeavour may be successful.”⁵⁰

*the churning of the milk ocean produced only one pot of nectar

†The word used here for gratifies, is *sitakarita*, which means literally: amorous cries.

‡*Tuṅga*- lofty, elevated; *vidyā*- learning, education

⁵⁰ There is an implied meaning. The matchless disciple of Bhagavatī can also mean: who is non-different than Bhagavatī. Thus, by accepting initiation from TuṅgaVidyā, Kṛṣṇa becomes non-different from her, and therefore eligible to receive Rādhārāṇī’s favour, or, in another sense, he then can become one with Rādhā, since TuṅgaVidyā is the self-same form as Rādhā. Things equal to the same thing become equal to each other: A=B, B=C therefore A=C

NāndīMukhī laughed, “*He Sulaksan!* [Oh you who are endowed with auspicious bodily signs!] In that case, you have to do that which has been ascertained by those conversant with scripture to be the first duty of an aspiring disciple. You must serve the guru.”

I replied, “Well spoken! But it is also appropriate that the prospective guru and śiṣya first examine one another.* Then, for three nights, in some secluded kuñj, let TuṅgaVidyā attain her fame by showing her prowess in learning before me. This should be accomplished by sometimes transforming me into a female, and then back again into a male. Thereupon, I, having naturally become a great believer in her, will very reverently and with the utmost regard, decorate her feet with *jāvak* (vermilion), massage her hips†, scratch the itch on her bosom, braid her hair (after having first, of course, undone it) and in this way worship her, rendering whatever other services she may desire, which may even make all the aforementioned services seem very negligible and paltry indeed. If I am able to do all of this, then she will no doubt be very satisfied with me and say, ‘You have given me the utmost pleasure by your willing, service attitude.’

“Having said this and other similarly sweet things to me she will then establish me on the dais within ManoBhavānanda kuñj (the bower which gives the joy of lovemaking). Feeling great delight within her mind, she will address me, “*He Vicakṣan!* [Oh wise and experienced one!] With your two hands you should first smear these two golden, auspicious waterpots on my chest with musk and *kunkum* [saffron], and then adorn them with garlands of jewels and flowers.

*Another play on words. The word for appropriate: *sangata*, also means: joined or united. Thus, “The guru and śiṣya should first test each other by uniting together.”

†Again a variety of equivocal meanings present themselves: the actual word used is *Sronimarddan*: *Sroni*- hip, loins, waist; *marddan*- rub, grind, thrash, press, squeeze

“After having established the two auspicious pots (*mangal ghat*) according to the proper formulas, by these instructions and various other mantras she will then bless me with the *mahāprasād* from her bosom, by anointing my forehead and other limbs with kunkum tilok. Then she will write on my chest with musk the syllables of the mantra of MahāDevī and mark my arms with the symbols of her lotus feet and other auspicious impressions. After removing her own single-stranded pearl necklace and placing it around my neck, TuṅgaVidyā, the *āgama ācārya*, will begin the sixfold *aṅganyāsa* ritual by placing her breasts on my chest, her two creeper-like arms on my shoulders, her lips on my mouth, and other limbs in the proper order, all of which is unknown to me who am completely ignorant of the various parts of the esoteric scriptures (*āgamas*).^{*} After these indispensable antecedents (performing the six-fold *aṅganyāsa* ritual; applying mantras to the various parts of the body through touch and sound) have been completed, she will then continue the preparatory rituals, saying, ‘This six-syllable king of all mantras has now been invested with the ‘self-born’ seer Svayambhū as its *ṛsi*, *gāyatri* as its metre, its titular Deity, Śrī Gāndharvā and the Divine energy of the first mystic seed syllable with its dot (*klim*), that the desired perfection may be obtained, namely, the generation of amorous union between the worshipful object and the worshipper.’

“Then TuṅgaVidyā will show me how to meditate on my tutelary Deity for a very long time by teaching me the following verses:

“Her very being overflowing with exultation,
by the banks of her own *Kuṇḍ*, in a clearing within the *kuṇḍ*,
She is dancing in such an amusing fashion,
exhibiting such an abundance of gestures and postures,
just to bring delight to her *sakhīs*, who are assembled there
to watch her.”

^{*}“She will perform *aṅganyāsa* on my two breasts, my two shoulders, my two arms and my mouth, with her lips.”

“She is very fair and is wearing red-coloured garments.
Her face is lit up with a slight smile.
Her eyes are extremely beautiful,
in fact she is the most exquisite and delectable feast
for the eyes.
I take shelter of Śrī Rādhikā, my worshipful Deity,
The personification of the erotic sentiment (Śyāmā),⁵¹
Who alone can achieve the fulfillment of Śyāma’s desires.”

“Having caused me to meditate on my tutelary Deity in this way, may TuṅgaVidyā then kindly bestow upon me, who am *kāmi* [desirous or, lascivious], the king of all mantras, joined at the beginning and at the end with the *Kāmbijā*, (the sacred syllable of the God of love). Please make my life a success, by initiating me with this mantra. May she also instruct me in the recital of the king of all panegyrics to Śrī Rādhā:

“Her body, the veritable form of *MahāBhāva*,
conceived by the most resplendent *cintāmani* gem,
and anointed with the sweet-scented love and intimate
friendship of her *sakhīs*,
shines with an inconceivable, lustrous splendour.

“She bathes in the morning in waves of the nectar of
compassion,
at noon in a nectar shower of youthfulness
and in the evening in a flood of the nectar of charming
loveliness.
The Goddess of Fortune, LaxmīDevī,
languors in lassitude by the side of her blazing effulgence.

“Her graceful form is covered by the silken garment of
shyness,
decorated with the *kuṅkum* (saffron) of graceful beauty,
and dappled with the black musk of erotic sentiments for
Śyāma.

⁵¹ Śyāmā- This word is often translated to mean, ‘a golden-skinned woman who is cool to the embrace in summer, warm in winter, and attractive to her lover’. It is also an epithet of Rādhā which carries with it the import given in the translation. Śyāma is the colour of the erotic sentiment.

“She puts on her natural ornaments,
fashioned from the best nine jewels:
shivering, tears in the eyes, horripilation
[standing up of the bodily hairs],
becoming stunned, perspiration, faltering of the voice,
blushing, madness and inertness.

“She is garlanded with flowers of wonderful qualities,
such as her sweet-tongued speech.
Her garments are cleansed and purified with the camphor
of her sometimes sober and sometimes restless moods,⁵²
brought about by ecstatic emotions.

“Her imperceptible and incomprehensible *mān*
(*amour-propre*, pique; feigned resentment out of love)
is restrained,
confined and concealed within the coils of her hair.
Her brilliant *tilok* is the emblem
of her immense good fortune.
Hearing Kṛṣṇa’s name and qualities are the ornaments
swinging in splendour and jubilation from her ears.

“The reddish colour of her lips
is produced from the *tāmbūl* (*pan*)
of her great attachment (obsession) for Kṛṣṇa.
The black ointment (collyrium) of her eyes [*kajjal*],
is the crookedness of her loving affairs [*prem-kautilya*].
Her body is perfumed by the camphor of her sweet smile,
while hearing the joking words of her *sakhīs*.

“Within the inner apartments of her bodily fragrance
is a bed of pride.
Here she sometimes sits in willful and wanton moods
(as though unconscious),
while wearing the restless necklace of *prem-vaicittya*
(separation from her lover, felt even in union),
beautified by a locket of humiliation.

“Her breasts are concealed,
bound with a bodice of wounded vanity
(sensitive love; sham anger in love, *mān*).
The sounds of her *vīṇa*, her fame and beauty,
dry up the faces and hearts of her competitors in love.

⁵² Dhīrādhīrā (UN 5.39; 5.59)

“She has taken up the most amorous posture,
leaning with her lotus hands
on the shoulders of her *sakhī* friend
[adolescence personified],
just before beginning to distribute the honey
of Cupid’s infatuation and intoxication,
(infatuated love for Kṛṣṇa,
{herself} the personification of the erotic sentiment.)
which is itself the remembrance of
the pleasure pastimes of ŚyāmāŚyāma.

“Please bring back to life this very sombre somebody,
who is bowing down before you with a straw in his teeth,
by sprinkling him with the nectar of your servitorship.

“He Gāndhārvike!

A truly compassionate person will not reject even a rascal
if he is surrendered to him/her.

Hai ! [Oh my!]

Therefore, please never abandon this person,
who is similarly surrendered to you.

“That person, who recites this *stava* [hymn],
of the name *PremāmbhojMaranda*⁵³
(the nectar of the lotus of love),
produced of her mercy,
will surely attain service at her lotus feet.”

“May this hymn also advise and counsel me.”

“Then, with the words, ‘*I have received that most cherished object of my desire from Śrī Gurudeva,*’* choked up in my throat and my body trembling, I will fall down at her lotus feet. Then she will most certainly pick me up and embrace me, herself thrilling with ecstasy, while she places the remnants of her chewed *tāmbūl prasād*, saturated with the nectar of her lips, into my mouth. But if you say that I am a *brahmacārī* and therefore it is not proper for me to take *tāmbūl*, then she may

⁵³ *The Nectar of the Lotus of Love* - this prayer was composed by Śrīla Raghunāth das Gosvāmī. Kṛṣṇadās Kavirāj paraphrases these verses in *CaitanyaCaritāmṛta*, ii.8.

**Kām* is the name of the *bija* mantra, and means, as well, desire)

give me the remnants of her own *mukhabās*,* scented with camphor.”

“Thereafter, coming to the realisation that my life is now successful, I will present as *dakṣiṇa*† these most cherished pearls, along with heaps and piles of many other varieties of pearl fruits. By accepting these she will demonstrate that her favour is upon me.”

The gopīs all giggled as they looked at TuṅgaVidyā. She was gushing as she tried to conceal her inner ecstasy by knitting her eyebrows into a great frown and giving me a sidelong glance laced with apparent fury. She called out to NāndīMukhī, “Ayi! NāndīMukhī! You are a perfected renunciant, therefore you should initiate him according to this procedure. If the mantra is received from some perfected person who has developed mystic powers, then the desired result [*kāma*] will be accomplished very quickly.”

Saying this much, she was preparing to leave in a great huff to go home, when Viśākhā caught hold of her and brought her back. Viśākhā laughed as she spoke, “NāndīMukhī! Actually it would be a contrary course to initiate this offensive character. For this reason the *ācārya*, TuṅgaVidyā, is angry with you.”

NāndīMukhī: “Ayi! You liar Viśākhā. How is it you are prepared to cast these false aspersions against the saintly son of the King of Gokul, Śrī Nanda, best friend of the lotus of religion?”

Viśākhā: “I assure you! He is guilty of having committed a major transgression.”

NāndīMukhī: “What exactly is this transgression?”

Viśākhā: “Eating that which has already been tasted by another.”

**mukhabās*; *mukhsuddhi*- like an after dinner mint; something to scent the mouth after having taken a meal

† alms given to the guru after receiving initiation

NāndīMukhī: “Tasting someone’s remnants? Whose remnants?”

Viśākhā: “A maidservant’s.”

NāndīMukhī laughed, “And who might this maidservant be?”

Viśākhā: “There is a certain resident of the forest of Sakhoṭ,* who, by the power of illusion, has taken the form of a *gopikā*. She was seen going to the house of Candrāvalī, the wife of the servant of Kamsa, Govardhan Malla. Indeed, the following conversation was overheard there:

“Ayi! Candrāvalī! You are the dearest servant of the Goddess of the universe, Caṇḍikā, and I am also one of her attendants. Due to my overwhelming affection for you, I am desirous of becoming your friend.

To which Candrāvalī replied, ‘That sounds reasonable,’ and, saying thus, she embraced that person whose friendship she had just accepted. That is the maidservant I am talking about!”

NāndīMukhī: “But who is that person?!”

Viśākhā: “This extraordinary Goddess of Wealth is renowned far and wide. I’m sure you must know of her.”

NāndīMukhī: “What are her remnants that you spoke of?”

Viśākhā: “The ultimate purifying nectar, that abides in a small, black, inferior, oil pouch.”⁵⁴

Rādhikā smiled to hear this and all of the *gopīs* laughed when they saw her smiling face.

*known today as Śyāorā; perhaps a corruption of Sakhisthali, the residence of Candrāvalī, the chief competitor of Rādhā

⁵⁴ Generally translators take the meaning of *adhora* as lips, implying that the nectar has come from the maidservant’s lips, however, another meaning of *adhora* is inferior. *Kupi*-[a long leather pouch with a narrow opening for keeping oil in.] *Paramapavanam* can mean either ‘supremely purifying’ or ‘most contaminated’.

NāndiMukhī: “Ayi! Viśākhe! Has anyone seen this?”

Viśākhā: “Of course! What do you think?”

NāndiMukhī: “Who?”

Viśākhā: “The two gopīs Mallī and Bhṛṅgī, when they were sent by Priyasakhī Gāndharvā, to fetch some saffron cloth. Just the day before yesterday, they saw all of these sublimely purifying activities going on near MānasīGaṅgā, on the barren and saline banks there. Then, when they returned, they discussed what they had seen with all the other gopīs.”

NāndiMukhī became very thoughtful as she said, “Kṛṣṇa is the life of all Gokul. How can this fault of his be exonerated?”

Viśākhā replied, “By observing some rites of atonement.”

NāndiMukhī: “Then let Bhagavatī determine the proper penance, so that Puruṣottam (the supreme male) can be acquitted of his crimes. Then after some provision is made for his purification, you can initiate him.”

ChampakLatā spoke up, “Mugdhe! The method of atoning for this sin has already been explained in the *UjjvalamaṇiSamhitā*. You must have never seen this book and only for this reason you brought up Bhagavatī’s name.”

NāndiMukhī: “So who here knows this *Samhitā*?”

ChampakLatā: “Only priyasakhī Gāndharvā.”

NāndiMukhī: “But she is not here amongst this assembly just now. Therefore how can this penance be performed without excessive delay?”

Viśākhā: “Lalitā is the second Gāndharvā, her very self-same form. Having studied this *Samhita* under her [Rādhā], along with all of its related treatises, she is now quite proficient in this subject due to the fact that she continually reads it again and again. She can therefore easily determine what a proper arrangement is.”

NāndīMukhī, sarcastically imitating a mood of supplication, replied, “Sakhī Lalite! After carefully considering the matter, please be so kind as to instruct us in these affairs regarding atonement.”

Lalitā smiled slightly, “Priyasakhī! If the guilty party comes himself into the midst of this assembly and informs those of us present, giving a complete and straightforward account of his crimes, and if he feels repentant for what he has done, then that is itself atonement. In this way have the wise and learned authors of the *Purāṇas* decreed:

*‘Whoever feels remorse for his crimes
after having confessed them before a council
is fully pardoned.
This is the encomium given by the munis
in the dharma śāstras.’*

Hearing this, NāndīMukhī looked at me with emphatic intention. I then came before Lalitā with Subal and MadhuMaṅgal, but as I expressed my desire to say something...

Viśākhā said, “*He Virvara!* [Oh best of heroes!] Lustful persons have neither shame nor antipathy [self-mortification]. Because of this, you have done whatever you have done, due to your naturally libidinous nature. Yet now, after careful consideration, you should divulge everything here in front of Lalitā.”

This time I hid my smile as I spoke like one thoroughly regretful of his past misdeeds, “Lalite! Four days ago, when I was looking for some of my cows who had strayed away, I came to Gaurī Tīrtha,* where I saw a certain Carcikā, a companion of the goddess Gaurī, coming out of her temple. Suddenly, she came and struck me on the chest with her left breast and then, after taking me within the Mādhavī garden

*Rādhā’s rival, Candrāvalī, daily worships the goddess Gaurī at this particular spot

house, she forced the remnants of her chewed *tāmbūl* between my trembling lips. What more she did I cannot say exactly, since I was in a state of shock, and now cannot remember everything very clearly.

“Then again, just the day before yesterday, I was carrying a flower garland strung with golden thread and a variety of forest flowers, completely absorbed in thoughts of my sweetheart, Gāndharvā, the mistress of the bowers [*nikuñja*] on the shores of RādhāKuṇḍ, when I wandered into MandāraUdyan,⁵⁵ just by the side of MālyaHaraṇ Kuṇḍ [Lake of Stolen Garlands]. Just then who should appear on the scene there but that same *carcikā* [‘highly perfumed one’], who again forcefully kissed me on my left cheek and entrusted the nectar of her lips unto my mouth. So that these two sinful and wicked activities might be annulled, please give your permission for me to drink the honey remnants of her lotus mouth.”

MadhuMaṅgal laughed, “Bayasya! This is indeed an excellent means of atonement; especially since it contributes to the further increase and expansion of the sinful activity itself!”

I replied, “*Murkha!* [You fool!] Fie on you! Don’t you know anything? ‘The best medicine to counteract poison is poison itself.’ It is also said:

*‘A boil burns with a pain produced of heat [fire],
but it is again by fire that this pain is checked.’* And also-
*‘Those who are intelligent know that the best remedy for a
soft foot, pierced by a thorn,
is to remove that thorn with another thorn.’*

In pursuance of these proofs, the best means of righting the wrong of tasting someone’s remnants is to again taste remnants [*ucchiṣṭa bhojan*].”

⁵⁵ Slow and Gentle Gardens; Coral Tree Gardens; Mandāra- one of the five heavenly trees said to be present in Indra’s gardens. *Erythrica Indica*.

MadhuMaṅgal: “Since you are the only physician qualified to cure the disease of such sins as these, why then do you bother following Lalitā’s directions at all?”

I replied, “Sakhe! It is also said:

*Even though one may be extremely knowledgeable
about a variety of subject matters, still,
in matters pertaining to his own personal affairs
he might have some uncertainty.
Therefore, the medical treatment of a doctor
is best effected by other doctors.”*

Lalitā laughed, “He Deva! Alliance with a Devī [demigoddess] is accomplished only by another deva [demigod] (like you). We are only human beings. How will we even be able to perceive this Devī (Carcikā)?”

I replied, “Ayi! Lalite! Having accepted a human form, isn’t she present somewhere very close by?”

At this their curiosity was greatly stimulated, yet they remained very apprehensive as they all began to whisper to each other, “Who is he talking about?”

Rādhā said to herself, “It would appear that this crest jewel amongst the most cunning of all charlatans is about to express some embarrassing joke right in front of all those assembled here?”

Viśākhā: “Deva! Please tell us. Where is this Devī? Only if you tell us can we then, after properly praising her by the recitation of various hymns and prayers, bring her into the midst of this assembly, and thus quickly see to the execution of your atonement.”

I replied, “Viśākhe! That Devī is present within your assembly, resembling as she does a streak of lightning. Though you possess very beautiful eyes, like the expanded petals of a lotus, I think you must be blind.”

Having heard these words of mine, filled with the deepest profundity and gravity, Lalitā and the other *sakhīs* were completely filled with apprehension. They were all thinking, “He is probably referring to me and is about to make some more funny and embarrassing remarks!”

While thus absorbed in the midst of various doubts and hesitations, all the while looking each other up and down, Viśākhā interjected, “*He lampat!* [You debauch!] Is that *Devī ChampakLatā?*”

I replied, “Na. Na.”

Viśākhā: “Then Jyeṣṭhā?”

Me: “No, not Jyeṣṭhā.”

Subal spoke up, “Then it must be either RaṅgaDevī or Sudevī.”

Me: “Nope. Neither of them either.”

Viśākhā: “Then it must be the pardon officer herself, Lalitā.”

I replied, “Viśākhe! It is not Lalitā either.”

Viśākhā: “Not this one, not that one, not the other one, not so-and-so. Then what! Has she just vanished from here, then?”

I replied, “*Dhurte!* [You impostor!] You know who it is! Just think!”

Lalitā said, “*Hai, Hai!* [Oh my!] Sakhī Viśākhe! Hurry up! This poor lecher can’t wait much longer. Help this helpless fellow to get his business over with.”*

Viśākhā acted like she was thinking for awhile, and then said, “Lalite! The person whom I am thinking of is neither a *Devī* [demigoddess] nor a human being.”

*or, “You’re simply helping this lecher by keeping us in this unnerved and distraught state. Hurry up and get it out of him!”

NāndīMukhī: “Then who is there within this assembly who is neither a *Devī* nor a human being?”

Viśākhā: “A fairy (*śaṅkhinī*)!”

Lalitā: “Who is that?”

Viśākhā: “That scurrilous Padmā with whom Kṛṣṇa has been engaged in some very unpleasant acts.”

TuṅgaVidyā: “Sakhī Viśākhe! Why do you blacken her name by saying, ‘That *śaṅkhinī*?’⁵⁶ She is very devoted to Goddess Katyāyini and has performed much service for her. By the mercy of Katyāyini Devī she has become non-different from the Devī herself, though she remains concealed.”

Hearing this MadhuMaṅgal and the others laughed. Then I said, “Viśākhe! If, you are feeling any embarrassment due to your previous statement and would like to accuse someone else, then in that case I can divulge another name.”

Viśākhā: “Let’s hear it then!”

I said, “You are that CarcikāDevī.”

Seeing that all the other gopīs got quite a laugh out of this, Viśākhā’s lips were trembling as she replied, “*Aye! Canca!* [Fickle-minded libertine!] *Vanca!* [Cheat!] *He gopa nisthur!* [Oh most cruel of all the cowherds!] Oh you who smeared turmeric all over the body of the wife of Kālīṅga Malla,* the servant of that demon Kāṁsa! When it comes to wisdom, you are just like a great mass of molasses! Because you are so devoid of finesse in the fine art of cleverness, and so greedy for (her) affection, you are reduced to wandering

⁵⁶ In addition to fairy, *śaṅkhinī* also means female ghost [also, one of the four categories into which women are divided (the other three being Padminī, Citrānī and Hastinī)]. Because Kṛṣṇa has tasted the lips of Padmā and Candrāvalī and they are here compared to female ghosts, or, *śaṅkhinī*, low class women (whose lips may have been contaminated by the aforementioned ‘remnants’), therefore he has to atone, and specifically his mouth needs to be purified. Padmā is also a name for the snake goddess, Manasā.

*another name for Govardhan Malla, the husband of Candrāvalī

around in the groves of jujubes,* hoping to find her to play with. Oh worthless husband of PadmāŚaṅkhinī.† Oh best of the merchants, greatest of the cheaters who like to deal in goods captured with the five arrows of Cupid! Though you think you are so clever, you are totally lacking in the necessary skills required for one to perform in this arena. Go and perform your impertinent activities in the chipped rice and molasses market within the forest of Sakhot! [Śyaorā] Go on! Get out of here right now!”

Śrī Rādhā, in her soft and gentle voice, began to praise Viśākhā, “Priyasakhī! Viśākhe! May you be victorious! You have given me the greatest satisfaction by expressing externally exactly what I was thinking within my mind!”

RaṅgaDevī said, “Sakhī Viśākhe! Why are you getting so angry? Sakhī Lalite! While he was supposed to be confessing all of his crimes before us, full of shame and remorse, he took the forest of Sakhot to be a bower of Mādhavī creepers; the dry, salty land on the banks of Mānasī Gaṅgā to be the Mandāra Gardens on the banks of MālyaHaraṇ Kuṇḍ; and the tasted remnants of the ghostly associate of the snake goddess to be the nectar of the lips of Viśākhā. This clever cheat, while saying one thing, actually implies a different, hidden meaning. In this way he has ascribed the different qualities of other objects to you. Therefore, it still remains for you to prescribe his proper atonement.”

Lalitā laughed, “He Arya MadhuMaṅgal! Sakhe Subal! Come and hear what we have in store for your friend.”

Citrā: “Sakhī Lalite! It is said:

*If the offender has any property [if he has any wealth],
then the rule is that his penance should be levied*

*berries; a fruit similar in taste to a crab apple; known as *kul* in Bengali and *ber* in Brijbhāṣa

†Padmā the ghost; female ghost associate of the snake goddess Manasā

*at an increase of four times.
But the sons of kings are only freed
after performing six times the usual penance.*

Remembering these injunctions from the *SmṛtiŚāstras*, you should arrange for his penance.”

Lalitā: “Mugdhe! The last line of that verse from the *Samhita* should read, ‘after performing twice six times the usual penance.’ How did you come up with only six times?”

Citrā: “You are the one who is most proficient in this *śāstra*. Whatever you have understood is certainly the truth. But there have been a number of incidences when this young prince has saved our lives- when he picked up Govardhan hill, for instance; when he saved us from the forest fire; and when he thrashed Śaṅkhacūṛa. In light of this, maybe we should not be so quick to count all of his faults. We could be a little lenient by settling up at six times.”

Lalitā: “Fine! This is the provision I am recommending in accordance with your request. First off, in the matter of delivering him from his sins, he will have to take some ritual baths. This should be performed in Mānasī Gaṅgā for three days. Then, to undo the evil influences upon his mouth, for twenty-one days he shall have to take a dose of the five kinds of nectar [*pancamṛt*] from the lips of Mallī and Bhṛṅgī. Later on we can arrange his acquittance at the rate of twelve times.”

MadhuMaṅgal pretended to be very angry at this, “Lalitike! The son of the King and Queen of Vraja is the veritable bridge of true religion. He is the medicine which sustains not only the life of myself and his other friends, but of all the residents of Gokul. Yet you have now undertaken to destroy his caste by making him taste the remnants of these *ceṭikā* [servant] and Pulinda [*mleccha*; tribal] girls. Therefore I can see no other recourse but to go and immediately inform his mother and father in detail about this. By bringing them

here I will deliver him from this dangerous dilemma. This will also serve to further increase our friendship.”

Saying thus, he muttered to himself as he prepared to run off, but Subal caught hold of him and dissuaded him from going.

Lalitā: “*Anarya bato!* [What a low-born plebeian you really are!] You are simply ignorant of the glories of these two *sakhīs*, our *priyasakhī* Rādhā’s minister of loving affairs and the one named Bhrṅgī. Perhaps then, you should hear of their greatness from the mouth of your NāndīMukhī.”

NāndīMukhī: “Brother MadhuMaṅgal!

govarddhanagirau ramye rādhākuṇḍam priyam hareḥ |
yathā rādhā priya viṣṇostasyah kuṇḍam priyam tathā | |

‘There is a very beautiful mountain of the name, Govardhan, where is to be found RādhāKuṇḍ, very dear to Kṛṣṇa. As Rādhikā is most dear to Śrī Kṛṣṇa, her kuṇḍ is similarly as dear to him.’⁵⁷

Far superior to Vaikuṇṭha is Madhupuri (Mathurā), the place of Kṛṣṇa’s birth. In spite of that, Vrindāvan is even far more excellent as the scene of the Rās festival, a marketplace of ecstasy, the epitome of eternal enjoyment. Within Vrindā’s forest, Govardhan is even greater, for it was held up by Kṛṣṇa’s benevolent hand. Situated by the slopes of GiriGovardhan is Rādhā Kuṇḍ, even more glorious, and whose existence is fully dedicated to flooding the Lord of Gokul with oceans of the nectar of his love. Is there any conscientious soul, averse to worldly pursuits, who will not serve Śrī Śrī Rādhā Kuṇḍ?

(*Śrī Upadeśāmṛta*)

“In light of these and other verses, the seer of the gods and guru of BhagavatīPaurṇamāsī, Śrī Devarṣi, along with many other great sages and eminent saints, has also described the residents of the caves upon Śrī Govardhan, near the southern

⁵⁷ This oft quoted verse is said to originate in the *PadmaPurāṇ*. It is quoted several times in CC i.4.215; ii.8.99; ii.18.8 & *LaghuBhāgavatāmṛta*, 2.45.

bank of Rādhā Kuṇḍ: the Pūrṇas, Pulindyas, Urugāyās, and so forth, as being exceptionally fortunate, glorifying them in majestic terms. The great good fortune of these two girls, the daughters of the king of the Pulinda tribe, who reside in caves on the southern bank of RādhāKuṇḍ, has been further described by Śrī Sukadeva himself in the verse (*BhP* x.21.17), where he states that these tribal girls (*pulindis*) were entirely fulfilled when they rubbed on their bodies the *kuṅkum* dust from the gopīs' breasts which came to be on the forest floor after falling from his feet. In light of these proofs, the words of the śāstras pronounced by these perfected beings, will not the supremely sanctified *pañcāmṛt*, liquefied by the lips of these two daughters of the king of the Pulindyas, Mallī and Bhṛṅgī, destroy the effects of sinful activities? I have more to say! Listen carefully-

“Sometimes Viśākhā and her friends feign shyness, that they might obtain the highest ecstasy by engaging RāṅganMālā and her friends, the other *praṇayī-sakhīs*,⁵⁸ in their most cherished services as maidservants to the new Youthful Couple of Vraja; thus may they listen to the extremely funny conversations that take place between these gentle and soft-spoken gopīs, unaware of the intricacies of conjugal affairs.”

Taking this opportunity, Śrī Gāndharvā summoned Tulasī from the congregation of gopīs by a gesture of her eyes, and then, with the little finger of her right hand, more beautiful than the sweetest scented Campak flower (more beautiful than beauty itself), she took some *sindur** from the part in her hair and with this began to compose a letter according to her own feelings, so that the letters of the words themselves became a herald of the scent and loveliness of a bunch of golden Ketakī flowers. This letter she placed in Tulasī's hand, to be delivered

⁵⁸ loving friends; *PraṇayīSakhī* is the term used by Raghunāth dās Gosvāmī for the mañjarīs, whose activities are summarized briefly in this paragraph.

*red lead, vermilion

to Lalitā and the others.

Thereupon, Lalitā, after touching the letter to her head, went off to read it in secret with the other *sakhīs*. After finishing reading the letter she smiled as she handed it to NāndīMukhī.

NāndīMukhī reacted as though it was a matter of great exultation and began to read the letter aloud, after first holding it to her heart,-

Blessings and prosperity on you all. Śrī NāndīMukhī, Śrī Lalitā, Śrī Viśākhā and all of my prāṇapreṣṭha sakhīs.⁵⁹ After first embracing you and exchanging hundreds and thousands of millions of jokes, a certain lady makes the following submission.

He who achieves the highest happiness while wandering around Govardhan Hill with his cows and friends, such as Śrīdām, Subal, Bhadrāsen and others, and who is the dearest son of the King of Vraja, hundreds and thousands and millions of times more beloved by him than his own life; and who attains the topmost pleasure, playfully lying on a soft mattress, scented with various flowers, which is actually the motherly affection that the Queen of Vrajarāj feels for her son; on the bed inlaid with a great variety of valuable jewels, which are really the manifestation of her life force, multiplied hundreds and thousands of millions of times; within a vast temple, constructed from

⁵⁹ PrāṇaPreṣṭhaSakhīs are Rādhā's girlfriends who are most equal to her in age and qualities. The term is not found in UjjvalNīlamani, where Lalitā etc. are categorized as ParamaPreṣṭhaSakhīs (8.137). PrāṇaSakhīs (8.134) belong to a different category, closer to the mañjarīs, whom Rūpa calls NityaSakhī. Raghunāth's terms, made popular by Narottam Dās, have superseded those of Rūpa.

hundreds and thousands of millions of golden bricks, which are, in reality, nothing more than her body itself— to the image of the little toe of his left foot. I offer āraṭi, taking ten million [arbud] of my prāṇ parārdhā and then again, taking that prāṇ parārdhā arbud† and multiplying it again by hundreds more parārdhā‡ just to fuel the wick of the ghee lamp. My heart is melting like fresh butter to hear that One whose tender and delicate body is so attractive, as though fashioned from a bouquet of blue lotuses perfumed with fresh musk, the lustre of which is like cream, and who is dhur lalit§ will have to engage in such severe penances.*

Lalitā appears to have forgotten this verse from the Ujjvala Saṁhitā:

If persons who are particularly delicate have shown themselves to be genuinely sorry for their acts, and if they are the objects of affection, then their penance should be entirely prescribed by tantra.

Now if this lad of delicate limbs is agreeable, and is still in a penitent mood as regards his previously committed crimes, then the actual prescribed means of his deliverance is by tantra. Having forgotten this part of the Ujjvala Saṁhitā, Lalitā had made some separate arrangement for drinking pañcāmrit, only for the purification of his mouth. In any case, if he can now be made blameless through this system of tantra, by both purifying His mouth and destroying his various other sinful

*life force multiplied hundreds and thousands of millions of times

†arbud- hundred million

‡hundreds and thousands of millions

§that hero, devoid of anxiety, very polite and meek and who is expert at singing and dancing

activities as well, then I will be beside myself with bliss. It would be superfluous to say more.

He should also lovingly embrace Mallī and Bhṛīṅgī, who are as dear to me as my own life.

I would just like to emphasize one point in closing: This young prince is supremely pure, and at the same time, addicted to luxury. Therefore, with His lotus feet he should tread on a flowering creeper taken from an Aśhok tree, and the nectar that exudes from those flowers should be used, in the measurement of twenty-four gandushas, to wash His face. Then pañcāmṛit should be administered to His smiling and camphor-scented lips, very gently and lovingly causing him to drink it. In this way, the sins of this tender young child can be very quickly driven away, effecting his great happiness at one and the same time.*

Having heard these words, like nectar to my ears, my mind was transported to the very outer reaches of ecstasy, as I looked towards the kuñj wherein Śrī Rādhā was seated. Lalitā laughed to see this as she said, “Even though it is true that the sinful reactions of a wicked man are destroyed by his repentance, there still remains something further to be said. Namely,

*‘If there remain any properties,
then the penance should be multiplied four times.
Moreover, ‘especially for the sons of kings
it should be twelve times.’ or,*

*In the case of minor injunctions and specific ones,
the specific injunction is always more important.’*

*one gandusha is approximately equivalent to the amount contained in the spoon of an ācaman cup

According to this logical proof, the proper penance for him was calculated at two times six (or twelve) which conclusion we had reached by different means. Nevertheless, *‘the order of one’s elders [gurujan] is not to be questioned, even if it may be inconsistent.’*

Thus, taking this order upon my head, I will cause his sins to be expiated by the process of tantra.”

Then I said, “The learning of the *śiṣya* is superior to even that of the *guru*.”

At this, Lalitā made a face which perfectly revealed her thoughts, as she said, “NāndīMukhī! This foolish black deer has abandoned the lovely, playful doe [Goddess of Youth], who has thoroughly satisfied the lotus eyes of the residents of Gokul with her liquid loveliness, and who plays at the celebrated place known as Parāsalī,* the constant companion of *parama-rasa-taraṅginī raṅginī*,† to repeatedly run after that apparition,‡ the resident of Sakhīsthali and confidante of Śaivyā (Candrāvalī). This restless and senseless bumblebee has forsaken the lovely jasmine flower, the friend of the Champak creeper (ChampakLatā), that has filled with the sweetest fragrance the four directions in and around the *nikuñj bhavan* (bower residences) surrounding RādhāKuṇḍ, to relentlessly and recklessly pursue the scentless *kuṣmānda*§ creeper that grows in one corner of the yard of Govardhan Malla, by the side of it’s friend the land lotus, (*SthalaPadmā- ArumIndicam*) which grows in the dry, sandy and saline soil there. Because of the ineptness and tactlessness of this dim-witted dolt, the

*corruption of the word *Para-rāsa-sthali*, the site of the *rāsa* dance

†‘She who spends her time, playing in the waves of the topmost, divine mellows’; or, ‘the companion of the gopī named Raṅgavatī, (Śrī Rādhā)

‡mirage / the word for mirage is: *mṛgaṭṛṣṇa*- the thirst of a deer; very appropriate for this allegory

§*Kuṣmānda* means pumpkin, as well as *false conception*

constant companion of Vrindāvaneśvari, namely her naturally pleasant and agreeable repose,* has superficially been saddened and made gloomy so that the sentiments of conjugal love (*syāmala rasa*) are not being nourished.⁶⁰

“Therefore, this ignorant and inexperienced bumblebee needs to be enlightened about the foolishness of his ways, so that he deserts that pumpkin creeper, devoid of the scents of fine sentiments, and instead becomes the devoted follower of the Goddess of Vrindāvan. Then her dear friend [*priyasakhī*], in the form of her amorous pleasure, radiant with contentment, will undoubtedly fulfil his most cherished desires.”

Having been made to drink such a variety of sweet and intoxicating beverages, all scented with the flavour of conjugal affairs, Satyabhāmā said, “Prāṇanāth! Though I am drowning in this ocean of nectar, I am not in the least bit feeling satiated!”

Kṛṣṇa replied, “Priye! It is as if your question has caused the appearance of my dear friend, the King of the Season Springtime, who used to accompany me in my sublime pleasure pastimes within the forests of Gokul.” Saying thusly, he heartily embraced Satyabhāmā.

Satyabhāmā joyfully replied, “Then! Then what happened?!”

Kṛṣṇa continued, “Then Subal laughed as he spoke to me:

“PriyaBayasya! Priyasakhī Indulekhā, by various hints and gestures, sent me here to inform you that her life has been made explicitly uneasy by the constant ranting and raving of her atheistic husband, Bhāsvara. Therefore, I am requesting you to settle the price for her pearls, and then, after presenting

**madhura rati*; amorous affection

⁶⁰ Raghunāth here hints at the relation between *rati* (or *sthāyibhāva*) and *rasa*, as found in most of the works on poetics, including *BhaktiRasāmṛtaSindhu*, ii.1.9; *ratir ānandarūpaiva niyamānā tu rasyatām*

them to her, send her swiftly home that she might properly perform her household duties.”

I replied, “Sakhe Subal! You have spoken correctly. This Indurekhā is so attached to me in loving affection, that even though she is very afraid of her husband, still, she is not able to give up my company. Therefore, please listen carefully to the following assessment of the price she must pay. The aptly named Indurekhā,* unable to tolerate separation from me, should manifest two bodies. One of these can remain in the dark sky of my heart, being etched there with the sharpened nail of her finger. Then I, who am also incapable of enduring separation from her, will rise up, by the power of my mystic science, like two half-moons on the mountains of her chest. There she can keep me within the folds of her cloth, like a poor man keeps a valuable gem that he has found. Thus will she realise the topmost ecstasy by occasionally stealing a glance at me, situated upon the hairs of her body, standing on end. Or, I could remain in her unblemished heart, by remaining there as a lovely, dark deer.”⁶¹

Her lips trembling, Indurekhā shot me a very crooked and tortuous glance, the sight of which made TuṅgaVidyā laugh as she said to me, “*He Nāgor!* [Oh great gallant!] This RaṅgaDevī is also very appropriately named! Therefore, let us hear the evaluation of the price she is to pay.”

*Impression of the Moon, partial moon, sliver of the moon; also, ‘the marks which are left by the nails on the body of one’s lover’

⁶¹ *mṛganka-* [lit.- drawing of a deer] - moon; *mṛgalāncan:* [lit.- sign or emblem of a deer]. The moon in Sanskrit literature is often said to have the mark of a rabbit or a deer on it, just as the English-speaking world has the conceit that there is a man in the moon. This mark is said to be a blemish on the face of the moon, a blemish which is absent from the moon-like face of Indulekhā. Kṛṣṇa thus likens himself to the deer who will reside in the heretofore faultless face of Indulekhā. Indulekhā means literally, ‘a digit of the moon’; and Indurekhā means a ‘line’ or ‘mark’ on/of the moon.

I replied, “Sakhī RaṅgaDevī! Previously, during our Rāsa dance, I was especially delighted while continuously absorbed in watching your dexterity in dancing. Now, within the lonely and secluded compound of this *nikuñja mandir* (bower temple), I am eager to experience a special version of that dance once again. Therefore, please come here and make those two golden waterpots on your bosom dance on my chest, in the ways in which you are so adept, so that I, having been highly pleased by you, may reward you with the nectar of my lips, the most coveted treasure of all the gopīs, thus bestowing the highest happiness upon you too.”

“*Ore bhaṇḍasekhor!* [Oh summit of buffoonery!] Don’t you come near me! Leave me alone!” RaṅgaDevī said as she looked askance at me. Then she ran and hid behind Viśākhā.

Sudevī laughed, “*He Rasik Sekhor!* [Oh summit of wit and merrymaking! so adept at relishing *rasas* (mellows of ecstatic love)!] It is clearly felt that RaṅgaDevī will quickly achieve perfection by relishing this *mahāprasādam*, that which is eternally enjoyed, emancipated and worshipped by the gopīs. Thus it is hoped that she will bestow perfection on all of us also.”

Subal said, “Bayasya! See how Sudevī remains eyeing you, longing to know what price you have ascertained for her pearls!”

I replied, “Sakhe Subal! Since Sudevī is celebrated as being very skilful at throwing dice, we will play a game together, but in order to avoid any cheating or embezzlement, no one amongst you will be able to take sides. The two of us will play by the power of our intuitive intelligence. Now if I am soundly defeated by her, then she can press my chest very tightly with her left breast and drink twice from my lips, which are the whole of my wealth. Or, in the case that I am able to defeat her, then her right breast, very firm to the touch,

will be squeezed by my right hand, as much as I like, and she will have to cause me to drink the nectar of her lips twice.”

Thereupon, Sudevī knitted her eyebrows into a terrible frown as she looked at me and spoke to Viśākhā, her words dripping with malice, “Ayi Viśākhe! This merchant has always been known for trying to bargain with the gold of his facetiousness. Does he know nothing more than joking on and on, forever and forever. Nowadays he has begun speculating in commerce in pearls, but unable to make any profit he has returned to his original business. Therefore all of you should set aside two *parārdhas** of golden coins in the form of the five arrows† he is so much desirous of getting struck with. Let him have as much as he wants from this reserve while we collect all our pearls from him. In the meantime, I’m going home.”

As Anaṅga Mañjarī caught hold of her skirt to prevent her from going, Sudevī again turned towards me, accosting me with her anger as she challenged me, “*Bho! Kelilampat!* [You love-making libertine!] Anaṅga Mañjarī is even more expert at rolling dice. Therefore, you should play dice with her, unless of course you’re worried that she might crumble the mountain of your pride to pieces.”

To these sweet words I replied, “Are you sure? This quiet, little Anaṅga Mañjarī!? A practised dice-thrower? It is true that the dear sister of she who is the personified form of my Kaustubha necklace and the mark of Śrīvatsa, the golden streak on my sapphire chest (Śrīmati Rādhikā), is very affectionate to me. The bumblebee of my mind is similarly so delighted with the sweetness of this Anaṅga Mañjarī that it hovers near her constantly. I am prepared to give her some of my most round,

**parārdha*- hundred, thousand billion

†five arrows- *pancabān*: 1 fascination; 2 excessive excitement; 3 exploitation / extortion; 4 inflammation / heat / affliction; and 5 stupefaction

robust and radiant pearls for free. For her I won't charge anything. Then I will take her to a solitary *kuñj*, and, placing her gentle form upon a dais within that *kuñj*, I will recite all fifty of the sacred syllables on all the various limbs and parts of her body, beginning with her heart.⁶²

"I will embrace her and then perform a complete *aṅganyāsa** while reciting all the appropriate mantras. Then I will bestow upon her a most perfected mantra. By reciting this mantra only once, she will be able to enjoy direct association with Cupid himself.⁶³

"After the conclusion of her dalliance with Cupid, she will humbly present the jewels of her wanton coquetry, the whole of her worldly possessions, to her *mantraguru* as *dakṣina*, all of which will have been rendered holy remnants by the satisfied Cupid. In turn, I will be so delighted with her that I will bestow my graciousness as hundreds and hundreds of benedictions upon her, by awarding her the title, *VisomsorVilasācārya*.[†] Having received this degree, she will in turn worship me with doubled devotion."

Accepting these words of mine like a hymn of flowers, she decorated her ears with that bouquet as she glanced at

⁶² To be used in the mantrams; found in the *Smarapañjara*. There is a word used here, *Smarapañjarāksaran*, which creates a wealth of beautiful, poetic imagery, the whole of which is very difficult to express in an English sentence. - *Smara* refers to Cupid, or in this case *AnaṅgaMañjari*, since *Anaṅga* is also another name of Cupid; *pañjar* means ribs or cage, as well as aviary; and *aksaran* means syllable, as well as sky, or atmosphere. So as he is arranging the mantrams on her various limbs, her heart, fluttering with the wings of a bird, soars in the sky, as a result of his saying so many sweet things to her.

*applying mantras to the various parts of the body through touch and sound

⁶³ Throughout this section, Kṛṣṇa is playing on the word *anaṅga*, a name of Cupid meaning "bodiless", after the incident when Lord Siva burnt his body to ashes, angry at the fact that Cupid had shot Lord Siva with his flower arrows. By chanting this mantra, *AnaṅgaMañjari* will give Cupid a body (*saṅga*).

[†]*Visomsor*: lit. - deadly arrow, an epithet of Cupid; rendered as - The Most Extraordinary Ācārya of Cupid's Pleasure Pastimes

me very quickly, while making a hasty retreat behind Tulasī and RanganMālikā, her lips trembling all the time. The full-faced, fortunate gopīs laughed with full-blown eyes, full with affection, to see her disappear behind the backs of her friends, while her elder sister, Śrī Rādhā, watched with sympathetic and smiling eyes.

Satyabhāmā laughed, “Prāṇanāth! Then! Then?!”

Śrī Kṛṣṇa replied, “At that time Mallī and Bhṛṅgī appeared with two letters and presented them before the assembly. With elated minds, they all gathered around Lalitā to hear them be read aloud, as she proudly handed one of the letters to Subal.”

I asked, “Lalite! Who wrote these letters?”

Lalitā smiled, “The letters will say!”

Then Subal opened the letter given to him and began to read in a quiet voice.

NāndīMukhī: “Subal! We can’t hear!”

Subal laughed, “Sakhe! Please hear this remarkable letter!”

I replied, “Go on! I’m on the edge of my seat!”

Subal:

Swastisamastasammukhah!

[Denoting benediction or prosperity]

Before the right honourable, worthy of comparison (in writing) to the best of the saintly persons, surrounded and served by a host of good qualities, our dearest friend, the highly magnanimous Subal-⁶⁴

⁶⁴ ‘Our dear friend’, *priya-narmā-sakhā*, in fact denotes Subal’s relation with Kṛṣṇa. They are generally somewhat younger than Kṛṣṇa. Cf. UN 2.13-5; BRS iii.3.43-51.

Please know the following, by this letter, like a sweet cake served to you on a golden plate, come from the village called Jābat, and composed of syllables which are nothing less than the condensed form of the nectar of my love-

Though the lotus feet of your dear friend, and of the other residents of Trāja Māṇḍal as well, like your good self, are always graced with all auspiciousness, may this always continue to be so. There is one other matter to which you should please be attentive:

It is common knowledge that the exacting of revenue from one's dear friends is unbecoming, and so, though on many occasions we have had to part with considerable sums, we have up till now, remained silent. Now, however, due to the squandering of all the pearls that we had planted, our elders are awfully upset and complain all the time. Only due to this fact, that we are unable to attain a moment's peace since the dreadful day of our big blunder, I have had to say something about this. Please don't count this as a fault against me.

In this village of ours, Trindāban, your dear friend (Prāṇbādhū Kṛṣṇa) has taken up pearl farming nowadays, in the fields near the Jamunā, as His means of livelihood. After you have all settled on an adequate amount, through written correspondence with Lalitā, I will expect prompt payment. Here of course I am referring to the taxes due to us for the use of our land. With this revenue we will then go to bring a sufficient quantity of pearls from Māthurā. Having presented these

to our elders, we will have thus crossed over this ocean of anguish.

Or, if you are unable to come up with the considerable amount required, since of course you understand that it takes very expensive land to produce valuable pearls, then in that case, five representative members should meet together, and, after settling the rate, a quantity of pearls equal to that amount should be made over to Lalitā.

You are yourself recognised as the best amongst learned and experienced persons. Therefore what need is there for me to say anything further?

Sincerely yours,

Completely transported into the realms of rapture at having heard these lucid remarks, I revealed my inner thoughts, “Ayi Mallī! Ayi Bhṛṅgī! Your mistress is well I hope!?”

They replied, “Absorbed in meditation on the feet of her lord and master, she is quite content.”

Then, glancing out of the corners of my eyes towards the kuñj, I inquired, “Where is she just now?”

They replied, “In the village of the name Jāvat.”

I inquired further, “And what is she doing just now?”

They replied, “She is sitting, watching the path, waiting for the arrival of Lalitā and the other sakhīs, while anxiously praying for the auspicious welfare of the kingdom of Vrindāvan.”

I said, “Sakhe Subal! I suspect that our double-dealing friend here (Lalitā) has signalled someone to write this letter and then produce it as if it had come from Jāvat.”

Subal: “Na. Na. This is definitely Rādhā’s handwriting.”

Then I said, “Sakhe! Let me see the letter!”

Taking the letter from Subal I marvelled at it as I said to myself,

“Aha! These rows of words illuminate my eyes with brilliance like a flame of nectar. However, I will have to disguise the appearance of these ecstatic symptoms, such as the standing up of the hairs on my body, by attributing to them a cause other than the real one.”

Thus I laughed as I said, “How astonishing! I can’t believe it! These sly foxes have pulled this rabbit out of the hat like a flower from the sky, by unexpectedly raising a completely new issue.”

MadhuMaṅgal spoke up, “Bayasya! This overindulged and pampered Lalitā, the personification of the most grotesque and shrewd trickery (*kuṭi-nāṭi*), the first preceptor of all deceitful dancing girls who cavort around on the dramatic stage, and who is herself a first-class actress, is non-different from Rādhā. Thus, by her beguiling words she very easily subjugates Śrī Rādhā, and having thus overpowered her, enacts her own will through the personality of Rādhā. Know this to be a desperate and futile attempt. I know also, that as long as one of your enemies remains, then for that long you should relinquish all your hopes for happiness. Remembering this and all other pertinent information, you should recommend to the well-wisher of our kingdom of Vrindāvan that all these charlatans be run out of Vrindāvan at once. Then only, in this kingdom freed from all thorns, will you be able to enjoy all the sweet flowers and juicy fruits. Immersed in the happiness of that moment, I will then myself become a dancer as I continue to live here free from any further affliction.”

I said, “Lalite! How has our Vrindāvan become the kingdom of your sakhī?”

Lalitā: “*Bho! Paramkapatin!* [Oh consummate fraud!] You were present at the coronation festival of Śrī Rādhārāṇī. Why are you trying to conceal this fact?!”

I replied, “What to speak of seeing such a festival I don’t remember even having heard of it!”

Viśākhā: “Lalite! It’s not his fault. Through transgressing the codes of religion with hundreds and hundreds of chaste young cowherd women, the darkness of ignorance has descended upon him and covered his intelligence. Through his association, his two friends appear to have lost their minds also. How can they be expected to remember anything? Now the question is: How to resuscitate their consciousness?

“This can best be accomplished by causing the nectar of the words spoken by Rādhārāṇī to enter into the holes of their ears. This will bring about the appearance of her mercy within their consciousness and in this way their memories will be revived.”

Just then VrindāDevī arrived. This brought unlimited joy to all the gopīs as they embraced her along with Lalitā, who said, “Vrinde! You have come at a very good time. Please describe the great fun we had at the coronation festival of Śrī Rādhā!”

VrindāDevī very humbly replied, yet with great delight, “Sakhī Lalite! Actually I have come here just to drink the flower nectar description of that festival from your lotus mouth. Therefore, please distribute this nectar to us yourself.”

Lalitā cheerfully replied, “So be it. Everyone please listen very carefully-

“During the reign of the King of Seasons (Springtime), at the time of Paurṇamāsī *tithi* (the full moon) and during the Viśākhā *nakshatra* (constellation called Viśākhā), all of the rivers such as Kālindī and Mānasī Gaṅgā met together with

the demigoddesses headed by Ekānamśā,⁶⁵ Samjā, Savitrī, etc., having been ordered to do so by a voice from the sky, that of Hiranyagarbha (Lord Brahma), and another instruction received through their dreams from a resident of Vrindāvan, Lord Gopeśvar. Then all of them, together with Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī, attracted various Kinnarīs and Gāndharvīs there by making a tumultuous uproar produced from various musical instruments like flutes, lutes, vinas, gongs, mridaṅgas and other kinds of drums. While the Kinnarīs and Gāndharvīs sang, the Apsaras and Vidyādharīs began to dance, as Śacī and the other heavenly nymphs let loose with triumphant outcries accompanied by showers of flowers like the *parijāta*. The approach of Viśākhā and all the other *sahacarīs* (confidantes) was heralded by the melodious songs that went before them, resounding in all directions, as they appeared on the scene exquisitely decorated with sweetly scented silken cloths fastened with multi-coloured cords, and carrying in their hands freshly ground sandalwood paste, mind-enchancing musk, delicious *kun̄kum* (saffron), sandalwood oil and a variety of heavenly scented flowers. The wives of the brāhmanas uttered hundreds and hundreds of benedictions as the sakhīs carried in 108 brilliantly decorated golden pots filled with water scented with *kun̄kum*, *aguru* (an oil which is *not-heavy*), *karpur* (camphor), *candan* (sandalwood), and various fragrant flowers. To these were then added various gems decorated with auspicious markings. As the Ratnābhiṣeka began, all to the accompaniment of triumphant cries of joy, thousands of streams flowed from the lotus feet of priyasakhī Gāndharvā, who was seated on an altar encrusted with rubies, atop a brightly coloured dais.”⁶⁶

⁶⁵ Kṛṣṇa’s younger sister, a form of Yogamāyā, who was exchanged for him in Mathurā immediately after his birth. She is said to have then gone to live in the Vindhya mountains. Cf. *LalitāMādhava*, ct 1.

⁶⁶ The abhiṣeka of Rādhā as queen of Vrindāvan is found in Jīva Gosvamin’s *MādhavaMahotsava* (1555), particularly in chapters seven and eight. This work is based on evidence found in the *Matsya* and *PadmaPurānas*. The *GautamīyaTantra* is also mentioned in an alternate reading. See MM 1.8.

VrindāDevī joyfully inquired, “Then? Then?!”

Lalitā replied, “Then I gently rubbed her with a very fine, soft cloth to dry her body, before dressing her in a red skirt, with a dark blue veil (the colour of clouds), scented with Ketakī flowers. After comfortably seating her on a small golden seat, I began to braid her luxurious hair, which defeats the beauty of peacock feathers, intertwining the braids with garlands of fresh flowers, colourful guñja berries, pearls and jewels, finally fixing a colourful bouquet of flowers at the end of each braid. Meanwhile, the other attendants (*sakhīs*) present each began to perform the respective service that they were particularly expert at; decorating her transcendental body with various unguents, ornaments and garlands, whatever was suitable for the particular part or limb that they were diligently decorating...”

Suddenly, while in the middle of this sentence, Lalitā became overwhelmed by the remembrance of her *priyasakhī*, as the ecstatic symptoms of trembling, horripilation and faltering of the voice transported her into a state of divine unconsciousness. Viśākhā then sat down behind her and filled her ears with the nectarean vibrations of “Radhe Kṛṣṇa Radhe Kṛṣṇa...”, thus arousing her from her faint. Lalitā patiently remained silent for a few moments and when she had regained her composure, prepared to resume the narration.

In the meantime, however, when Śrī Rādhā saw that Lalitā had become unconscious, she exclaimed, “Oh light of my life, whose character shines like a burning ghee lamp, encircling and dissipating the darkness, Oh priyasakhī Lalite! Have you left this already unfortunate soul in a state of complete hopelessness? *Hā Bhagavān! Hā Bhaktavatsal Bhāskardeva!* [Oh Lord! Oh you who are affectionate to your devotees. Oh most merciful Sun God!] Please save us! Please protect us! *Hā Gokul Sudhānidhe!* [Oh Nectar Reservoir of Gokul!] Oh you

who have unconditionally resolved to protect the residents of Gokul, up to and including the Pulindas. Quickly therefore, bring life back into this succulent young creeper by sprinkling her with the nectar touch of your hands, this girl named Lalitā, who is the means of existence for people like me, whose hearts are like a cuckoo's. I will bear the expenses, whatever the cost! Better yet! As your remuneration, you can purchase this ascetic, Rādhikā, and make her your maidservant."

Lamenting in this way, her face streaming with tears, Rādhārāṇī rushed forward to embrace Lalitā, but before she could advance she was herself embraced (and thus protected) by her companions in the form of the ecstatic symptoms headed by paralysis (*stambha*). In other words, she also fainted in a swoon of ecstatic love.

Seeing this, Raṅganballī and Tulasī became frightened and ran to Rādhārāṇī with their hearts pounding. Raṅganballī put her left arm around Śrī Rādhā's back, and then, with her right hand, began to gently rub her body. Tulasī was crying profusely as she called out in a faltering voice, "*Hā Nāth! Raksha! Raksha!*" [Oh Lord! Protect us! Save us!] She ran and brought some fresh new leaves from a Tamāl tree, and after having fashioned a fan from them, began to fan Rādhārāṇī very briskly. Then Śrī Rādhā regained her consciousness and was delighted to see Lalitā already fit and well.

Meanwhile Lalitā continued, "Where was I? Oh yes! Then, all of those assembled there, decorated as they were with the ornaments of ecstatic symptoms, surged forth like a swell in the ocean of happiness, and, with Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī at their head, seated Śrī Rādhā on a very ornate, jewelled throne. Then, tilok was prepared from musk collected from the chest of the dark-blue demigod [Shyāmal devata] of the name Kāma, the brother of [Ekānaimśā] Yogamāyā,⁶⁷ and Śrī Rādhikā was anointed with this tilok as the Queen of Vrindāvan, all to the

⁶⁷ Kāmākhyā- 'of the name Kāma' can also be taken as Kāmākhyā Devī, the sister of Ekānaimśā.

accompaniment of the blowing of conchshells, ringing of bells and beating of gongs and drums.”

Having heard this wonderful description of Śrī Rādhā’s coronation festival, a great din and bustle of laughter was produced amongst all those present. I was also so much taken up by the intense rapture of that moment that a variety of ecstatic symptoms sprung up in my physical person, which I was able to constrain and contain only by sheer effort.

I managed a slight smile as I said, “Lalite! How is it I never came to know about any of this? Anyway, simply by this have you all acquired the kingdom? Especially since these very words of yours prove that it is my kingdom, with all of you as my subjects.”

NāndīMukhī: “How is that?”

I replied, “Since it was by my suggestion that Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī crowned Rādhā as my queen, the Queen of the Inner Sanctum [*Purandar*] of Vrindāvan.”

Viśākhā laughed, “*He asaṅgata bhāshin!* [Oh you of inconsistent speech!] The queen of Purandar is a demigoddess, the wife of Indra, famous by the name of Śacī, and she lives in heaven. However, my sakhī Rādhārāṇī wanders upon this Earth as a human being, the wife of the fortunate Abhimanyu.”⁶⁸

I said, “Oh most esteemed preceptor, crest jewel amongst the professors of the science of polemics! Viśākhe! You are endowed with the most decrepit intelligence (You imbecile)! Though you have repeatedly studied the section of dialectics dealing with direct perception, you have evidently forgotten it all?”

⁶⁸ Here Purandar, which literally means: *andor*- the interior, or female quarters (harem), of a *pur*- city; has been taken as a name of Indra, though it is also a name of Kṛṣṇa.

Viśākhā replied, “And just exactly what is it that I have forgotten?”

I said, “I will tell you. Just listen carefully-

If your priyasakhī Rādhā is not my mistress, then why did Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī anoint her during her coronation ceremony with tilok made from musk from my chest? Why did she place my necklace and my flower garland around her neck?”

Lalitā: “*Bho śaśaśṛṅga dhanurdhar!* [Oh wielder of the bow made from the horns of a hare!]* *He Alīk Purandar!* [Oh you false Indra! God-king of the illusionists!] She (Ekānamśā) whose lotus feet are adorned with the most excellent lines of auspiciousness; whose wealth of glories are sung by the Gandharvas and Vidyādhara; whose character is praised in hymns recited by Prajāpati Brahmā; the bestower of the fruits of manifold desires; the consort of the Lord of Nandi, Śrī Mahādev, the resident of Kailāsh and Vindhyaśāla, has an elder sister, a bluish deity named Kāmākhyā. The reverend Paurṇamāsī used the *mahāprasāda* (musk and flower garlands) of this dark blue Deity Kāmākhyā (and not Kāma) to anoint Rādhārāṇī during her coronation festival. What has any of this got to do with you?!”

TuṅgaVidyā: “Sakhī Lalite! This title, *Alīk Purandar*, that you have used to address him, is so fitting since in fact he is nothing more than a false Indra!”

Viśākhā: “How is that?”

TuṅgaVidyā: “Just as we see that in this province of Mathurā it sometimes happens that the headman of a single tiny village feels delighted and puffed up at being addressed as, “He Deva! Oh He Mahārāj!” [“Lord! Master!”], by a beggar brāhmaṇa or musician, all for the sake of alms of a mere

**Dhanurdhar* also indicates a bold or clever person, and, *śaśaśṛṅga*, the horns of a hare, is another way of denoting an impossibility or absurdity. (Brave Liar!)

twenty-five cowries (conchshells). In the same way, a certain inebriated (intoxicated from taking *bhāṅg*) and dissembling scholar (court jester) of low character, and others of his ilk, simply greedy for the pay of one *pol* (four tolas) of fresh butter, respectfully greet their fearless leader with the title *VrindāvanPurandar*. Lacking any profundity of character, this Kṛṣṇa is nothing more than an ambitious farmer. Meditating on this ‘Indraship’ of his, he advertises himself as the god of the celestial city, Amarāvātī, thus revealing his true identity as a foolish idiot.”

Biting her bottom lip to hold back her laughter, TuṅgaVidyā now began to describe my *abhishek* (coronation ceremony), “Sakhīgan! He is comfortably seated on a throne made from gold produced from moss growing on the banks of PāvanSarovar.⁶⁹

“This throne is encrusted with tasty pearl fruits and other jewels. He wears a crooked crown, roughly fashioned from flowers from the sky [(*akāśh kushum*- day dreams), the scent of which has attracted a swarm of intoxicated yellow bumblebees eager to collect some pollen, as they busily buzz about. Subal is happily holding an umbrella above his head. Aha! I can’t even describe the elegance of that umbrella, made from the shells of tortoises, from which is falling a shower of the most fragrant nectar.[†]

“His two friends, Ujjval and Catur, appear very delighted as they stand by his two sides, fanning him with *cāmaras* made from bunches of hair produced from the soft palms of the

⁶⁹ There is a kind of gold called, Jambunād, produced from mud on the banks of the Jambu River, moistened by the flowing juice of that river, which when dried by the sun is transformed into gold. However, what transformation occurs with the mud on the banks of Pāvan Sarovar is unknown. Still, this mud is being referred to here as gold, though in actuality it is probably nothing more than mud.

[†]There is another kind of nectar(?) associated with tortoise shells, which anyone who has ever picked up a (live) tortoise will have experienced.

hands.* Some of the greatest and noblest saints, born from the wombs of the most celebrated, barren women, are performing his *abhishek*, anointing him as the Chief Sovereign (*Mahendra*) of Vrindāvan, by bathing him in a shower of the delicious milk of Padmāgandha and some of the other bulls. His hare-horn bow that he holds in his left hand, shines with a splendour like a gift from the mighty Kuvera himself.

“In this and so many other ways, his Rajyābhishek was performed throughout the day. Thus his blindingly luminous fame flooded throughout the universe, carried by the tidal wave of his majesty. Though all of you are aware of this, it seems a great impropriety to me that none of you are falling at his feet while addressing him as Mahendra incarnate.”

The fair-limbed gopīs laughed with delight as they shyly glanced towards me from the corners of their eyes. They all smiled at one another as Citrā said, “Bho! Why are you two (Viśākhā and TuṅgaVidyā) making fun of him like this? He really is the Lord of the Gods (*Devendra*) you know! There is no doubt about it.”

Then TuṅgaVidyā said, “Citre! If that be true, that he is the Lord of the Gods (*Devarāj*), then why would he come here before all of us ordinary folk?”

Citrā replied, “Though it is common knowledge that Indra gets enamoured by the wives of other men (*par ramānī rata*)⁷⁰, *Devī* was so angered by this that she kicked him and rebuked him severely. Thus he left that heavenly home of his and came here to the forest. Accepting the dress of an

*Since everyone knows that no hair grows in the palms of the hands, this might be the joke in itself; otherwise, another possibility is that the cāmaras were made from bunches of hair from the soft underside of an elephants trunk. This also presents a pretty funny picture of cāmaras with stubbly little hairs sticking out.

⁷⁰ This description is based on the character of Indra who is known as an inveterate womanizer, in particular for his illicit affair with Ahalya, the wife of GautamaMuni described in the *Rāmāyana*, *Bālyakhaṇḍa*.

enchanting young cowherd boy, he then began the performance of *purash caran*.⁷¹ By this process he has attracted the favour of Vrindāvanēśvarī and is now happily passing his time here. Therefore, instead of teasing him by making him an object of ridicule, we should affectionately welcome this guest who has come to our home.”

The glowing faces of the graceful young gopīs lit up with smiles as they listened to this explanation of Citrā’s.

NāndīMukhī addressed her, “Sakhī Citre! The words you have used to describe the Son of King Nanda, Vrajendra Nandan, who eternally sports in the forest of Vraj, appear to contain an inner, esoteric meaning. Please therefore, after due consideration, bring delight to all of our hearts by explaining this secret before us.”

Citrā smiled but remained silent. When Śrī VrindāDevī saw that she appeared like a saint who has taken a vow of *maunam* (silence), Vrindā blissfully began, “NāndīMukhī! I have clearly understood the esoteric meaning of clever Citrā’s statements. Please listen carefully as I reveal this to you.”

NāndīMukhī: “First tell us how he has become the King of the Gods, *Devendra*.”

VrindāDevī replied, “Those who are very playful, who engage in a variety of captivating pleasure pastimes, are *devas*; or, on the other hand, those who are very effulgent, whose brilliant bodily lustre shines like the waves of a river of nectar on a moonlit night, can also be called as *deva*.⁷² He who is the

⁷¹ lit.-repetition of the name of a Deity attended with burnt offerings. A special performance of the mantra in which one repeats it a fixed number of times over a limited period of time along with other ritual performances and strict dietary restrictions. It is generally said that *puraścāraṇa* is necessary to breathe life into the mantra.

⁷² These are the customary etymologies of the word *deva* from the roots >*div*- ‘to play’, and >*dyut*- ‘to shine’. The latter is generally accepted as the genuine origin of the word by modern etymologists.

indra, or Sovereign Chief of all the *devas*, is Devendra Rāj; that is to say, he who far outshines the other *devas* in terms of the above mentioned qualities. This is how he is known as Devendra.”

NāndiMukhī smiled, “Vrīnde! You have sufficiently explained the meaning of Devendra. Now tell us the meaning of *par ramanī rata*.”

Vrīndā replied, “*Para* means ‘another’, or ‘opposing competitor’. It can also indicate *paramothkṛṣṭa ramanī*, a ‘very eminent lady’. Thus, the meaning of *para-ramanī* is, ‘the most superior woman’, that is, Śrī Rādhā. And of course, *rata* means ‘deep and fond attachment’, so, *par-ramanī rata* means, ‘one who is passionately devoted to Śrī Rādhā.’”

ChampakLatā laughed, “Vrīnde! Then who is that *Devī*?”

VrīndāDevī replied, “It is said, *‘Unless one is a god himself, he has no right to worship the gods’*. In accordance with this injunction, she who is very diligently engaged in the service of Caṇḍikā Devī, is also called *Devī*. Or, *Devī* means the wife of this *deva*. Or, a third possibility is that she has been called *Devī* just to lend some auspiciousness to an otherwise inauspicious situation, like calling a blind child, Padmalocan.” (lotus-eyed)⁷³

NāndiMukhī inquired, “Who is she?”

Viśākhā: “Well, that’s obvious. The person that fits this description; who has all of these characteristics, is Candrāvalī.”

VrīndāDevī smiled to hear this but then fell silent, as all the other bright-eyed gopīs laughed together.

⁷³ In other words, Candrāvalī (about whom these statements are being made) is being called a goddess precisely because she lacks any of the qualities of a goddess.

NāndīMukhī: “Yes, the fact that she rebuked him by kicking him clearly indicates her lower propensities and shameless impudence. But what then is the meaning of, ‘his greatly pleasurable heavenly home’ (*parama sukhada tan nija bhavanam*)?”

VrindāDevī replied, “One meaning is, ‘the place that is not very deep or dense, with insufficient foliage, without flowers or the buzzing of bumblebees, and which only (*param-* exclusively) affords unhappiness, uneasiness and a lack of contentment (*asukhad*),’ or, ‘that place which ruins real happiness, the place which gives pain, our Devī’s residence, Sakhīsthali.’ Quitting that place, he has come to this forest.”

NāndīMukhī: “How wonderful it is that you have so cleverly recognised the esoteric meaning of Citrā’s statements. Please therefore, divulge the hidden meanings of the other words which still remain incomprehensible to us.”

VrindāDevī replied, “The phrase beginning with *navin gopatva* indicates ‘someone who carries a flute, a buffalo horn, a cane, and a rope for tying cows; who is painted with red mineral dyes, decorated with new peacock feathers and necklaces made of guñja berries; an enchanting young cowherd boy bedecked with forest flowers and leaves.’ *Navīn* especially refers to his ever fresh, eternally youthful quality. *Purash caran samvidhān* (‘the performance or practice of the *puraścarana* rite’) is understood in this way: *purah* means ‘in front of, or, in other words, ‘underneath the sweetly scented Bakul trees just before us, ornamented with a multitude of bumblebees’. *Caran* means self-willed, wanton or noble; or, ‘like the king of the elephants, Gajendra, maddened by Cupid’s shafts, who wanders about, engaged in a variety of pleasure pastimes’. His precepts (*samvidhān*, or ‘the processes’ preceded by such wandering) consist of such things as kissing the lotuses (of his pastimes), biting the tender leaves of the Ashok creeper, playing with

round, plump pomegranate fruits, embracing golden jasmine creepers and causing others to drink the intoxicating honey of his camphor-sweet smile and the sidelong glances from his lotus eyes. It is, by such a ritual performance, that he forcibly attracts the playful coquette of this capital of Vrindāvan, who has come here to share some of her ecstatic feelings with the Mallikā, Bakul, Campak, Mādhavī and golden Jasmine flowers that grow here, collecting them that they may render service as various fragrant flower garlands. The word ‘attracts’ (*karṣaka*) indicates that after enticing her and making her completely mad with excitement, he pulls her to himself.

“The inner meaning of, *sukhena samayaṁ gamayan*, or, ‘happily passing the time’, is as follows: *sukhena* (happily) means, ‘in the topmost ecstasy produced by tasting the most commendable and indescribably sweet mellows’. This ecstasy has the ability to endow *samaya* (time), that is, the time of soporific Spring, with the most unique and incomparably good fortune, as though the Goddess of Fortune herself was eternally present, by means of a mystical myriad of pleasure pastimes. *Gamayan* or ‘causing to become’ indicates that he remains there, in her association, incessantly and intently absorbed in inventing ever more inexpressible and unspeakable ways to divert the attention of his playmate, through the artistry of delicious, wanton dalliance.”

My heart filled with joy, I addressed her, “*Viśvāsgātini Vrinde!* [You traitress!] You are the keeper (mistress) of my gardens; these groves of Vrindāvan. Why have you now gone over to their side?”

MadhuMaṅgal said, “*Priya bayasya!* This garden keeper has abandoned your groves to become their housekeeper, just so that she can eat some rice with salt and buttermilk. So what else would you expect her to say in these present circumstances?”

Vrindā exclaimed, “*Aye bhūsurābhāsh!* [You mere semblance of a brāhmaṇa!] *Kaṭubaṭo!* [You crude, rude and jealous jester!] Upon hearing these words, comparable to a fresh Spring shower, from your friend who is himself like a cloud, you have become quite a cheerful little frog now haven’t you? Your harsh croaking, however, is simply a source of disturbance for us.”

Mallī and Bhṛṅgī said, “Devī Lalite! Have you forgotten about what our Svāminī wrote in the other letter?”

Lalitā: “What was that?”

Mallī and Bhṛṅgī : “She wrote: ‘Whoever behaves in a contrary fashion, furnishing fallacious arguments, simply to instigate quarrel and hostility in the matter of settling a just and equitable price for the levy of land-rents, should immediately be bound and sent to me. And so forth and so on’

Lalitā said, “Yes! This MadhuMaṅgal is definitely antagonising the situation. After binding him tightly with some vines and creepers, take him, not to our soft-hearted Priyasakhī, but submit him instead to Jaṭilā and Abhimanyu. There, the lion of Jāvaṭ village,⁷⁴ Abhimanyu, can collect his dues from him and pay him his dues also, in the form of a good, sound thrashing.”

MadhuMaṅgal timidly remarked, “Bayasya! I have some very important work waiting for me at home. I’ll come back as soon as I’m finished.”

I replied, “*Dhik brāhmaṇ!* [Shame!] When you are with me why do you fear the tall talks of these weak, young girls?”

MadhuMaṅgal: “*He Mahāsūr!* [Oh great hero!] I have directly experienced your great valour enough times at the toll gate on the path around Govardhan. Even if you so conveniently have, I haven’t forgotten that day the gopīs

⁷⁴ Grāmsinḥa- literally ‘village lion’, means ‘dog’.

bound me with their veils, by the order of Gāndharvā, for the purpose of realising the revenues on Vrindāvan, and carried me off right under your nose as you looked on with your mouth hanging open. Fortunately, I somehow or other managed to save myself by my own brāhminical prowess.”

Saying this much, MadhuMaṅgal imitated someone in a panic of terror trying to flee away. I caught hold of his hand to bring him back and said, “Lalite! Why should I pay revenues to such a soft, gentle-hearted young girl as she? Rather, I shall collect my own dues by force if necessary.”

When she heard this, Śrī Rādhā glanced at me from the corner of her eyes and gave a beautiful smile.

NāndīMukhī said, “Citre! What is the meaning of what you said about him being our house guest (*bāṭīr atithi*)?”

Lalitā offered, “NāndīMukhī! When you already know, then why do you ask? He has only been here for about six or seven years since he left his own village in Mahāvan where he always used to stay.”

NāndīMukhī: “Why did he abandon the place of his birth?”

Rādhā answered under her breath, “Because there he was not free to do as he pleased. In a big village like that, practically a town, with many people always present, where is the opportunity to accomplish all the odd and unbecoming things that he is accustomed to, such as assassinating the character of young girls, breaking milk pots and stealing butter? Since there he has little scope for committing these crimes, and thus perfecting his natural calling, he has come to this lonely and dense forest of Vrindāvan. Here, his intense eagerness for such activities as biting the lips and stealing the clothes of chaste young girls goes unchecked, and with it the good name of our respectable families.”

NāndīMukhī smiled as Lalitā expressed aloud Śrī Rādhā's observation for the benefit of all those present. Divulging her own thoughts, she remarked, "Yes Lalite! Yet he seems to have relinquished this profession as of late."

Rādhā again answered quietly, "That does seem to be the case at present, for, as a result of the penances previously prescribed by the ācārya Lalitā, he has been acquitted of his crimes of thieving and the like, which arose out of a distorted intelligence coming from the abandonment of his personal duties and his improper upbringing. Now, out of the discernment produced of repentance, he has taken up the occupation of the gopīs, namely agriculture, as his religious duty. He is producing quite a good harvest and giving that too over to the gopīs, after first accepting a share for himself. In this way he brings so much happiness to the gopīs and himself as well, behaving just like a virtuous and pious gentleman."

This much Viśākhā similarly communicated to everyone, with her smiling face.

The lovely young gopīs (*Vrajasundarīgan*) discovered a festival of laughing and merriment in these statements of Śrī Rādhā, as I said to Subal with insincere malice, "Sakhe Subal! Have you seen how these cunning rascals, under the ruse of jesting inferences, have thoroughly undermined my authority here in this kingdom of Vrindāvan?"

Subal replied, "Not only have they dismissed your proprietary rights over Vrindāvan, but moreover, they have made a ploughman out of you!"

VrindāDevī said, "Subal! You are very wise and an experienced scholar. You are also the favoured recipient of the affection of both Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa. Therefore, why don't you confer with NāndīMukhī and try to arrange some settlement here? Though Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa are naturally very affectionate to each other, they have become engaged in this dispute over

Vrindāvan. Why aren't you able to refute this incongruity of opinions regarding the proprietorship of this kingdom, by citing some appropriate arguments gleaned from your learning in logic?"

To this, Lalitā and I responded by saying, Well done! Good idea! Excellent proposal!"

Subal then addressed me, "Bayasya! First of all, let Lalitā explain how the gopīs attained exclusive mastery over the kingdom, and then you can present your viewpoint, outlining your respective position and what are your claims to the kingdom."

I replied, "Sakhe Subal! Overcome by illusion, I became an offender by cohabiting with all of the celestial nymphs here in Vraja, but then, by my acts of atonement I again became purified. Please tell me how it is that I am again supposed to bandy words about with these gopīs? (In other words, this could easily lead to getting involved with them, thus I may again become defiled.)"

Vrindā then said to me, "*Mahāsuddha*! [Oh, aren't you the pure one! * Even though some of these gopīs may have become defiled by even the faintest whiff of your words, they have repeatedly bathed in the lake of Shyāmal's (Cupid's) deadly arrows (Śyāma Kuṇḍ), according to the method given them by the Empress of Vrindāvan. They thus come before you, once again pure and chaste. Since both of you have performed the required atonement rites, no fault can be incurred by your talking together. Therefore, Lalite, would you please begin."

Lalitā: "First of all, let us leave aside the question of Kṛṣṇa's sovereignty over the kingdom of Vrindāvan. The actual fact is that this lying cheat has no real connection with Vrindāvan whatsoever."

**Mahāsuddha*- can also mean: 'most impure'. In any case the epithet is sarcastic in intent.

NāndīMukhī: “How is that?”

Lalitā replied, “Since he and his forefathers have lived for generations in Bṛhadvan.”⁷⁵

NāndīMukhī: “What is the proof of that?”

Lalitā: “The utterances of the great sages headed by Vyāsadeva, as recorded in the revealed scriptures such as the *Bhāgavat* and other *Purāṇas*.”

Then Subal addressed her, “Lalite! As one of the mediators here, I have something very pertinent to add at this stage. Moreover, I will not be able to utter anything false while looking you in the face. Now my question is this: Have you attained this kingdom of Vrindāvan simply on the strength of the fact that Bṛhadvan is the kingdom of Śrī Kṛṣṇa? If you have any better evidence for your claims then we anxiously await its presentation.”

Lalitā replied, “Subal! Indeed, we have direct evidence as well as indirect evidence, as per the statements of the *Purāṇas*. Nevertheless, since it is said, ‘*Where there is a conflict of hearsay and direct perception, directly perceivable proof is the most substantial*,’ we should, in light of this, accept the direct evidence.”

NāndīMukhī: “And what might that be?”

Lalitā: “Do I have to say? As if you haven’t all perceived it yourselves.”

NāndīMukhī: “I don’t remember anything in particular. Please tell us.”

Lalitā: “Is there anyone in the three worlds who was not bowled over by the bliss of the *Ratnābhishek* performed on the

⁷⁵ In all accounts of Kṛṣṇa’s life, the cowherd settlement is moved in his third year. According to Jīva, Kṛṣṇa’s grandfather made his home in Bṛhadvan (also known as Mahāvan). Cf. *GopālaCampu*, Vol. I.3.19.

great throne by the wives of the demigods, headed by Savitrī,* all to the accompaniment of an uproarious din produced from beating on drums like the *dundubhi*?”

Subal: “Lalite! Yes, the *abhishek* is accepted. My dear friend, however, might easily describe this same event in different terms. Don’t forget that he is present here to make you all his own.”

Lalitā: “Subal! If this cowherd boy, your biped friend there,[†] does in fact imply that there is some untruth here, then why does this ‘master’ (Swāmi) still so earnestly long to be initiated with her mantra, that he might obtain the service of her lotus feet alone, she who was ceremoniously installed as the Queen of Vrindāvan and who continues to sit on the *śimhāsana* at MahāYogPīṭh? Have you already forgotten all these previous statements of his?”

NāndīMukhī laughed, “Lalite! This foppish young buck [prince] is addicted to the drug of love (Madan) and is therefore excessively lusty. Can his incoherent ravings during moments of this drug-incited delirium be accepted as proof? I’m afraid we’ll need something more solid than this to go on.”

Vrindā: “Whatever testimony Lalitā produces is being refuted by the both of you (Subal and NāndīMukhī), who have taken the side of this maddened and intoxicated young son of the king. Consequently, Lalitā has become so overpowered by indignation that she doesn’t even bring up those arguments which are well known by everyone, everywhere.”

NāndīMukhī: “Well Vrindē! Why don’t you give us an account of this evidence then?”

*Savitrī -wife of Lord Brahma and tutelary goddess of the *gāyatrī* mantra

[†]*dvīpada*- two-legged is a contemptuous term for ‘man’; or, the subtle implication is that he is an animal

Vrindā: “Priyasakhī Rādhā has, through her unbounded love, bestowed a form similar to her very own (*sārūpya*) upon this forest of Vrindāvan. Thus this forest itself is now designated as her own intimate companion (*priyasakhī*).”

NāndīMukhī: “How has this forest become as like her portrait?”

Vrindā: “Please listen-

In this most beloved place (Vallabhpur),
the golden vines of Jasmine creepers
and Campak flowers,
distinguished by their exquisite fragrance
and loveliness,
have attained the very form of priyasakhī
Śrī Rādhā’s divine body,
thus vanquishing creepers of Lightning (Vidyutballī).
The lovely, full blown lotus flowers
are reflections of her charming and cheerful,
lotus face.

As her eyes flutter,
the lotuses tremble in the gentle breeze
and the lithe and lissome deer,
of slow and gentle gait,
are startled and run off into the forest.
As her full, lustrous lips begin to tremble,
the Bimba fruits hanging in the trees swing to and fro,
while Bandhuli flower buds bloom in the morning mist,
blessed with fortune,
having attained the form of her glistening,
honeydew lips.

The pleasing form of her two arms has been captured
by all the tremulous creepers
in this forest of Vrindāvan,
and the beaks of the parrots have received
the eminent form of her highly raised nose,
the best friend of the sesame flowers.
The flowers of this forest, all in full bloom,
are the personified form of her laughter.
The sweetly scented buds of the Kunda flower,

surrounded by black bumblebees infatuated
by their fragrance,
are blinded by the radiance of her teeth.

Rows of bumblebees in flight
have found the measure of her eyebrows disposition,
and the fortunate Bok flowers, shining and smooth,
have attained some of the exquisite beauty
and grace of her brilliant forehead.
The tail feathers of the playful peacocks
are the image of the decorated braids of her hair,
while the splendour of the bowstring
of the bow of Cupid has lost heart,
after seeing the Munja ornament
which decorates her ears.

The fruits of the Bael, Tāl [Palm]
and Pomegranate trees,
are modelled after her lovely, rising breasts,
poised as though waiting for the dawn
in the eastern sky.
The resplendence of her chest has lent
it's eminence to the multitude of golden simhāsanas.
The jingling of the little bells
in the embellished bracelet that goes round her hips,
is echoed in the forest round the girdle
of the great mountain (Giri Govardhan),
as the sound of the flute.

Her excellent thighs, able to excite Cupid himself,
are mirrored in the trunks of banana trees,
shining with liquid beauty.
The land-lilies have attained their appearance
through association with her lotus feet.
Both flocks of swans, gracefully moving
through the water with dextrous ease,
as well as lust-intoxicated elephants,
see her gait as their guru.

Hundreds of Jambu fruits hanging in the trees,
are the reflection of the tilok markings on her face
(gopī dots);
the sweet songs of the young cuckoos in the Spring,

are the echo of her enchanting words;
and the wagtails, flitting and dancing
from one lotus flower to the next,
have learned their movements
from the corners of her eyes that dance,
within the lake of her gracious, lotus face.

The waters of the Yamunā are tears of joy
produced from loving ecstasies
flowing from her eyes and mixing with the collyrium
[kajjal] that decorates them.

Mānasi Gaṅgā is the outward manifestation
of her pure and peaceful heart,
while the other lakes that adorn this lovely land,
are the condensed form of her perspiration.
The multitude of gleaming guñja berries
have received their lustrous splendour
from her passionate affection.

Kuṅkum [Saffron] and Lotus flowers
have attained their fragrance
through association with her body;
a fragrance that makes her co-lovers despondent
when it enters their nostrils,
but which engladens the hearts of her friends
and well-wishers,
a scent that, in fact, attracts and entices all the
residents of Vraja in one way or another.

The radiance of her body
humbles the pride of Mount Meru,
crowned with lightning bolts,
who worship her bodily brilliance
as the source of their own splendour.
Bathing in the penumbra cast
by only a minute fraction of her lustre,
they have attained their own elegance.
The effulgent land, caves, kuñjas [forest bowers],
houses made of gold, and mountains of stone,
here in this forest of Vrindāvan,
have all been modelled after her radiant beauty.

All of the lakes of this forest have attained
the form of her deep navel
and the black snakes that are to be found
around these lakes
are manifestations of the fine, black bodily hairs
that grow above her navel,
like ripples on the surface of these lakes.
The black crane* who subsists on these snakes
trembles when he sees them.
The be-jewelled desire trees
are extensions of her munificence
and the fine hairs of her body, standing on end,
are the benevolent preceptors
for all Kadamba flowers.

The gentle and refined people of the three worlds,
sing the praises
of all the liberated beings in Vrindāvan,
born as both animate and inanimate creatures
in these woods,
yet these beings are simply reflections of the beauty
of Śrī Rādhā's form and different bodily limbs.
Āha! The lustre of that body is constantly described
by Umā, Rati and Laksmī,
among the assembly of the heavenly damsels.

The desire trees and creepers of Vrindāvan
bestow an abundance of delightful pleasures,
far exceeding even that which is available
in the spiritual sky,
in the abodes of the Lord of LaksmīDevī,
which are virtually overflowing with ecstasy.
Their effulgent presence is as resplendently evident
as that of all the moons
existent within the multitude of universes;
thus they have attained a measure
of the unmeasured fame of Śrī Rādhā.
In this way we can clearly perceive how this forest
of Vrindāvan is said to be
her priyasakhī (dear friend)."

*Since cranes are usually white, this obviously refers to something, or someone, else.

At this point I proudly interjected,

“I have been ceremoniously installed
as the all-conquering, heir-apparent of the kingdom
of my father, Vraja- j Nanda.
With fixed intelligence but a heart softened with love,
I roam these forests with my friends,
on the pretext of herding our cows,
but in actuality with the sole purpose in mind
of protecting my forest.
Therefore, how is it possible that this forest
has recently become yours,
simply on the strength of some implied oneness
or similarity of appearance?”

VrindāDevī replied,

“That person who becomes the friend of another,
certainly acquires a ‘sameness’
with his/her dearmost.
Otherwise it is to be understood
that his/her friendship belongs to another.
If you can’t accept this point,
then, Hanta! [vexation!],
you had better just run off to join Lakṣmī
and her associates.”*

MadhuMaṅgal replied with uncontrolled laughter, “*Bho mithyābādini Vrinda!* [Oh you liar Vrinda!] Out of greed to enjoy the pleasure of drinking condensed milk, you have abandoned your divinity to become a flatterer. Simply by reciting this false eulogy will you make our forest of Vrindāvan into (the possession of) your best friend?”

*The idea of *sāruṇya* is described in *BhP* xi.9.22-3, illustrating with an example how the stunned insect stored in the wasp’s nest becomes a wasp itself through constant meditation on it. In the second half of the verse, Vrindā refers to this type of salvation (*sāruṇyamukti*). It is said that on the planets inhabited by Nārāyaṇa, all of his eternally liberated devotees have four-armed forms similar to his own. So Kṛṣṇa should go there to see, if in fact, the followers of Śrī LakṣmīNārāyaṇ have the same bodily characteristics or not. Obviously they do, so if they are not their followers then whose followers are they? Vrindā’s (and Raghunāth’s) point is that of Rūpa Gosvāmin, that those devoted to Nārāyaṇa do not gain the favour of Kṛṣṇa.

NāndīMukhī spoke up, “Lalite! In the absence of the authorised statements of the sages of yore, neither side can be defeated. Therefore, please quote some references from the *Purāṇas* for us.”

Lalitā: “If the supporters of his side are going to say such things as this, then I suggest that you go see Paurṇamāsī. She has a wealth of references from the *Purāṇas* for you to hear.”

Subal: “We want to hear some references from you.”

Lalitā: “We are cowherds by caste. Moreover, we are women. Therefore we have no authority to quote from the *Purāṇas*.”

Subal: “Well, this Vrindā is a Devī (goddess). Let her please be so kind as to enlighten us.”

VrindāDevī posed as though she was thinking for a moment or so, and then said, “Yes! There are many statements pertinent to this matter. In fact, there are so many that I don’t know where to begin. The point is, who is there amongst us who has not heard from Paurṇamāsī the passage in the *Purāṇas* which subdues all other statements, namely,

*“Though many other Devīs (goddesses) hold dominion
in various other places,
it is Śrī Rādhā who holds dominion
over the forest of Vrindāvan?”*

When MadhuMaṅgal saw the cheerful faces of Lalitā and the other lovely young cowherd girls of Vraja all lit up, indicating their pride of victory, he very haughtily said, “NāndīMukhī! In the *GopālTāpaniUpaniṣad*, a work which stands above all the *Purāṇas*, this forest is celebrated by the name, *Kṛṣṇavan*. For this reason, the demigods headed by Lord Brahmā and Lord Śiva continuously sing the praises of Priyabayasya (our dear friend) as the Prince of Vrindāvan. Is there anyone who is unaware of this? The utterances of the

Śruti always supersede that which is stated by the *Smṛti*. In light of this, the kingdom of Vrindāvan is obviously under our jurisdiction. Therefore, Sakhe Subal! Get these gopīs, who are so covetous of another’s property, out of here.”

I said, “Sakhe MadhuMaṅgal! You are my most benevolent and dear friend!” So saying, I hugged him tightly.

NāndīMukhī pretended not to notice this as she looked towards the kuṅj where Rādhā was sitting. As NāndīMukhī studied the faces of Lalitā and the other sakhīs, Rādhā smiled and softly said, “How astonishing! Simply upon hearing the word, *Kṛṣṇavan*, from the *GopālTāpaniUpaniṣad*, this prudent Paṇḍit, without even a hint of the real meaning of the word, has attributed another meaning, thus assuming that in this one fell swoop he has made another’s kingdom his own. Now he looks just like a stupid bumblebee trying to drink honey from a parrot’s beak, because of its similarity to a big red kimśuka flower.”

Lalitā expressed these remarks of Śrī Rādhā for the benefit of everyone, to the unrestrained laughter of all those present. (With a few exceptions, of course.)

I then began to consider, “Most probably Lalitā will interpret this word *Kṛṣṇavan* in some other way.”

While I was thus considering her intentions, NāndīMukhī exclaimed, “*Jayākāṅkṣin!* [All glories to you who are so hopeful of attaining your end!]. I have something I would like to contribute at this point! If you approve, then I can say it.”

I replied, “By all means!”

NāndīMukhī: “Lalitā intends to defeat you and claim the kingdom as their own, by taking the word *Kṛṣṇavan* as a compound word (*karmadhāraya*), meaning *Shyāmvan* (dark forest).”

I replied, “This Lalitā is the primal preceptor (ācārya) in the lore concerning the fine arts of adornment with flowers and painting the body with *candan* (sandalwood) and mineral dyes, using a small brush. I have personal, practical experience of this as she has on many occasions embellished my form with a variety of forest flowers. But what does she know about grammar?”

Vrindā smiled, “Oh most venerable and wise professor of grammar! Our priyasakhī Lalitā is a very well renowned ācārya in the science of grammar. Much more so than you!”

Lalitā replied with embarrassment, “Oh you villain, Vrindē! Get out of here with that nonsense.”

Vrindā: “I’m contending with him on your behalf and now you’re mad at me?”

Lalitā then said to me, “Bho! Oh tiger amongst the teachers of compound words! You have thought to frighten us with this apparition of the person you so much want to become (through this misunderstood meaning of the word-*Kṛṣṇavan*), but why do you vainly long after this playground of our *priyasakhī*? You will have to move aside and go far away as soon as you have understood the obvious, that by the use of a juxtapositional (appositional) or attributive compound,⁷⁶ the meaning of *Kṛṣṇavan* is *Shyāmvan* (dark forest). Why persist at taking the meaning to be *the forest of Kṛṣṇa*. This is a truth as apparent as a blazing fire.”

I replied, “*Caturanmanyē*! [Think you’re very clever don’t you, Lalite?!] When it is perfectly plain to see that this is a determinative (*tatpuruṣh*) compound, it is superfluous to try to combine it any other way. Anyway, how would you explain this statement, ‘*May the rascal be gratified?*’ (or, ‘*We’ll let you say your piece according to the principle of keeping the wicked happy.*’)”

⁷⁶ karmadhāraya- compound in which the first member is an adjective describing the second.

Rādhā spoke softly from within the kuñj, “By reason of the fact that this forest is very deep, dense and dark, the word *Kṛṣṇa* has been placed in apposition to forest (*van*). Thus this juxtapositional compound (*karma-dhāraya*) gives the clearest meaning.”

Lalitā repeated these words of Rādhā, exactly as she had said them, which prompted ChampakLatā to say, with praise, “Lalite! Sadhu! Sadhu! [Bravo! Bravo! Well spoken!] You have spoken correctly. Since this forest is the place where he himself has manifested and accomplished a variety of activities (*karma*), such as his playful killing of the demons Aṛiṣṭa and Keśi, subduing Kāliya, lifting up Govardhan hill and performing the eternal Rāsa dance, then it should be clearly obvious that this is an appositional compound (*karma-dhāraya*).”

Lalitā again expanded on the original statement of Rādhā’s, explaining in a variety of ways how it is that Kṛṣṇavan means Shyāmvan. First she established that that place which has many wooded areas which are extremely deep and dark is a *Kṛṣṇa-vana*. Since this is an attribute of Vrindāvan, or an adjective modifying Vrindāvan, the word should be understood to be an attributive compound (*bahu-vrīhi*).*

Vrindā said, “*Satyang! Satyang!* [Here! Here!] [Aye! Aye!] [True! Very true!] The place where the Rāsa dance is held on the banks of the Kālindī is a dark banyan forest, and the RāsaSthali near Govardhan (Pārāśalī) is also very dense and dark. These places are renowned for the joy they bring to all.”

Indurekhā said, “Lalite! Your conclusion that the word Kṛṣṇavan is an attributive compound (*bahu-vrīhi*) is one

*Here Lalitā has made a play on words. The word for attributive compound is *bahu-vrīhi*. *Bahu-vrīhi* can also mean [literally]: *much paddy*. Therefore she is saying that in this instance, the rice is blazing like fire, or, burning in the sacrificial fire. In other words, it is so obvious that this is an attributive compound word (meaning dark forest), that it is like a blazing fire.

hundred percent correct. This is due to the fact that there is so much grain (*vr̥hi*) growing here. Then of course there are also these fields of *mukta vr̥hi* (pearl grains). That forest in which a great harvest of grains is produced is clearly describable as *bahuvr̥hi*. What could be a more significant indication than this, that this word, *Kṛṣṇavan*, is an attributive compound (*bahu-vr̥hi*).”

As they all laughed heartily, their minds full of conceit, I replied, “*Nānākuṭkalpanānagarī cakravartini Lalite!* [Oh Empress of the imaginary city, conceived through an intricate web of prevaricating and paradoxical falsehoods!] The primary and principal meaning of *Kṛṣṇavan* is *the forest of Kṛṣṇa*, in accordance with the fact that it is a determinative compound (*tatpurush*). Therefore, what makes you think that you can refute this meaning simply by some invented attributive and appositional compounds, imputing to these all sorts of ridiculous and imaginary meanings?”

Lalitā replied, “*He MahāPaṇḍit! Tatpurush, tatpurush!* What are you babbling on and on about? I ask you- ‘Since there are many different kinds of determinative compounds (*tatpurush*), please be so kind as to explain which type this one is, after clearly ascertaining this yourself.”

I said, “*He jarabuddhike!* [Oh you of decrepit intelligence!] *The forest of Kṛṣṇa*, this *Kṛṣṇavan*, is famous in the three worlds as the sixth type (genitive case) of determinative compound.”

Now Rādhā spoke softly again from within the kuṅj, “If the word *Kṛṣṇavan* is taken as the sixth type of determinative compound, meaning *the forest of Kṛṣṇa*, then in that case, the forest of banyan trees around Sakhīsthali (the grove of Candrāvalī) is yours, Oh lion among men, for there in Sakhīsthali, the *ṣaṣṭhi-tatpuruṣa* (lit.- the sixth, that person) is always present.”

Lalitā laughed, “In this instance there is not even a slight possibility that this is the sixth type of determinative compound.”

NāndīMukhī said, “Lalite! What is this? A *sutra* from some treatise, pregnant with purpose? Go on. Explain to us the hidden meaning behind your words.”

Then Lalitā placed the blue lotus flower garland of her sidelong glance around my neck, as she said with a secretive smile, “NāndīMukhī! The meaning of *ṣaṣṭhi-tatpuruṣa* is as follows: *ṣaṣṭhi*- some woman; and *tatpuruṣa*- the man or servant of that woman, or, in other words, her husband or man-servant.”

Viśākhā said, “Lalite! I understood the meaning of *tatpuruṣa*, but who does *ṣaṣṭhi* refer to? What is her name?”

Lalitā: “Candrāvalī!”

Viśākhā: “How is it that Candrāvalī is *ṣaṣṭhi*?”

Lalitā: “Amongst the retinue of the great goddess, first we have MahāBhairav (a name of Lord Śiva), the servant of Kāṁsa, the terrible Govardhan Malla. Then, amongst the *Devīs* that worship him, are secondly, his mother Bhārūṇḍā (Caṇḍī); thirdly, the mother of Candrāvalī, Mahīkarālā (of massive and dreadful appearance; with notched teeth) [CarcikāDevī]; fourthly, Śaivyā (Kālī); fifthly, the famous Padmā (Śaṅkhinī - female ghost); and finally (sixth), Candrāvalī (*Ṣaṣṭhi*), the resident of the banyan forest at Sakhīsthali. Because she is a resident of the banyan forest this appellation of *ṣaṣṭhi* suits her, since everywhere it is known that *Ṣaṣṭhi Devī* resides within the banyan trees.”⁷⁷

⁷⁷ *Ṣaṣṭhi* is the feminine form of the adjective for ‘sixth’. Thus it refers to the genitive case, which is the sixth case in order when declining a noun. It also refers to a female deity, identified with Durga, presiding over children’s welfare and who is generally worshipped on the sixth day after a baby’s birth.

The sakhīs all laughed uproariously to hear this explanation, while I thought to myself, ‘The excellent intelligence of these young gopīs of beautiful limbs (Vrajāṅganā) is actually quite astonishing. Even I have been silenced by their pompous boasting.’

At this point there was no other recourse but to remorsefully reveal my inner feelings, “NāndīMukhī! These gopīs are the wives of our peasant farmers.*

Therefore, whatever enjoyments we present them with, in payment for services rendered, be it colourful, fine cloths or whatever else, are all readily received by them. They are also decorated with ornaments made from jewels and gems presented by ourselves; pearls, coral, rubies, emeralds, and diamonds. Nevertheless, they have, as of late, become overly conceited by their newly acquired treasure of ever fresh adolescence, thus they now take their superiors (*guru* [heavy] *jan*) very lightly and look upon them with disregard and neglect. By the corners of their restless eyes, dancing with exultation, they now seek to dupe me, the formidable son of the Emperor of all these lands, with their proud and pompous talks. Yet even though I am constantly being deceived by them, I remain exclusively dependent on the first and foremost attendant of the respectable Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī, namely your good self (NāndīMukhī). Since we are all from the same village, although what they have done is obviously an infringement of the accepted codes of conduct, and most lamentable to be sure, I have thus far not given it much importance, mainly due to my apprehension of the disgrace that all of this might bring upon our good village. However, as of this moment this baseless recrimination will go no further. For now I will attack in battle, with the fatal weapons of my sharp nails, the very form

**Kṛṣak gujarer gujarī*- According to *RādhāKṛṣṇa GanoddeshDīpikā*, ‘*gurjar*’ indicates the class of persons who looked after the goats. Nowadays however, it refers to any type of cultivator or husbandman.

of the wealth of their new-found freshness and youthfulness, which have never been seen even by their respective husbands; namely those two colourful, golden caskets, marked with the dawn-hued signs of the moon, which they keep covered with the fine, blue cloth of their bodices. Then I will cause my indomitable commanding officers of my teeth to plunder the ruby gems of their unparalleled lotus lips. In this way, they will then be rendered silent.”

Thereupon, as I suddenly and proudly advanced in their direction as if to catch hold of them, they all glanced obliquely in my direction with crooked, dancing eyebrows and smirking smiles, as they began to move about, hither and thither.

Lalitā addressed me, as if smouldering with rage, “*Aye Śyāmalrasapannirata!* [Lo! You who are so busy to drink the nectarean mellows of Cupid’s dalliance!] Get thee hence! Get thee hence! We are going to inform Vrajeśvari (Mother Yaśoda) about your indiscriminate desires, brought on by passionate infatuation.”

Satyabhāmā laughed with astonishment as she asked Śrī Kṛṣṇa, “*Vinodīn!* [Pleasant one!] There’s something I want to ask You.”

Śrī Kṛṣṇa replied, “*Priye!* Please tell me, my beloved, what is it?”

Śrī Satyabhāmā, “How is it that Lalitā and the other gopīs (Vrajāṅganāḡan) were able to interpret so precisely the things that Śrī Rādhā said to herself within the *kuñj*?”

Śrī Kṛṣṇa replied, “*Priye!* Lalitā and the other gopīs are the expansions of Śrī Rādhā’s own form. Why then should they be incapable of interpreting her soliloquies?”

Śrī Satyabhāmā, “He *Subhag!* [Oh most fortunate one!] How were you affected by the derisive and mocking retorts of Śrī Rādhā?”

MadhuMaṅgal replied, his voice tremulous with emotion, “Priyasakhī Satyabhāmā! As a flower bud (*mañjarī*) and the navel of a deer are inseparably endowed with sweet fragrance, the talks between Gāndharvā and Giridhārī cannot but be saturated with anything other than ecstasy.”

As Śrī Kṛṣṇa drank in the words of MadhuMaṅgal as though they were some milky ambrosia, he remembered Śrī Rādhā in such a way that the pangs of separation began to burn his heart terribly, worse than the most acutely acrid poison. Again and again his heart throbbed with pain, as though it had been pierced to the quick by a serpentine iron arrow, glowing with fire. In this condition of dire affliction, when it seemed he could bear this distress no longer, his body started to tremble violently, due to intense absorption in meditation on Śrī Rādhā. Then his other comrades and friends in the shape of inertia, fainting, stupefaction and madness came running from one side, while from the other came paralysis, shivering and the other eight symptoms of loving ecstasy (*aṣṭa sāttvik bhāv*), all clamouring, “I’ll be the one to touch him first!, I’ll catch him before you do!...”

According to the rules of play they all engaged in this insolent braggadocio, competing with each other to see who could achieve the ultimate victory within the playground of his heart, that was now surging with activity. Then, all of a sudden they all rushed forward, climbing on top of one another as if to embrace him simultaneously.

However, his dear friend named Śrī Śrī Ras, dearer than life itself, after considering which friendships here could possibly result in incompatibility (*rasābhās*), came forward and spoke to all the other companions (frigidity, paralysis, etc.), “*Re Re vidagdha siromaninmanyagan!* [Hallo! Hallo! Most respected sirs! You who think you have ascended to the pinnacle of achievement in scholarship, refinement, intelligence and humour!] This is a fine time to play now isn’t it?!”

Chastising them in this way, with his brows furrowed and his eyes rolling, he continued, “Under the present circumstances it is not at all fitting for you to exhibit these moods!” Thus he restricted their roughhousing and playful antics.

This RasNarma sakhā is actually the personified form of a transformation of the most indescribable love, combined with the most pure and pleasing, intimate friendship. Thus in the form of the best medicine, endowed with inconceivable properties, he is capable of subduing all the other dear associates and attendants of Śrī Kṛṣṇa, who remain in his company. In fact, his very existence has sprung from Śrī Kṛṣṇa Himself. He is his self-same form and he is the energy behind the most glorious and radiant pleasure pastimes of Śrī Kṛṣṇa, beyond the realms of debate or description. The cintāmani gem, as well as other priceless jewels, have all been endowed with his auspicious form. His form is like a pleasure garden, where clever wit, artful dexterity and proper understanding of the time, are all arrayed like so many rows of flowers.

Heeding all of these points, the companions and attendants bit their tongues as they exclaimed, “Bho! Bho!? We have behaved improperly!” So saying, they felt quite embarrassed as they checked themselves and slowly began to back away.

Thereupon, Śrī Śrī Yādavendra, visibly affected by those retreating symptoms of ecstatic love, with his heart still palpitating, lamented in his mind,

“Hā! [Ah me!] You are the dovecote of my life
[Like a dove, my life wants to fly away,
but you are it’s shelter],
a vast river of glittering, liquid prem,
showering a spray of honey-sweet drops of nectar
as you bound along your course.
You are a mine of artful qualities,
of mirthful raillery
and enigmatic glances and gestures.

Oh you who are the moonshine
that nourishes my Cakora bird eyes!*

Oh my Rādhike! *Hai! Hai!* [Oh my! Oh my!]
Why had I found this treasure,
only to again see it fall from my hands?!
(Would it have been better that I never found this
treasure, because upon losing it I now feel that I
must also lose my life?!)"

Satyabhāmā exclaimed, “Yadavendra! While drinking the drops of flower nectar dripping from your lotus mouth, the honey of your wanton dalliance in Gokul, I find that my thirst is simply increasing, moment by moment. Please, therefore, kindly cause me to drink this nectar again.”

So Śrī Kṛṣṇa took up the story again, “Priye! Please hear me.”

Thereupon MadhuMaṅgal said, “Sakhī Lalite! I am the minister to uphold the inviolable statements of my dear *priyasakhā*; he cannot contravene my recommendations. Therefore, whatever excellent bribes you wish to give me, will, no doubt, go quite far in your favour, when it comes time to settle the price for the pearls.”

Viśākhā said, “Arya MadhuMaṅgal! There is nothing suitable here to oil your palms with. However, in the evening we can definitely give you four *kapardak* (cowries; conchshells), so that you can purchase some *bhāṅg*. If you don’t trust us, then we’ll leave NāndiMukhī here as security.”

MadhuMaṅgal angrily retorted, “*Re avadyabhāṣinī ābhīrike Viśākhe!* [Oh you of improper speech, you milkmaid Viśākhe!] Just forget it! I’ll fix you! You’re going to have to make amends for insulting me like that!”

Then he turned to me and said, “Priya Bayasya! Your soft speech, like melting ghee, only has the effect of making these milkmaids, who are as puffed-up and conceited as the God of

*The Cakora bird is said to subsist on moonshine.

Fire, Agni, all the more temperamental (their conceit flaring up like fire), in that they reciprocate simply by rebuking you. I wouldn't be surprised if at this very moment they are planning to bind me up and carry me off."

I replied, "Sakhe MadhuMaṅgal! The truth of the matter is, that without conquering the capital city, one cannot expect to bring any country under his control. Similarly, as long as the leader of this flock⁷⁸ goes undefeated, then we can't expect her followers to hold their tongues."

As I was explaining things to MadhuMaṅgal in this way, I looked towards the kuṅj wherein Śrī Rādhā was seated, and breathed a sigh of sadness, "What to do?! In fear of her defeat, Rādhā will never come before me."

When Rādhā heard my words she craned her neck so that she might see me better, but then hesitated and hid herself again within the kuṅj.

Satyabhāmā: "Then! Then what happened?"

Śrī Kṛṣṇa replied, "Then I said to NāndīMukhī,...

"NāndīMukhī! You know, in comparison to the treasure of new youthfulness of Lalitā and the other sakhīs, the blooming freshness of Śrī Rādhā is of much greater value. I would even say that it was priceless."

NāndīMukhī: "How is that?"

I replied, "Well, the wealth of new-found youthfulness of Lalitā and the others could be contained in two small treasure chests. By comparison however, the wealth of Śrī Rādhā's adolescent beauty fills full to the brim the two golden waterpots on either side of her wise and experienced heart.

⁷⁸ Yūtheśvarī refers to those mistresses of Kṛṣṇa who are leaders amongst the other gopīs, many of whom take an attitude of service to Rādhā. Though Rūpa Gosvāmin does not limit the potential number of yūtheśvarīs in his *UjjvalNīlamani*, the only ones he describes in any detail are Rādhā and Candrāvalī. Here the reference is evidently to Rādhā. For more information, see *UN*, ch.6.

On account of their fullness and raised, erect posture, they appear rounder, taller and wilder than the globes on the head of a warrior elephant. In fear of the celebrated thief of Gokul, she has tried to disguise their glaring golden effulgence by smearing them with musk.”

NāndiMukhī inquired, “*Mohan!* [Charming one!] Have you ever seen this treasure which is so carefully hidden?”

I laughed, “Yes I did once, but just a glimpse, like a flash of lightning.”

NāndiMukhī: “When?”

I replied, “One day, as she was getting out of the water at her own lake (Śrī Śrī RādhāKuṇḍ), Śrī Rādhā dropped the fine upper garment from her delicate frame into the water below, since there was no one present. By chance I had come there to pilfer some flowers,* so at that moment I caught a brief glimpse of her wealth of fresh youth. Thereupon, however, she felt some fear in her heart and quickly covered her wealth with the corner of her blue sari. If at present I am so fortunate as to again get a glimpse of that pride of youthful wealth, of the eminent Śrī Rādhā, (who is) desirous of gaining her own kingdom, then I will lay aside the soldiers and commanding officers of my nails and teeth, and, becoming just like her shadow, I will oppress those two golden waterpots with only my two lotus hands, thus grabbing hold of her wealth of youthful freshness. Then this Yūtheśvarī Rādhā will begin to tremble as the hairs of her body stand on end, all due to a sudden outburst of emotion. Thus finally will she have been reduced to the point of speechlessness. Having become terribly anxious about the matter at hand, her sakhīgan will then naturally gather up their own wealth of youth and try to flee to the four directions, but will find no quarter safe. Or possibly,

*Here a very beautiful pun is used, as the name of the flower given is *sumanah*. This renders another meaning, namely that Kṛṣṇa came here not to steal flowers, but to lose his mind, or to become enchanted.

they could simply surrender their own riches to me, that they might be permitted to engage in my pure, unadulterated service. What then is the point in engaging in this wearisome and filthy debate with these boastful, yet insignificant gopīs? only to diminish my own resplendent glory?”

Thereupon Śrī Rādhā smiled as she looked towards NāndīMukhī and softly said, “*Ayi capal brahmacārini!* [Oh you inconstant *brahmacārini!*] Flee! Flee away from here!”

Viśākhā said, “How surprising! This greedy, famished parrot, who is accustomed to eating only the ripened fruits of the bimba tree, is now unable to fly away from here after having tasted the flavour of rare and delectable grapes and raisins, rarely attained by her even within her mind.”

MadhuMaṅgal said to me, “Priyabayasya! Just give me my desired reward and I will assuredly bring this Rādhā, who desires to usurp your kingdom, and deliver her into your hand this very day.”

I replied, “Sakhe MadhuMaṅgal! If you are able to do that then I will certainly feed you some sweet-rice this evening.”

MadhuMaṅgal said, “I will call the king in Mathurā, by giving a loud whistle, to send one hundred of his best soldiers here on horseback. After having bound Abhimanyu’s elbows behind his back, they will then prepare to give him such a beating with their whips that the husband of Rādhā will personally bring her here and offer her to you.”

Everyone laughed heartily to hear this statement of MadhuMaṅgal’s.

Lalitā said, “He Viśākhe! Listen carefully to my petition, which I offer on behalf of a certain noble-minded person.”

Viśākhā: “Please proceed.”

As she looked towards the summit of a Kadamba tree, Lalitā said, “*Bho! Vrindāvanacar tapasvibar!* [Oh best of the ascetics; wanderer (thief) of the forests of Vrindāvan!] You are famous as one who subsists only on fruits. Why then are you prepared to damage your own dignity; to transgress your vows and thus pollute yourself by vainly longing after that which is beyond your qualifications, the wealth (concealed near the heart) of that most unobtainable chaste girl?”

Viśākhā: “Lalite! This ascetic is so hungry, that in the absence of any available fruits he has been induced to do this, in spite of the impropriety of such conduct. Therefore, please show him where he can obtain some excellent fruits. Thus you will also obtain religious merit by rendering service in this way.”

Lalitā restrained her laughter as she said, “Viśākhē! Do you think this ascetic is familiar with MānasīGaṅgā?”

Viśākhā: “Since he has travelled far and wide, I can’t see why he wouldn’t have heard of the celebrated MānasīGaṅgā!”

Lalitā: “In the Northwest corner of MānasīGaṅgā there is a lotus flower (Padma) in full bloom, and in the centre of that flower are two very enchanting and long *tumbi* (a long gourd) fruits. Just in the forefront you will also see two very large, sweet, red *bimbi* fruits.”*

Viśākhā addressed me, “Gosvāmin! [O Master of the senses!] Please proceed there without delay, so that you can enjoy these excellent fruits,[†] just suitable for you. In this way you can renounce your craving for the wealth of this chaste girl, and thus preserve your religious principles and happiness as well.”

*Candrāvali is always in the company of Padmā.

[†]*anuttam-* means excellent as well as inferior

After the laughter had subsided, I replied, “Lalite! This ascetic follows the *ayācak vritti*,^{*} that is, he doesn’t solicit anything from anyone. He eats only as much as will fill his hands[†] and he will not be able to enjoy the *tumbi* gourds because they are a forbidden fruit. However, she who is visible here by her radiant splendour, but who nevertheless continues to conceal herself; this golden creeper carries on it’s bosom two most excellent, juicy, succulent[‡] and sweet bilva fruits, endowed with the most superb shape and loveliness. If this golden creeper will come forward of her own volition and intimately extend an invitation to this ascetic, in her own sweet speech, and serve him those fruits, placing them in his hands, then he is sure to become most happy by enjoying them and will thus bless her with a benediction that her fruits will prosper.”[§]

Rādhā replied softly, “This licentious clown! This cunning cheat has probably come to know that I am present here and is bandying about simply to vex me. Therefore I should now enter another *kuñj* and remain hidden there.”

As Śrī Rādhā was thinking in this way, I addressed Lalitā, “Priyasakhī Lalite! This wanderer of the forests of Vrindāvan, accustomed to a variety of pleasure diversions, wishes to make you, the despondent *yūtheśvarī* of a shattered troop, his Queen-consort, and sit together with you on the *simhāsan* to watch Viśākhā and the other sakhīs give a dance recital. Therefore please give your order for them to begin the dance.”

Lalitā stormed in anger, “NāndīMukhī! Have you forcefully brought us here simply that this buffoon can entertain us with the wealth of his jokes (as payment), instead

^{*}vow of the python

[†]this is the *karāpatra* vow

[‡]*madhur rasa*- ‘sweet juice’ is the name of the erotic sentiment

[§]*unnati*- improve, increase, rise, lift

of paying us the revenue on our pearl fields?! Listen, let's leave this delaying tactic of joking behind us and instead make the proper arrangement, that this ascetic, in the company of Subal, commit himself in writing to the payment of the land tariff. Then you may send us on our way home without further delay!"

NāndiMukhī replied, "What amount have you agreed upon for the payment of this tax? First inform us of that."

Lalitā: "The levy on grain fields is more than that on fields of greens (fodder); and the levy on cotton fields is more than that of grains. The assessment on land for dwellings (residential) is more than that of cotton, and the tax on lands used for growing pearls, owing to the fact that the pearls are themselves priceless objects, must necessarily be a few hundred, thousand billion times more. Therefore Subal should procure a supernatural rod to measure the supra-mundane boundary of these pearl fields, since it is stated in the scriptures that the kingdom of Vrindāvan is supremely extra-mundane (not of this world).^{*} These measurements he can write down in his notebook and then announce his findings to us.

NāndiMukhī: "What size should this measuring rod be?"

Lalitā: "Who will believe what I say? It is better that the protectress of these fields, who is educated in all the scriptures, namely VrindāDevī, ascertain the proper measurement of such a rod."

NāndiMukhī: "Very well, Vrinde! You should arbitrate in this matter, by fixing the size of this measuring rod."

VrindāDevī replied, "It is said that,

‘Dwelling lands, grain fields, pastures of millet
and other fodder,

^{*}Thus it requires a rod of similar nature to measure that which is immeasurable.

cotton fields and pearl fields are all measured,
first beginning with the thumb,
and then proceeding successively with all the five fingers.

Then again, however, in another scripture we find:

‘Scholars say that since the taxes exacted
from pearl fields are so exorbitant,
they are usually measured with the ring finger.’”

NāndīMukhī said, “Of these two methods of measurement,
which is the more applicable in this situation?”

Lalitā: “Since only a small hand sickle may be used to
plow the fields suitable for producing such invaluable crops,
in this instance, measurement should be taken with the little
finger.”

NāndīMukhī: “Lalite! Although this is applicable to
be sure, still, as the maidservant of Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī,
I request you, that while looking us (myself and the Son of
the King of Vraja as well) in the face, you settle with the ring
finger.”

Lalitā said, “Vrinde! You are expert at writing and taking
measurements! Therefore, let’s all go to the pearl fields and take
their proper measurement, with the consent of NāndīMukhī
and Subal of course.”

NāndīMukhī: “Kṣṇuṇṇayutheśvari! [Oh you who have
lost your leader! Substitute leader of the flock!] I would like
to make one request.”

Lalitā: “If whatever you desire seems suitable, then it
must certainly be fulfilled.”

NāndīMukhī: “This young visitor, after leaving the land
of his home, has come here to our province to seek shelter
of the Queen of Vrindāvan. Here he has cultivated the fallow
earth with great care and effort, sufficiently increasing your
wealth. Now if you insist on this measurement business,

then you will suffer great loss due to inattentive care of the crops and the expense of arranging meals for this period of time. Not only that, but this individual will still be unable to pay you the tariff if you engage him in the hard labour of all this measuring.* Therefore you should reject this idea of measuring the fields. Instead, accept your portion of the harvest, and, in presenting to him his proper share, give him the encouragement he deserves.”

Vrindā inquired, “What then is to be our share?”

NāndīMukhī: “Don’t you know? As level (*saman*) as is this brilliant field, the two shares should also be (*saman*) equal, since this person has come here to farm from another village.”

Raṅgaṇamāla meekly offered, “He is not a farmer from another village. At present he resides here in this forest and cultivates this land for Śrī Vrindāvaneśvarī. Therefore he is entitled to only one sixth of the harvest. Why should he receive an equal share?”

Viśākhā: “*Ayi Mugdhe!* [Silly girl!] What use is it to us to try to determine the division of shares by our own direction, when we have already received the written order of the Queen, that the revenue is to be paid in accordance with the size of the land? How will we be able to determine this in our own independent fashion?”

Thereupon Vrindā, while looking towards Lalitā and Viśākhā, showed NāndīMukhī her earring, glancing at her from the corner of her eyes.

*The pun is this: *mān* can mean measurement, or also anger, thus: “If you insist on being angry, then you will suffer a great loss in enjoyment at the expense of your anger.” Since *kar* means hand, as well as tax: “He will still be unable to put his hands on you, if you keep up this anger.” ‘Arrangements for eating’ (*bhogarāgādi*) can also be taken to mean ‘sensual enjoyment’.

NāndīMukhī smiled as she moved slightly forward, indicating by some token gesture to Lalitā and Viśākhā, that she had understood Vrindā's hint about offering a bribe. As she approached me she said in a soft whisper, "He Mohan! This Lalitā and Viśākhā are the chief executive ministers for the Queen of Vrindāvan. Therefore, if you give them some excellent gifts, they will immediately bring about the accomplishment of that which is desired by you."

I joyfully replied, "Sakhī NāndīMukhī! Secretly bring Lalitā and Viśākhā to a solitary *kuñj* without anyone else's knowledge, so that I can satisfy them by giving them their desired bribes."

NāndīMukhī: "*Sundar!* The other beautiful Vraja gopīs are inseparable and non-different from Lalitā and Viśākhā. Don't be shy; you can publicly present your bribes to them right here."

I replied, "Without having gotten what I want, how will I at first give anything away in charity? If I am not trusted then I will place my bribe with you."

NāndīMukhī shook her head as she said, "Na! Na!"

I said, "Ah! [Alas! Too bad!] I understand. Since you are a brahmacāriṇī you may become contaminated by the touch of any worldly affairs. In that case I should offer my bribe to the dear object of my affection (who I trust, and who trusts me), the best among chaste girls, RaṅgaṇMālikā."

NāndīMukhī: "*He Rasiksekhora!* [Oh topmost of the connoisseurs of rasa!] First of all you should tell me what you are prepared to give for a bribe and in how much quantity. Whether or not Lalitā and Viśākhā will be satisfied with that, I will have to determine beforehand."

I replied, "Very well. Just listen. I am the King of Vrindāvan. Now this Vrindā has abandoned her service as custodian of

my forest of Vrindāvan and out of cupidity devoted herself to my Queen, Śrī Rādhārāṇī. Therefore, my first bribe will be to bring this clerk (*kāyastha*) Vrindā under my control.*

NāndīMukhī: “Excellent!”

I continued, “The locket that was made by the primal preceptor of the art of fashioning enchanting dresses and decorations, Gāndharvā [Śrī Rādhā], which she placed on the sky of my heart (my chest) at the end of that night, overwhelmed as she was by profound feelings of passionate affection, this most exceptional and unparalleled king of all lockets, in the shape of a half-moon, I will now place around the neck of Lalitā, with my own hand. Then, more refulgent than my own Kaustubha maṇi, and on an equal par with that locket, is my *cumbakmaṇi* (magnetic jewel), which, as a token of our mutually sincere affection, expressed so eagerly and with great curiosity that day at the feet of the Bakul trees, I had exchanged with Gāndharvā for her own *cumbak mahāratna* (magnetic gem), more valuable than my own, itself the personified form of the condensed cream produced from churning the ocean of unprecedented mellows. Though it be her unrivalled favourite, I will also give the same to Lalitā, that she might use it to adorn her lovely ear (temple).”

As I glanced repeatedly at the charming face of Viśākhā, I continued with a smile, “Their *priyasakhī* Gāndharvā, continuously filled with the most devoted attachment, constructed with her own hands the most exquisite necklace, which she presented to me with great finesse, in the courtyard near her own kuṇḍ (RādhāKuṇḍ). With this very necklace, I wish to decorate the constellation of the sky of my heart, Viśākhā, in the hope of pleasing her.”

*Kāyastha indicates a particular caste, but can also mean, *situated on the body*, thus: “My first bribe will be to bring this Vrindā under my control and situate her on my body.”

Having heard all of this, Śrī Rādhā spoke to me from within her mind, “*AlīkRajendra!* [Stop it! You king of perversity!] *Tiṣṭha! Tiṣṭha!* [Stop!]” Chastising me with words such as this she began to beat me (still within her mind) with the toy lotus that she held in her hand .

Lalitā said, “Having drunk the opium of Padmā’s lips you have now become poisoned and must surely go mad! Get thee hence! Get thee hence!”

Viśākhā: “*Ārya vidūṣak pravara MadhuMaṅgal!* [Oh best of the jesters!] Is your dear friend here your guru, or are you his guru? We are all very curious about this.”

Lalitā: “Viśākhe! I can tell you. Just listen. In the drama of deceit, the dancer of the name, Kusumaśara,* has, as his jester, he who is called Śuci.† This jester has very kindly bestowed his compassion on this cunning cheat (Kṛṣṇa), by accepting him as his disciple. MadhuMaṅgal however, is the celebrated disciple of the primal preceptor of all jesters, BhojanLampaṭ (lascivious eater) by name, who comes from a different tradition (*sampradāya*).”

Viśākhā: “Lalite! Therefore I should like to feed this brāhmaṇa some sweet-rice.”

Lalitā: “He is very competent and learned in all the six branches of Vedic wisdom including practice, ceremonial rites and grammar; thus is he a *Mahābrāhmaṇa*.‡ Therefore, how can he eat food cooked by us simple cowherds, who are inferior to brāhmaṇas?”

Viśākhā replied, “In that case, your desire will have to be accomplished by those two super excellent *dvijas*, Mallī and

*flower arrow- *puṣpaban*; an epithet for Cupid

†Śrīṅgar *ras*- the ‘pure’ mellow of conjugal love

‡great brāhmaṇa; A pun here can also mean- fallen brāhmaṇa

Bhṛṅgī.* They can cook for him and then very reverently serve him those foodstuffs.”

MadhuMaṅgal started to tremble with anger as he replied to their sarcastic remarks, “*Ore akathya bhāṣini!* [Soho! O thou of filthy and abusive language!] *Garbitā goyālini!* [Puffed-up milkmaid!] Your derisive mockery, unworthy of my audition, is like an acutely pungent, bitter and salty, stale *roṭi* [piece of bread; *chāpāti*], half-cooked on the inside and burnt on the outside, intended to offend my agreeable ears; what to speak of my mouth! All I have to say is that I am not going to ever even touch the ground which is so much as near the place where the shadow has fallen from such buffoons as you cowherd girls. Rather, tomorrow morning I will go to pay a visit to the wives of the *yajnika brāhmaṇas* [sacrificial *brāhmaṇas*]⁷⁹ who are members of my own caste. There, immediately upon my arrival, they will very respectfully bathe my feet and then dress me with fine, silken garments. After giving me a nice sweet sherbet scented with camphor, they will serve me with the finest sweet-rice, and then a big pile of the most fragrant *sali* rice, flavoured with sufficient ghee, ginger, sea salt and lemon, and surrounded by a vast variety of vegetable preparations. Then will come puffy balls of sugar [*feni bātāsha*], puddings and cakes made with *gur* [jaggery], jilepi, laddu, condensed milk, sweet yoghurt, fried cakes and drinks made with buttermilk, sugar and spices, all served with such loving attention, that when I finally make it outside to the path, I will collapse in the shade of the first big tree I see. After a nice little nap there I will come home and go back to sleep until 8 o’clock.”

*Since Malli and Bhṛṅgī, Śrī Rādhā’s *ban sakhis* [forest friends], are members of the aboriginal caste, the meaning of *paramottam dvija* must be taken as, ‘those who have very pretty rows of teeth.’

⁷⁹ The *yajnika-brāhmaṇas*, their wives and the feeding of Kṛṣṇa and his friends are described in *BhP* x.23. Jiva Gosvāmin has taken advantage of MadhuMaṅgala’s character to describe the feast presented by these women in an amusing fashion (*GopalaCampu*, i.22.54-9).

During a lull in the tumultuous laughter that followed I said, “NāndīMukhī! The rustic inhabitants of a tiny village, when engaged in a dispute with some opposing party over land boundaries, take the help of an arbiter to reach some compromise, and this is of course all very equitable and conformable to the principles of justice, etc. However, kings acquire territory by the strength of their arms. Therefore, what is the use of following just and equitable principles as regards this kingdom of Vrindāvan? Rather, anyone desirous of this kingdom will now have to fight me. Whoever wins the battle; well then, Vrindāvan will be theirs.”*

So speaking, I very arrogantly advanced forward, ready to do battle. At this, the Vrajasundarigan became a bit frightened and began to move hither and thither, preparing to flee, but all the while maintaining an air of seeming indifference.

At this point NāndīMukhī addressed me, “*Vir!* [Oh Hero!] It would be terribly improper of you to try to forcibly attack these wanton wives of the illustrious cowherds [*gopbadhu*], now, and in my presence.⁸⁰ Now just listen to what I am saying and try to understand; and having done so, keep your distance!”

Then she addressed Lalitā, “Just now this valiant champion of the forest is feeling very powerful in this solitary and lonely place, whereas your bodies are as soft and delicate as a Śirīṣa flower. In light of the present time, circumstances and relative strengths (*deśa, kāl & bal*), I think it would be wise of you to abandon this dispute.”

ChandraMukhī said, “*He Mugdhagan!* [Oh bewildered ones!] NāndīMukhī is correct, and for this reason, namely, that we are members of the fairer sex and of soft and tender

*The word for defeat can also mean, ‘to enjoy with’.

⁸⁰ The word for ‘attack’ (*dharsan*) can also mean ‘to rape’. *Param asāmpratam* can also be read *parama-sāmpratam* which would give the opposite meaning, i.e., ‘most proper’.

limbs. In contrast, this individual is a solitary forest dweller and therefore very agile, moreover impulsive. Now, in the presence of our *priyasakhī* Śrīmatī Rādhārāṇī, he does become very docile, frightened and confused, but our Empress is not here now. Meanwhile, the scurrilous Abhimanyu is unaware of these tidings and is therefore away in a distant place with the other colonels. While we are engaged with our domestic quarrel (civil war), in this dreadfully frightful wood, any number of wicked thieves might come here from any direction and quickly run off with all our pearls. In that case we would suffer a heavy loss, whereas he has only his one-sixth part share to worry about. If you all approve, it would probably be best, if, for the time being, we calmly and with serene and tranquil appearance abandon discussions of the kingdom. Instead, we should retrieve all our pearls by paying even slightly more than the going price, if necessary. Better to save ourselves and our good name by safely returning home, than to suffer the calumny that would come upon us if we were so much as touched by this pickpocket, who swoops upon his unsuspecting prey like a hawk.

“Later, when the Queen of Vrindāvan (Rādhārāṇī) subsequently hears the narration of these events from us, she will, no doubt, after having first satisfied our guardians by returning to them all of the missing pearls, fly to this spot in a great rage. Rather than directly engage herself in battle, she will stand at some distance, posturing as an entire military camp, and from there release with her arched eyebrows, like two powerful bows, a volley of deadly, sharpened arrows, issuing forth with tremendous velocity from the corners of her restless eyes, her lotus face having thus gradually assumed such a fierce visage. Then, this person will feel that Abhimanyu, the Horrible, has himself arrived, accompanied by a vast battalion.*

*Rather than engage herself in battle, she will engage her army, made up of the terrible Abhimanyu and others, to fight for her. *Abhimanyu* refers to her fierce visage and his companions are the arrows shot from her eyebrows.

“Then, right in the middle of this forest, this respected and courageous hero will begin to so tremble in fear that he will have no other recourse than to seek shelter at the lotus feet of Śrī Rādhārāṇī. Taking from his neck the lovely necklace made of the Cintāmaṇi gems of his pleas for mercy, his obsequious and sycophantic flattery, studded with the rubies of his loud cries of distress, he will offer to her as a symbol of surrender. Placing his offerings at her feet, the utterances of his heart, choked with emotion, will act like direct sunlight on the butter-soft heart of Śrī Rādhā, who under the influence of her own unlimited compassion will become favourable towards him once again. With the *jāvak* [red dye] from her lotus feet, like a softened dawn-coloured gem, he will then fashion an ornament for his head. And finally, surrendering all of the remaining pearls produced in this kingdom, he will also become her attendant companion.”

I thrilled with delight to hear this wonderful description of such a lovely scene and continued laughing as I looked askance towards the *kuñj* where Rādhā was seated.

NāndīMukhī laughed, “*He Gokul Pravir!* [Oh brave hero of Gokul!] This Empress of Vrindāvan, Śrī Rādhā, an experienced fighter in Cupid’s combats, is just the person to do battle with you in the War of Crooked Arrows.* To see your phalanxes arrayed against hers is truly the most beautiful sight. However, Lalitā and these other gopīs are extremely tender and soft. Therefore, without their Empress to lead them, how will her subjects conduct themselves in such wanton war with you? Therefore abandon this baseless dispute, and at present deal with the matter of determining the respective prices to be paid for these pearls, for all of those present here now. Later on, Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī Devī will decide the case concerning the kingdom.”

*Cupid’s arrows are crooked, or fired at oblique angles

MadhuMaṅgal, having listened to the shrewd and shiftY words of the proud Vraja gopīs, started to shout, “*Jita! Jita!* [Defeated! Defeated! We win!]” as he cupped his left hand to his mouth while continuing to shout, thus producing a sound like the beating of a kettledrum, all the while dancing around in a great frenzy.

VrindāDevī addressed him, “*Bho Natpravar Madhu Maṅgala!* [Hallo you great dancer!] If our Empress Śrī Rādhārāṇī were to arrive here just now, then for her entertainment your dear friend would be beating his drum to a different tune, (such as, “*Hā! Hā!*”) [Alas! Alas!] To that sound and the specific lesson it gives, you can then dance as a six-footed (the better to dance with!) bumblebee and fly away to find your female bumblebee friend so that you can have a wild dance with her, much more ecstatic than the one you are having here now. Then, with your two-footed friend here, you can go off to ‘join the ranks of the incomprehensible followers of Lord Śiva’; or, ‘hide in a cave within a deep, dark forest somewhere.’⁸¹ This would then be the success of our eyes.”

At this I laughed quite loudly as I said, “*NāndīMukhī!* This CandraMukhī is seriously devoted to trying to harmonise the situation here, very much unlike Lalitā and her friends who are happy to escalate the points of contention. Therefore, I would be most pleased to bestow some pearls upon her, in lieu of any charge. Since she is the crest jewel amongst counsellors, learned in a superfluity of mantras, she should, either tomorrow or the next day, come to a secluded and purified place, where, after I have purified myself by the requisite ablutions, she may then initiate me in the mantras from the great ācārya, Kāntadarpa[†]

⁸¹ *Sugahanam Nāndīvara-goṣṭham* has the alternative meaning of ‘a cave of the Nandīvara mountain’. This is given as the secondary sense due to the overtones of Śiva’s characteristics manifest in the frenzied dancing (*tāṇḍava nṛtya*) of MadhuMaṅgala.

[†]lit. aesthetic pride; proud paramour, etc.; This is one of the many names of Cupid.

Though I am just a simple cowherd boy of Vrindāvan, I will thus very swiftly attain opulence surpassing even that of the demigods.”*

CandraMukhī gave me a crooked stare as she said, “How astonishing! Even someone who gives you good counsel, your well-wisher, even me you are prepared to corrupt. I am not the one to initiate you with any mantras. You can engage KāñcanLatā, who is very clever in the use and knowledge of mantras, as your preceptor [ācārya].”

I replied, “Kāñcanalate! Seeing your expertise, the bumblebee of my mind has become very attached to you and possessed of great eagerness. If, in front of all these smiling faces gathered here, you were to affectionately place that gorgeous, nay, worshipful one-stringed necklace that goes round your neck, upon my most eager and impatient chest, then I will, without fail, bestow upon you all of the pearls that you most desire, for free.”† Having said this much, I began to pursue KāñcanLatā, who shot me a crooked, sidelong glance accompanied by a menacing shout, as she moved away. Rādhā laughed, but also felt awed, in apprehension of her own position.

Then Viśākhā snapped her fingers to get the attention of NāndīMukhī and signalled to her with her eyes, indicating RaṅgaṇMālikā and Tulasī.

NāndīMukhī smiled, “*He Mohan!* [Oh enchanting one!] This RaṅgaṇMālikā and Tulasī are very devoted to the lotus feet of Śrī Rādhā and are thus very dear to her. In fact, they

**surādhikā śrī*- beauty greater than that of the demigods; can also mean, ‘the virtuous and beautiful Rādhikā’

†*apr*: “If you were to very affectionately place the beautiful Rādhikā, who happens to be in the vicinity, upon my eager chest, here in front of these smiling gopīs, who are encircling us like a very lovely one-stringed necklace, then, I will also decorate you, from your neck down to your navel, with three enchanting jewelled necklaces in the form of my embraces.”

cannot remain anywhere for hardly a moment without her. Therefore, promptly determine the price for their pearls, and send them off to her.”

Feeling extremely delighted I laughed as I replied, “NāndīMukhī! When I am in a state of total bewilderment, overwhelmed by the combined effect of drinking the flower nectar of RaṅgaṇMālikā’s tender words, never before heard, scented with the camphor of her smiling lips and mixed with the black pepper of her unprecedented, restless glance, then she, overwhelmed with affection, should revive me, by pressing the two buds of her breasts on my chest and giving me the nectar of her lips, the veritable essence of my life.”

As everyone laughed RaṅgaṇMālikā and Tulasī looked down at the ground and went and hid behind Viśākhā.

NāndīMukhī said, “Oh you who so enjoys this playful pastime of carrying on commerce in pearl fruits! [You’re really enjoying all of this aren’t you?] Why is it that you are so inattentive to ascertaining the price for the pearls of Yūtheśvarī, Rādhā and Viśākhā?”

I replied, “If this Yūtheśvarī comes here personally and inquires from me the price for her pearls, then certainly I will determine a price. Otherwise, if she is not present, then why should I?”

NāndīMukhī: “Vīr! [Brave sir!] In her absence first let me know your price, so that after hearing from me she can begin to collect those goods.”

I said, “Owing to the fact that Rādhā and Viśākhā are so intimate, so alike and inseparable, they are extremely dear to me. Therefore, the small price that I am asking, I request you to listen to carefully-

“Around the middle of my back, more beautiful than a Tamāl tree, two soft, golden creepers should entwine

themselves, the right arm of Gāndharvikā and the left arm of Viśākhā. I will then place my two long arms, wanton with joy and anointed with the most fragrant saffron [*kun̄kum*] and sandalwood, around their soft and modestly inclined shoulders. Then, as we stroll through the forest, perceiving it's sweetness scented with the intoxicating redolence of a myriad of flowers, the two of them, their lovely moon-like faces like two artistic dancers, thrill with eager delight as they mutually exchange glances, noting the matchless ornaments of loving emotion that now decorate one another. May they increase my ecstasy by sometimes, simultaneously, or sometimes separately, exhibiting their prowess in dancing, on the stage of my cheeks.⁸²

“In the courtyard of the arbour house on the banks of Rādhā Kuṇḍ, underneath the Bakul trees dripping with flower nectar, and surrounded by busy bumblebees buzzing about, is a golden dais surrounded by an enchanting arrangement of Mallikā flowers. I will sit down there on a heavenly soft bed, with my left elbow resting on a moon-white pillow made from golden jasmine flowers, my two legs folded to the side. The shelter of the bee of my mind, (the jasmine flower) Viśākhā, having become slightly intoxicated by drinking the honey-sweet nectar of her priyasakhī Rādhā's love, sees that the *kun̄kum* decorating the golden caskets of her friend has become slightly moistened, so, taking that liquid ambrosia and mixing it with some of the sweetly scented saffron paste from her own round breasts, she very gently and slowly begins to smear that upon my chest, that is by now thrilling with rapture. The Śarikā [mynah bird] in the cage of my ribs (my heart - Śrī Rādhikā), sometimes from her own breasts, and sometimes from Viśākhā's, takes the fresh musk therefrom, and with the end of a Campak flower blossom, draws pictures

⁸² May they also sometimes glance at me with their dancing faces and decorate my cheeks with the nectar of their lips (kiss them).

of Capricorns and leafy creepers with small flower blossoms on my chest, with it's hairs standing on end. May my body, mind and words, benumbed with astonishment, be perfumed by the lovely fragrance of their unequalled, unrivalled, and intimate friendship.”

Then, as Rādhā's and Viśākhā's eyes met, their bodies were simultaneously thrilling with the ecstasy of affectionate attachment. Yet they felt bashful at the same time.

Viśākhā said, “He Lalite! This lascivious debauch has written a play called *Asombhav Manorath* [Impossible Desire] and wants that we (Rādhā and myself) should accept the parts of two lewd dancers who will act according to his directions. Only that she might be entertained by such a drama, has the aptly named NāndiMukhī* been induced to keep us in this solitary forest as an audience to witness this performance under the false pretext that she will present us with our pearls, but in actuality, simply to harass us that we might be cast in the role of his courtesans. Rather, let those who enjoy such performances sit down here to watch this drama performed by that actor expert in all the sixty-four arts, so that the reputation of the two families (father's and husband's family) of such a chaste girl, can easily attain further eminence. I for one, however, am going home!”

NāndiMukhī said, “Sakhī Viśākhe! Why do you allow yourself to become so distressed and vexed by a few wanton words uttered in jest by this mischievous person? If you stay here for just a few more moments you will, without a doubt, receive your pearls.”

Having dissuaded Viśākhā from going home, NāndiMukhī came to me and said, “*He Durlīl GopaYuvarāj!* [Oh intractable prince of the cowherds!] Taking your unbecoming language to be the most derisive mockery, Viśākhā and the other

*the introductory benedictory stanza of a play is generally called nāndi or nāndimukha

Vrajasundarigan continually blame me. Now I think you should kindly close the cover of the ‘Amusement Almanac’ and now open the pages of the ‘Business Almanac’ (in other words, “Please conclude your mirthful sports and take up the real business at hand, namely, real business (commerce and trade). Just accept some goods in exchange for the pearls, and in this way, without further delay, bring delight to the minds of the soldiers of your dearest, Gāndharvā.”

I replied, “He NāndīMukhī! Even though Śrī Rādhā is always very severe with me, upon the mere mention of her name, my naturally affectionate heart, though maimed by her cruel behaviour, remains in a state of anxious curiosity about anything even slightly related to her. So how does it benefit me to behave with her very dear friends in a harsh fashion? Whatever quantity of the specified value that can be brought here by them within the next two days; that much wealth of gold and silver, ornaments made of the same, *ranga* and *rasa* (colourful pigments, joking, fun, dancing and acting, juice, savoury flavours, sentiments, emotions), and loveable cows that are deposited with me as collateral; that commensurate quantity of pearls they may all accept from me.”

I then remained silent, but after further considering the matter, I continued, “NāndīMukhī! You know that I am always engaged in my most favourite pastime of herding my cows from forest to forest. Therefore, where I will keep so much gold and such, I do not know. I don’t really find anyone that I can trust sufficiently to keep so much gold for me. I am also especially afraid of the embarrassment and infamy involved with keeping the possessions of other’s wives. Therefore I have to honestly say that I don’t see how this exchange can be accomplished, in the absence of some other form of prompt payment.”

NāndīMukhī: “Mohan! I have neither seen nor heard of such an extraordinary price as that which you demand!”

I replied, “*Vidagdhe NāndīMukhī!* [Intelligent NāndīMukhī!] Throughout this universe, what will you see or hear concerning wonderfully uncommon pearls like this, produced from the earth? Thus the price for such remarkable goods should also be something extraordinarily unprecedented. Specifically, I am not a pearl salesman. I have become encouraged to take up this line simply upon the order of Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsīpad, and also, as a result of your zealous eagerness. Therefore, if all of you so desire, once we have settled on a price, that may be paid and then all of these gopīs can take their pearls. Otherwise, let everyone go home. I hope you realise that almost two *prahars* have passed by now (it is almost noon). I will have to take my adorable cows to Govardhan very soon.”

NāndīMukhī appeared visibly distressed to hear this as she approached Lalitā and spoke to her softly, “Sakhī Lalite! Sakhī Viśākhe! Ayi priyasakhīgan! This impulsive and inconsiderate lecher, without receiving the cherished objects of his desire, will not part with any of these pearls. This I have ascertained after making repeated requests to him. Since it has already been decided that these pearls must be retrieved by any means possible, I advise that we adopt the following stratagem-

“First, make him satisfied by consenting to pay the price which he has proffered, and then, after receiving the pearls, everyone can beat a hasty retreat homeward bound! Once we are there, who will be able to take any price from anyone? And who will pay his price anyway?!”

Lalitā: “*Adbhut tapassini!* [What a strange ascetic you are!] *Tiṣṭha! Tiṣṭha!* [Just hold on a second here! Be quiet!]

Having rebuked NāndīMukhī in this way, Lalitā smiled as she addressed me, “*He Dhir!* [Oh most patient one!] *Lalit yuvaraj!* [Most elegant prince!] These wonderful [*apurvo*] fields of Vrindāvan; these uncommon [*apurvo*] pearl seeds;

these extraordinary [apurvo] pearls; this most remarkable [apurvo] pearl merchant; and this unprecedented [apurvo] price that he asks are all from the realm of strange wonder. Yet we are terribly common, nothing out of the ordinary at all. Therefore, how will we ever be able to pay this peculiar price? However, this NāndīMukhī is uncommonly affectionate towards us, and is also non-different from us. Now since you are an exceptional brahmacārin, and she is likewise an extraordinary brahmacāriṇī, by the power of her penance she will present you with your chosen price, and having thus satisfied you, she will accept the pearls in exchange. We however, are all going home!”

With such loving malice, these beauties of Vraja, possessed of diverse emotional sentiments, seemed to make the air tremble with enraptured exultation, as they bent their heads to the side, preparing to make their exit. After collecting Śrī Rādhā from the *kuñj* and placing her in the forefront, she whose transcendental form was also exhibiting a variety of ecstatic emotions, they cast their glances askance at me, smiling and tittering all the while, as they proceeded towards a temple in the midst of a most pleasant grove of Bakul trees, on the banks of Śrī RādhāKuṇḍ.

Thereupon, I very happily gathered up all of those pretty pearls, and taking the very best ones, fashioned with the artistic skill of my own hands, a variety of exquisite ornaments and jewellery for the lovely limbs of Śrī Rādhā. These I placed in a golden box which was then embellished on top by the auspicious letters of her name. I did the same for Lalitā, Viśākhā and the other sakhīs, each with her name on the outside of her respective box. Many unstrung pearls of the most excellent quality I then dispatched to the *kuñj* mandir, by the side of Rādhā Kuṇḍ, with NāndīMukhī, MadhuMaṅgal, Subal, and also Ujjval, Vasanta, Kokil and the other *narmasakhās*, who had just arrived on the scene.

These were very jubilantly received by the smiling Rādhā, Lalitā, Viśākhā and the other sakhīs, all laughing in ecstasy to celebrate the joyous occasion. MadhuMaṅgal was then very affectionately served with a large quantity of delicious cooked food and a packet of tāmbūl, while Subal and the others were satisfied with presents of scents, sandalwood and tāmbūl, as tokens of the sakhīs' loving affection. Fresh flower garlands prepared by their own hands from a variety of golden jasmine flowers, so sweetly scented and soft to the touch, the colour of the early morning dawn, plus packets of tāmbūl scented with camphor, were also sent along with them to be given to me. Under the influence of their love, I felt overjoyed as I decorated myself with those flower garlands, and enjoyed the tāmbūl. Then, in the company of my friends I set off for Govardhan, to pasture my cows.

As Lalitā unfastened the little golden chest with Rādhā's name on it and delightfully decorated her transcendental form, Śrī Rādhā was overjoyed to see those beautiful pearl ornaments. Thereafter, Lalitā, Viśākhā and the other sakhīs all decorated one another with the jewellery that I had made for them.

Later, when they all arrived at their respective homes, they presented this abundance of exquisite ornaments to their husbands and elders, thus satisfying them to their heart's content. Then they returned to RādhāKunḍ to meet their Priyasakhī, with whom they passed the afternoon in the amusing diversion of remembering all the sweet words I had spoken to them in jest.

Satyabhāmā inquired, "*He Gokul vilāsārām matta kokil!* [Oh cuckoo of Gokul, intoxicated with delight while sporting in your pleasure garden!] Then? What happened next?!"

Kṛṣṇa replied, "Priye! Thus far you have heard the pleasure pastimes of Gokul. In the future you will also, no doubt, be able

to hear more. Therefore, what is the necessity of my narrating anything further just now?"

So saying, Śrī Kṛṣṇa, in having uncovered the memory of the merriment of those sweet and secret dalliances, became very impatient due to eager perplexity and began to lament as follows-

“She who is the captivating golden necklace,
set with sparkling jewels,
that goes round my neck;
Who is my two glittering earrings; and
Who is the veritable form of the sandalwood
and saffron smeared on my body.
Hai! [Oh my! Alas!]
When will Sarvādhikā Śrī Rādhikā (she who
surpasses all others),
by the strength of my insignificant pious merit,
be visible before me once again?!”

After remaining silent for some time, he again fervently cried out,

“Aha! She who is the Campak flower garland
resting on my chest;
Who moistens my lotus eyes with ambrosia;
Whose bodily beauty is the one and only place
of my pleasure pastimes,
the playground reserved for me alone;
the form of my most cherished and wished-for
wealth;
the tender creeper upon which the bird of my life (my
heart) is perched;
and the only medicine to sustain my existence.
Hai! Hai! [Oh me! Oh my!] How much longer,
before I again find her?!”

Lamenting in this way with tears streaming from his eyes, Śrī Kṛṣṇa became completely overwhelmed while remembering his Vrindāvan pastimes, and fell down on the earth. As the weeping MadhuMaṅgal came to his rescue, he embraced him and again called out, “PrāṇVallabhe! [Satyabhāmā!] You

please become Śrī Rādhā, the only medicine that can save me now!” his body trembling and his voice faltering, he embraced Satyabhāmā while his chest repeatedly heaved with loud, long and hot sighs.

Satyabhāmā who was herself drenched with tears, her bodily hairs standing on end, very reverently began to fan him with the end of her sari until he became quieted.

Having heard the narration of this story from the disciple of Paurṇamāsī Devī (Samañjasā by name), Lakṣmaṇā, her own bodily hairs standing on end, very eagerly yet sorrowfully inquired, “Sakhī Samañjase! Then? Then what happened?!”

Samañjasā replied, “After remaining respectfully quiet for sometime, Satyabhāmā finally said,-

“He Prāṇanāth! Oh you who are the one and only life of the residents of Vraja [Vrajajan]! All glories to you! All glories to you! [Joy hauk! Joy hauk!] Please be patient! Be comforted.”

Calling to him in this way, she continued to quietly fan him while gently stroking his body. Finally, she requested him that they proceed to Gokul, and in this way gradually brought her Prāṇanāth back, not only to consciousness, but to a happy frame of mind.

Satyabhāmā considered the ocean of nectar of her own unlimited happiness, and her own offspring and family to be no more than blades of grass, thus she could very easily disregard these things, keeping them at some distance. She considered her only and continuous desire to be non-different from even a drop of the happiness of Śrī Kṛṣṇa. She considered the lotus feet of Śrī Kṛṣṇa to be her only refuge.

Thus thinking that her Prāṇanāth would regain his composure after going to Vraja and having *darshan* of Śrīmatī Rādhikā, she therefore tried to instigate him to go there. She sent a sakhī to call Śrīyukta Uddhava Mahāśaya, the respected minister.

Upon arrival, Uddhavaji ascertained that the day after tomorrow (Thursday), the day of Brihaspati (guru of the demigods), the tenth day of the bright fortnight, during the presence of the constellation Dhanīṣṭha, at noon (the *abhijit muhurta* endowed with specific qualities and precipitating auspiciousness), would be the most favourable time for Śrī Kṛṣṇa to depart for Gokul.

On that day at the appointed time, after completing a repast of yogurt, rice and other items suitable for consumption before making a journey, Śrī Śrīman VrajaJuarāj Śrī Kṛṣṇa prepared to set out for his homeland, to the accompaniment of, and preceded by panegyric hymns and eulogies, invoking auspiciousness and making the way safe and free from impediments from any direction, soliciting the decrees of fate that the accomplishment of their entrance into Gokul would bring fame and good fortune on the families of all those concerned. Though His elder brother, *pūjyapaḍ* Śrīmadagraja Mahānubhava, Śrī Balarām, was very anxious to accompany them to Vraja, he was humbly entreated to remain as the guardian of Dvārakāpurī.

Then, taking Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī in the front, and with Uddhava, Īśvarī Rohiṇī, and he who is endowed with all auspiciousness, MadhuMaṅgal, they all made a quick departure, carried swiftly away by the handsome chariot named Nandighosh. As they reached the outer boundaries of Śrī Gokul it was decided, with the assent of all those present, that they should don their favourite and eternally desired apparel, appropriate to their station as cowherds [*gop jāti*], and in this way make a colourful and exuberant entrance into their beautiful village.

Having drunk with her two ears the incomparable nectar of this news, distributed so magnanimously by Samāñjasā, the most fortunate and resplendent Lakṣmaṇā, comparable to the crest jewel of the mañjarīs, Satyabhāmā herself, and endowed with hundreds and thousands of excellent qualities, the sum total of all the wonderful qualities of all the Queens

in Dvārakā, finding herself drowning in an ocean of ecstasy, exclaimed with fervour, “Sakhī Samañjase! Having heard this most delicious discourse I have become excessively anxious. Therefore, my only wish is that a hint of that indescribably sweet fragrance, the intimacy that Śrī Rādhā shared with Śrī Yādavendra that day when she came to meet him in the pasture lands of Vrajarāj Nanda, might be wafted my way, thus perfuming my own existence.”

Samañjasā replied, “Sakhī Lakṣmaṇe! Your desire will be fulfilled in every way; even to excess; beyond expectation!”

Concluding Prayers

With bunches of straw in my teeth I pray again and again that I might repeatedly take birth as a particle of dust at the lotus feet (PādaPadma) of Śrīla Rūpa Gosvami. I have been incited and excited by his nectarean direction, to prepare this bouquet of flowers called Mukta Carit. Only by his teaching has this become possible.

My living body is known as Jīva [I live through his (Jīva Gosvami's) body, whereas my own is already dead]. His eyes, like greedy bumblebees, are always eager to find the Mādhava creeper of Kṛṣṇa's pastimes, and it is the fragrant pollen he has left here that decorates and perfumes this bouquet [Mukta Carit].

By this bouquet of flowers [Mukta Carit] that has somehow or other been astonishingly arranged by me, may the followers of Śrī Rūpa Gosvami decorate their ears, and in so doing, shower some of their affection on me.

Life after life, may I obtain here in Vraja, the association of Kṛṣṇa dāsa Kavirāja, on the strength of which I was able to make known this most wonderful story about a superior type of pearl.

*Thus ends the Mukta Caritram
by Śrīpad Raghunāth dāsa Gosvāmī*